

“With scholarly attention now focused on digital platforms, we find a reprise of the old structure-agency debate: To what extent are social effects due to the platforms and to what extent to what people do with them. From the beginning, Mark Carrigan has been a leading scholar helping us navigate our way through the digital age. Now with this important new book, he addresses a central question lurking in all the talk about platformization”.

Professor Douglas V. Porpora, *Drexel University, USA*



Platform and Agency

This book examines how digital platforms are reconfiguring the parameters of agency and reflexivity in contemporary social life. Drawing on Margaret Archer's social realist framework, it moves beyond treating platforms merely as tools or environments to conceptualise them as distinct sociotechnical structures with emergent properties and powers that shape human action without determining it.

The book develops the concept of platform and agency to explore the temporal dimensions of sociotechnical change, tracing how platforms condition personal and collective reflexivity through mechanisms of distraction, cultural abundance and multiplying communication channels. While affirming the analytical distinction between structure, culture and agency, it demonstrates how platforms constitute a fourth dimension necessary for understanding contemporary social morphogenesis. Through the conceptual pairing of psychobiography and personal morphogenesis, the book offers a nuanced account of how individuals become who they are within platformised life worlds. Rather than announcing an epochal break with previous social forms, the analysis illuminates the accumulating consequences of platform mediation across biographical timescales.

This book will interest researchers and graduate students in social theory, philosophy of technology, digital sociology, platform studies, media and communication studies, critical data studies, internet studies, surveillance studies, sociology of knowledge, digital anthropology and social informatics.

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Becoming Who We Are

Mark Carrigan

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For Maggie. A teacher, mentor and friend.



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- Carrigan, M. (2018). 'The evisceration of the human under digital capitalism'. In I. Al-Amoudi, and J. Morgan (Eds.), *Realist responses to post-human society: Ex machina* (pp. 165–181). Routledge.
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Section One

The Ontology of Agency



1 What Does It Mean to Live in a Digital Age?

We live in a digital age. That statement can feel platitudinous, yet it expresses a defining feature of our contemporary world: an era shaped by digital technology, from smartphones and tablets to the consumer-facing internet. While the term “digital age” can obscure the variety of lived experience across different contexts, it also insists upon a horizon of change that exceeds immediate empirical observation. It implies a meta-process that will be difficult to characterise without oversimplifying the empirical complexity which ultimately defines it (Archer 2013). We can point to the rapid expansion of internet access across the global population, the diffusion of smartphones as primary devices, or the rise of social platforms that now dominate what “the internet” means in everyday life. The danger in talking about a “digital age” is that it can obscure the fact that global internet access remains deeply uneven, with many still lacking reliable connectivity. The range of what “the internet” means can too easily be subsumed into epochal generalisations about digital change. However, if we avoid terms like “digital age” we risk failing to grasp an emerging reality which surpasses any single trend. Once you insist on a certain degree of empirical robustness, it becomes difficult to keep hold of the meta-process.

The starting point for this project is that such a meta-process is unfolding, which we urgently need to grasp but that doing so is an epistemically complex undertaking. These are not isolated or easily quantified phenomena, but rather a qualitative shift in the parameters of social life (Couldry 2024). There is a change in the texture of the social which is widely felt, yet difficult to pin down in a robust or comprehensive way. Nearly three decades ago, Castells (1996: 508) noted the “unseen logic of the meta-network where value is produced, cultural codes are created, and power is decided”, suggesting that this “increasingly appears to most people as meta-social disorder”. It is this “meta” level that we evoke by talking about a “digital age”, imprecise as that term may be. Only at this higher level can we address how the “parameters of social life – of social interaction and even of socialisation” have begun to shift, rather than confining ourselves to discrete new forms of interaction (Couldry 2024: loc 1174). Otherwise, we are left with “the detection of empirical patterns” in which social transformation is inferred when a pattern is “big and bold enough”. These are by their nature *perspectival* claims, even when methodologically

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robust in their statistics, relying on “striking” observations which produce an intuitive sense of transformation in the analyst (Archer 2013: 3–5).

Platitudes proliferate precisely because they express a sense that something fundamental is changing in the nature of social experience. In this sense, empiricist accounts of social change are proceeding from the platitudes which we find circulating within the social world. Consider, for example, the growing tendency to see algorithms as orchestrating social and political life from the shadows, rendering manipulation ubiquitous yet the manipulators elusive (Bucher 2018; Carrigan and Sylvia 2022). The manner in which algorithms figure in routine social life is indeed “striking”, in the sense which Archer (2013) critiques as easily lending itself to impressionistic analysis. This is not to deny that algorithms should be central to our accounts of how power is exercised, but to recognise, as Bogost (2015) argues, that “Concepts like ‘algorithm’ have become sloppy shorthands” for complex sociotechnical systems (Seaver 2017). Such systems operate in distributed and often invisible ways, transforming our existence in ways we sense acutely but cannot fully pinpoint. We might seek to quantify the role of algorithms within the lifeworld, in order to give methodological weight to the claim that life is now algorithmically mediated. But before we rush in that direction, we should perhaps linger with the underlying intuition which made the initial observation so striking. Platitudes which circulate widely reflects attempts to come to terms with transformations with uncertain origins and outcomes.

If you search for the exact phrase “we live in a digital age”, you’ll find diverse sources yet clearly commonalities emerge. Communication has a new immediacy, an overwhelming quantity of information is accessible anywhere, and many of us live through the affordances of smartphones. New opportunities abound for those who can seize them, while emerging dangers lie in wait for those unprepared. The quality of our co-present interaction is being changed by the ubiquity of the portable computers the majority of the population now carry with them at all times. Though these observations may sound banal, they reflect a pervasive everyday reality. The real analytical challenge is to recover how such ubiquitous shifts shape lived experience, how we might grasp their underlying truth without reducing them to lazy generality. While invocations of a new age “vary considerably in their reliance upon actual empirical findings ... all make some use of them” because “[w]hat they share is the logic of empiricism, a search for patterns of associations, whether metrified or not” (Archer 2013: 6). If we rush straight from a striking observation (e.g. how frequently we encounter algorithmic intermediaries in everyday life) to mapping the apparent pattern, we fail to examine the reality (or lack thereof) underlying our perspective. It is not a problem to *start* with platitudes, only to remain with them.

These platitudes rest on countless specific moments in lived experience, often best seen in contrast to what came before. For example, novelist Anne Lamott (1994: 148–150) describes her quest to find the correct term for the “wire thing” securing a champagne cork. She called a winery, waited on hold, and discovered that even the receptionist only knew it as the “wire thing”.

Finally, an expert revealed that it's called "the wire hood". The pleasure in this discovery was shared: people were genuinely pleased to learn something they'd wondered about, and Lamott gained the precise word for her scene. Elements of this story are timeless: the satisfaction of answering a question and sharing that knowledge. Yet the persistence Lamott demonstrated can feel foreign to those of us whose intellectual curiosity formed alongside the consumer internet. Where my grandparents pulled an encyclopaedia down from the shelf when I presented them with a question, I could from my teens onwards simply type "wire thing on champagne bottle" into Google. In fact I instinctively did this when reading Lamott's (1994) story for the first time, discovering it's in fact called a *museler*, from the French *museler*, meaning "to muzzle". It would be simplistic to suggest that Wikipedia is right and the winery was wrong, but I couldn't shake the feeling I'd found a better answer to the question.

This instant capacity to find factual answers now feels mundane. Yet until recently, satisfying everyday curiosity could be time-consuming enough that many questions remained unanswered. The image of my grandparents physically taking down reference books has occurred to me a lot during this project. It was a ritual that made inquiry tangible. But if an encyclopaedia had no answer, the query often ended there. I don't recall us ever visiting the library to answer a fleeting question, even if that was the logical next step. Today, we may not delve further than a Wikipedia page, yet the scope and scale of immediately accessible knowledge has grown exponentially. There's vastly more information at our fingertips than ever existed on my grandparents' reference shelf.

What makes Lamott's anecdote striking is the sheer time and interpersonal effort for such a trivial question. In a world where answers are immediately retrievable on devices we carry everywhere, that kind of intellectual persistence is less common. These instant answers aren't always correct but they are unquestionably ready-to-hand. In this sense, we have fewer occasions to practice the virtue of persistence on mundane queries, though we may find other virtues, like broad curiosity enabled by easy access to vast knowledge. The risk in making such claims is that we fall into what Taylor (2007) calls "subtraction stories": narratives of decline suggesting we have lost some essential human capacity. These can be found frequently in panicked discourse about the loss of social skills or the capacity for attention, even though aspects of these claims might reliably map onto real changes which are underway. The point is not that we never lose anything, but rather to recognise the narrative temptation involved in stories of human decline.

A more nuanced picture emerges if we attend to the microsocial complexity of these shifts, staying close to the empirical specificity of every change. Such experiences often fade into the background unless a device breaks or a connection fails. Only then do we notice how thoroughly digital systems underpin our expectations, when the routines formed around them suddenly fail in action (Marres 2016; Stiegler 2019). Consider the 1993 film *Six Degrees of Separation*: a con artist's claim to be Sidney Poitier's son eventually unravels when the protagonists consult a physical biography in a bookstore. The narrative rests upon the

impossibility of immediately verifying his claim, even if there are mounting reasons to be suspicious. In 2025, a smartphone and a quick Wikipedia search would instantly reveal the scam, given that Poitier had no son, changing the entire narrative arc. This illustrates how our sociotechnical environment shapes the horizons of our interaction, as well as how taken for granted the ensuing constraints and enablements will seem to us at any particular moment. My grandparent's reference shelf defined the horizon of my factual universe as a child, whereas now it's Wikipedia, at least for those matters outside my academic training. Over the coming years, we are likely to see large language models (LLMs) assume this role given their capacity to offer confident and plausible answers to *any* question.

Not only have the costs of finding answers shrunk to near zero but also the range of questions addressable in this manner continues to widen significantly. LLMs like ChatGPT and Claude can parse complex inquiries with a speed unimaginable just a few years ago. What would ChatGPT have said about the conman at the door claiming to be Sidney Poitier's son? There's no need to wonder what Lamott's "wire thing" is called because we can immediately find an answer, much as with any other question which might occur to us in our daily life. The corresponding risk is that we remain on the surface, drifting in wider but shallower circles of curiosity. I suspect anyone reading this book will have experienced being lost in a Wikipedia rabbit hole, only to realise later how little they can recall of a topic which seemed gripping at the time. If instant answers become the norm, do we lose the motivation to persist when complexity resists quick solutions? If we instinctively trace connections between bodies of knowledge, does that leave us with a more shallow understanding of any specific topic? There's a vast universe of possibilities opened up by the immediacy with which what Archer (1988) calls the cultural system is now mediated within the lifeworld. It is all there, immediately, whenever we want. In quotidian experience, everything seems at hand, even if structurally the reality is more nuanced. Our relationship to knowledge, to culture more broadly, continues to be transformed as LLMs build upon affordances of the open web in complex and often problematic ways (Carrigan 2024).

This is not a book about curiosity. Rather Lamott's story is one among countless instances illustrating how everyday experiences are caught up in relentless sociotechnical change. These changes are unevenly distributed (as William Gibson famously noted), but after the pandemic accelerated digitalisation (even if only for a bare majority globally) it is harder to dismiss them as mere generational or subcultural phenomena. What might have once been a "sociology of the digital", referring to a specific domain, necessarily becomes a "digital sociology" in the sense of no domain which is insulated from these changes (Lupton 2014). The tendency to "domain" these changes, to use Bacevic's (2023) concept, restricts them to a specific epistemic domain in a way which implicitly denies their significance. If they are specialised matters to be studied only by sociologists of the digital, we don't have to consider their implications for our core sociological categories (Lupton 2014; Selwyn 2019). Yet at what point does the accumulation of digital transformation across social domains become so pervasive as to reshape the social as such? Framing them as mere sub-domains risks missing the digital

trees for the platform forest, with fragmented inquiry into the parts crowding out analysis of the whole. While I'm not fully convinced by Brubaker's (2022) invocation of Marcel Mauss's notion of a "total social fact", it nonetheless highlights the possibility that a fundamental transition might demand a review of core sociological categories.

It seems implausible to deny some kind of meta-process pertaining to digital change, yet conversely difficult to offer a compelling account of what this change consists in. There are many examples I could cite, equivalent to Lamott's "wire thing", with the intention of making the familiar strange through story and anecdote. But this book does not aim to be a compendium of how we "live in a digital age", even if it recognises a vast and vital empirical literature fulfilling such a purpose. Instead I'm interested in attempts to grapple with the meta-process in its broadest sense, such as Srnicek's (2016) *platform capitalism*, Zuboff's (2019) *surveillance capitalism* and van Dijck, Poell and de Waal's (2018) *platform society*. My intention is not to repudiate these accounts, or even to engage with them beyond acknowledging the points where they have influenced my own approach. Instead I want to linger at the microsocial level, conceptually rather than empirically, exploring how to trace connections between everyday formation and wider societal change in a fresh way. This means exploring the person who lives through these changes, recovering the category of *agency* as central for understanding digital change. In doing so I sketch an alternative way of gesturing towards the meta-process which frames the ambition and the object of this book.

Who Is the Person Living through Changes?

What is a person? Such a question is often assumed to fall outside the remit of sociology, instead being a matter of philosophy, anthropology or the human sciences. Yet any sociological claim that references actual human beings inevitably assumes certain characteristics of those persons. The category of "the person" might be denied, but some locus of individual properties remains, raising the question of how the lived individuals populating our lifeworlds relate to the minimal unit of sociological explanation. As Christian Smith puts it, "the better we understand the human, the better we should explain the social" (Smith 2010). Something analogous to the person is a recurrent metacategorical feature of sociological discourse; trying to explain away the putative causal powers of the person still requires recognition of this category, possibly explaining why the properties and powers so trenchantly denied often creep back in (Archer 2000: 1–50). This tendency of matters theoretically repudiated to return via the backdoor is not unique to this issue, as adroitly demonstrated in Mouzelis (1995). But the manner in which sociology struggles to vanquish the category of the person has intrigued me since I first encountered the discipline, as a student of political philosophy preoccupied by the category of the individual within liberal political thought. Even when it is repressed the person returns in curious places, as a reading of Durkheim's (1897 [2006]) *Suicide*

demonstrates. Although Durkheim repudiates the individual as an object of sociological concern, he nevertheless offers a sophisticated (if lopsided) social psychology of that individual and their purposeful behaviour.

Clearly, the person matters for sociological thought, especially as a lens through which to explore intensive social, cultural and technological change. These changes matter because something is happening at the level of the person that warrants commentary and concern. Even if they are not initially legible as ontological claims, the category of the person figures both implicitly and explicitly in academic and popular accounts of sociotechnical change. It would be difficult to grasp the stakes in these debates if we don't accept there are people for whom these things matter (Sayer 2011; Porpora 2016). Yet there is a conceptual queasiness concerning the categories we admit into social analysis for these purposes, even where they quite explicitly figure in the manner in which we talk about issues under question.

The point of this preamble is not to offer an ontological defence of personhood nor to settle the disputes surrounding it. Such debates have been tackled extensively by Archer (2000) and Smith (2010). Instead, this book focuses on a paradoxically more specific yet broader concern: *the relationship between personal change and social change*. What do the transformations people undergo *as* people reveal about social shifts, and vice versa? How can we connect personal lives and digital change without collapsing one into the other? In the widespread confrontation with digital technology's ubiquity we find an emerging recognition: *social change (particularly technological innovation) acts back, in non-trivial ways, on the nature of the person*. Not only are the changes in our technology changing us, there are aspects of this process which feel concerning and out of control. There is a sense "in the air" that something significant about personhood is shifting, tied in nebulous but contested ways to the changing technological scaffolding of social life. The parameters within which we become persons seem not only fundamentally altered but also caught in a sociotechnical process that might be accelerating.

The intersection between the digital age and people, what I will call **platform and agency**, poses a problem that is both existential and intellectual. It raises questions about how we use these platforms, now tangled up in our lives, or find ourselves *used by them* in a manner that negates our agency (Brubaker 2022: loc 906). We are, as Nielsen and Ganter (2022: loc 3869) put it, "simultaneously empowered by and dependent on platform companies", expanding the scope of our agency in a range of mundane ways but leaving us caught in systems of monitoring and influence which we did not choose. There is a new expression of what Archer (1995) calls the *vexatious fact* of society emerging at the intersection between personal and sociotechnical change.

This intersection is what I explore in the coming chapters, drawing on work I have conducted since 2008. Much hinges on defining the relation between platform and agency, with antihumanism, posthumanism and transhumanism engaging with this question in different ways (Carrigan and Porpora 2021). Yet a larger set of issues is at stake, and the field is strewn with conceptual detritus. Consequently, I take what may appear to be a circuitous route towards a single,

if very abstract, question. In the early chapters, I refrain from taking a stance on the broader issue, precisely because I sense these debates have gone badly astray. The cultural politics of digital devices have become entangled in a larger confusion over technological determinism, making it difficult to sustain analytical distance in the face of sociotechnical change (Lawson 2017). As Boyd (2014: loc 313) observes, “Utopian and dystopian views assume that technologies possess intrinsic powers that affect all people in all situations in the same way”. Whether we imagine a Promethean flame that saves us or dooms us, the underlying assumption is an aggregate of individuals will be shaped by these technologies in predictable ways. Yet rarely do such accounts clarify who this “us” is, or exactly how “we” will be effected, reflecting a wider tendency to ignore the *variability* of these sociotechnically mediated relations (Couldry 2015). This exacerbates pre-existing weaknesses concerning how the relationship between personal change and social change has been conceptualised in social theory (Mouzelis 2008). Thus, I begin with a body of work that starkly exposes these issues, even if my stance towards it is predominately critical.

My starting point is the literature on late modernity: particularly Giddens (1990, 1991, 1992), Bauman (1991, 2000, 2001, 2005, 2007, 2013) and Beck and Beck-Gernsheim (2001). Though these works may seem dated in the 2020s, they exercised significant influence on British sociology at the turn of the century. This influence feels especially salient to me, given it was the tradition in which I was professionally socialised, and it originally lured me away from analytic philosophy. What has always fascinated me about this body of work is its flawed, yet valuable, impulse to capture sweeping social change in broad, panoramic terms. They point towards a meta-process which exceeds our attempts to specify it empirically. Not only is there a *recognition* of meta-process, but there is an evident *joy* in describing it and enthusiasm for illuminating an unfolding transition (Connor 2021). Metaphors abound as these now canonical texts fold myriad empirical phenomena into a dazzling horizon of a purported bleeding edge of social transformation (Archer 2013; Outhwaite 2009).

When I first encountered this literature as a postgraduate student, frustrated by the aridity of analytic philosophy and the nebulous poeticism of certain continental strands, it felt like a revelation. In my early 20s, it offered a social and existential vocabulary for intellectual and personal questions that, until then, had been flickers of inarticulate concern. Richard Rorty (1989: xiv) wrote of “our own half-articulate need to become a new person, one who we as yet lack words to describe”. Those were the words I felt I’d found in the late modernity literature, even if it seems, in retrospect, curious that the reflections of ageing social theorists could resonate so strongly with an emerging adult (Arnett 2001). It may look and feel dated now, but the epistemic distance this affords can be helpful in making sense of our current conjuncture. This was a remarkably influential literature, in spite of the conceptual weaknesses which are evident upon closer inspection.

Despite its preoccupation with modernity’s bleeding edge, a rampaging juggernaut that would transform everything, there was *always* something oddly dated about this literature, even at its inception. My own engagement began

just as the 2007–2008 financial crisis was eroding the whiggish narrative of neoliberal globalisation, further revealing these texts to be out of sequence with the times. There was an almost comforting quality to the invocations of freedom alongside the sense of structural unravelling which accompanied my early engagement with them. The often careless handling of the *longue durée*, especially surprising given Bauman's and Giddens' theoretical sophistication, points to implicit assumptions in a literature that, as Savage (2010a), might be the latest iteration of a long-standing tradition in British sociology. Savage and Burrows (2007: 7) describe this tradition as “the kind of sociological theorizing that presents synthetic accounts of social change” appealing “to a (relatively) wide audience” and keeping “sociology in the public eye”.

What explains the enthusiasm for epochal diagnosis? One could read Giddens and Bauman as pursuing an ascension strategy in the human sciences, providing evocative themes that travel easily in a fast-changing intellectual environment (Clegg 1992). This keeps sociology visible but also elevates sociological “prophets” in the attention space of the discipline and its neighbours, offering intellectual reference points which are easy to draw upon. For instance Bauman's *Liquid Modernity* has over 23,000 citations while Giddens' *Modernity and Self-Identity* surpasses 57,000. Whatever virtues we attribute to these texts, it's clear both authors wrote earlier, more theoretically significant monographs that remain far less cited. This discrepancy is curious. It suggests a puzzle demanding explanation, a puzzle that the preliminary work of this book aims to address. If there's a professional and epistemic-affective payoff to undertaking epochal diagnosis, this would explain the *supply* but not necessarily the *demand* (Connor 2021).

Still, whatever inadequacies may inhere in this body of work, critique must be balanced by acknowledging the value many researchers have found in it (Smart 2007). These writings act as a conduit linking diverse sociological sub-disciplines, ensuring they can, at least potentially, be integrated into a shared intellectual framework. As Scott (2005) memorably states (albeit describing a position he doesn't endorse): “sociology may, on occasion, serve as a ‘mid-wife’ to new areas of investigation that do not yet form separate disciplines. However these specialisms will eventually mature and leave home to start a life of their own”. The detraditionalisation thesis stands as an incitement for emergent subfields to occasionally return home and find something of mutual interest to discuss when they do. It carries a sense of overarching intellectual motivation at risk of being lost given the “increasing specialisation focused primarily on individual substantive problem areas” (Turner, C 2010: 30) and the disciplinary fragmentation which tends to result (Holmwood 2010a, 2010b, 2011). Nonetheless, it typifies a

kind of sociology which does not seek to define its expertise in terms of its empirical research skills, but in terms of its ability to provide an overview of a kind that is not intended to be tested by empirical research.

(Savage and Burrows 2007: 12)

I will suggest we do need precisely this kind of overview to grapple with the fundamental character of sociotechnical transformation. Yet the literature also offers cautionary lessons on the risks inherent in such panoramic undertakings, and perhaps hints on how not to repeat its errors. The weaknesses are obvious but I don't believe we should entirely dispense with the intellectual sensibility which animated it.

We gain much by appreciating how epochal enthusiasm was both this literature's charm and its undoing. Despite its ambiguous standing regarding empirical research, this influential body of work makes ambitious claims about what it means to be a person under contemporary social conditions. It asserts that an epochal change leaves people "continuously confronted with a plurality of uncertain life course options" transforming life into a "reflexive project" and obliging individuals "to organize the future and reconstruct their own biographies in light of rapidly changing information and experiences" (Mills 2007: 67–68). It diagnoses a predicament where we seek "biographical solutions to systemic contradictions" (Beck and Beck-Gernsheim 2001: xxii).

Under this frame issues once treated as philosophical anthropology appear fundamentally sociological: *what is it like to be a person now?* In various ways, under multiple descriptions, the question recurs in sociological thought (Chernilo 2016). Yet it often eludes those who pursue it, being an empirical question posed at a level of generality that precludes a straightforward empirical answer. Trying to solve it empirically, amassing data in the hope of a direct answer, soon erodes the panoramic vista that makes the question so compelling. Insist too strongly on empirical robustness and you risk losing the broader canvas that epochal theorising was meant to capture in the first place. As Archer (2013: 19) puts it, "The basic shortcoming of empiricist and actualist accounts is that observable *transitional* features are simply extrapolated and presumed to constitute *transformation*". Instead of examining the "changing structural and cultural contexts in daily life and across generations" which people confront, individually and collectively, in order to identify the mechanisms driving change, empiricist treatments of epochal change simply generalise from the initial observation in a way that actively obscures the underlying question of what Chernilo (2016) describes as *philosophical sociology*.

These accounts of late modernity do capture something deeply experiential, but perhaps only for those inclined to share a "celebration of a cosmopolitan intellectual ethic, that can only be realized by a small minority of people". Skeggs (2004: 54) further warns that "[c]lass is displaced and effaced in these new modes of mobility and individualization, by the very people whose ideas are institutionalized and help to reproduce class inequality more intensely". This is a sociology that can easily lend itself to legitimation rather than critique: Tony Benn (2007) remarked on the early New Labour years that "Anthony Giddens just hovers round trying to put an ideological cloak around whatever is being discussed" (Skeggs 2019). The extent to which its originators succeeded at "shifting sociological product" should not be underestimated, nor should the extent to which this was likely one motivation for their work (Clegg 1992).

In making this point, I do not intend to explain away the sociological accounts under discussion, but to highlight how the authors' intellectual careers were intertwined with the very transformations they analysed. This literature is a product of its time, as were the authors whose sensibility and quirks reflect a dominant trajectory of post-war sociological thought. If we are to treat them as an exemplar of epochal theorising, we need to carefully distinguish between the issues involved in telling stories about social change and the particular stories which were told by these theorists.

Telling Stories about Social and Cultural Change

What to do? How to act? Who to be? These are focal questions for everyone living in circumstances of late modernity – and ones which, on some level or another, all of us answer, either discursively or through day-to-day social behaviour.

(Giddens 1991: 70)

It is a central tenet of Giddens (1990, 1991, 1992, 1994) that under late modern conditions, the existential dimension of human life has undergone a radical transformation. Global forces have reshaped emotional life, with several interconnected processes rendering long-standing orientations inadequate for navigating a rapidly changing social world. Giddens (1991, 1994) refers to this reshaping of late modern life as *detraditionalisation* and, along with Bauman (1991, 2000, 2001, 2005, 2007, 2013) and Beck and Beck-Gernsheim (2001), his writing on the topic has wielded immense influence across many areas of social inquiry. Adams (2004) suggests Castells (1996) and Gergen (1991) could also be grouped in this body of work, as could Sennett (1998, 2007) and Young (2007). These original texts and their subsequent literature claim that under conditions of late modernity, “processes of ‘individualization’ ... undermine and dissolve old constraints that bound people to certain lifestyles and open up many areas of life to personal choice” (Howard 2007: 1). A profound social change is underway and is being lived out at the personal level. The former reshapes the parameters of the latter, by removing old certainties and calling inherited orthodoxies into question, thus creating opportunities for self-determination while also posing unsettling existential questions that not everyone is equipped to answer.

While the relationship between the concepts of “detraditionalisation” and “individualisation” is often unclear, prompting authors such as Smart (2007) to use the terms synonymously, this confusion mostly reflects the broader differences among various individualisation theorists. Pilkington (2007) contends Beck and Giddens share certain core ideas but emphasise them differently, while Bauman's poetic style and gloomy pronouncements (analysed by Rattansi 2014), remain analytically continuous with other authors. Elchardus and De Keere (2010) propose that individualisation, in this literature, is effectively the

outcome of detraditionalisation. Though the textual basis for this claim is unclear, it provides a helpful way to approach a body of work which, despite its influence, often lacks rigour and consistency. For this reason, I will treat detraditionalisation as the process of social and cultural change through which the *reproduction* of tradition declines in social life and the *authority* of what remains is simultaneously diminished.

Revisiting this work with hindsight reveals a notable sense of shared assumptions, as though these authors felt no need to justify claims that mirrored the intellectual “air” of the time; much like the current sense of digital change pervading today’s public debate. How far this consensus reflected the cultural common sense of what Stiglitz (2003) called the “roaring 90s”, framed by ascendant academics becoming global celebrities, would be a fascinating study. While that is not my focus here, I regard this literature as a curious artefact of its era, coloured by the whiggish assumption of the “end of history” (Alexander 1995). These assumptions now appear crass after the financial crisis, global pandemic, and war in Europe. Even Bauman’s sombre outlook reflects the depoliticisation of that time, despite his inclination to critique it (Rattansi 2014). It’s difficult not to wonder if the same might appear true in the future of a notion such as Zuboff’s (2019) *surveillance capitalism*, which so perfectly captured the mood of the late 2010s, following Edward Snowden’s revelations about collaboration between Big Tech and the national security state for mass surveillance (Greenwald 2014).

In the post-traditional order described by Giddens (1991), tradition increasingly loses purchase on our internal deliberations about *what to do* and *who to be*. If the present diverges from the past, inherited guidelines fail to map onto current predicaments. The disruptive events shaping history since Giddens wrote, like the financial crisis and the COVID-19 pandemic, illustrate this well, representing novel situations which invite a comparable novelty in the response of agents and organisations. The risk in such a framing is that we lose sight of the evident continuities between past pandemics and financial crises, leading us to overemphasise the novel elements (such as the role of video conferencing in facilitating social distancing) and underemphasise the familiar features (such as the tendency towards “cultural amnesia” in responding to pandemics) (De Waal 2021; Crow 2005). These events serve as cautionary tales against hastily involving epochal change; what now seem like the stable days of the 1980s and 1990s were once imagined to involve an unprecedented shift in everyday life. The unsettling possibility is that we could apply the same epochal lens to contemporary instability, particularly the climate crisis, which might unravel those very parameters (Bacevic 2023; Couldry 2024). Could the “polycrisis” of the 2020s appear as a lost period of stability from the perspective of an uninhabitable earth in the 2030s and 2040s (Tooze 2021; Wallace-Wells 2019)?

Inevitably there is a poetic aspect to these judgements, expressing a desire for the fatefulness of our times to be recognised as historical rather than merely experiential. There is an aspiration to dignify our experience with the sense of

living through something monumental, which is distinctly modernist as a sensibility. Ghosh (2016: 125) warns us

the same process that inaugurated the rising death spiral of carbon emissions also ensured, in an uncannily clever gesture of self-protection, that the artists, writers, and poets of that era would go racing off in directions that actually blinding them to exactly what they thought they were seeing: that is to say, what lay en avant, what was to come.

The impulse to “keep up” with the present moment (and the isms which it generates) can obscure deeper implications in a discursive flurry which is more heat than light (Ghosh 2016: 127). This distinction between fatefulness as narrative impulse and as ontological property will reappear in subsequent chapters at the micro-level of personal biography. The tension between them can be seen to play out just as much in the lives of theorists, once we insist on locating these people within and responding to their historical conditions (Alexander 1995; Sloterdijk 2012).

Although modernity and tradition have long stood in opposition, Giddens (1994) argues modernity tends to *rebuild* tradition: capitalism’s creative destruction erodes tradition with one hand while generating opportunities for its renewal with the other. For instance, industrialisation transformed traditional labour practices yet also enabled individuals to organise and improve their shared conditions, thus breeding new traditions of collective action. With the onset of late modernity, he argues, this counterweight ended: change led to further change, not the solidification of stable conditions. Heelas et al. (1996: 2) offer a helpful working definition of this process in terms of detraditionalisation:

As a working definition, detraditionalization involves a shift of authority: from “without” to “within”. It entails the decline of the belief in pre-given or natural orders of things. Individual subjects are themselves called upon to exercise authority in the face of the disorder and contingency which is thereby generated. “Voice” is displaced from established sources, coming to rest with the self.

While detraditionalising processes may be implicit in classic modernisation a theory, a perspective Heelas et al. (1996) calls co-existence theorising, the contemporary notion is a “radical thesis”. It asserts a break with modernity: as Giddens (1991: 175) puts it “the radical turn from tradition intrinsic to modernity’s reflexivity makes a break ... with preceding social eras”. The radical change being claimed lies not simply in the erosion of tradition but in the absence of distinctly modern traditions that might have emerged instead (Heiskala 2011). This aligns with Heelas et al.’s (1996: 3) observation that detraditionalisation is often defined by stark dichotomies:

fate (or the pre-ordained) v. choice (or reflexivity); necessity v. contingency; certainty v. uncertainty; security v. risk. Differentiated (or organized)

culture v. the de-differentiated (or disorganized); the embedded (situated or sociocentric) self v. the disembedded (de-situated or autonomous); self under control v. self in control; and virtues v. preferences (with values coming in between).

In broad terms, detraditionalisation theories assert a temporal transition from one pole to another: in a post-traditional order, fate becomes choice, certainty becomes uncertainty, security becomes risk and so on. Even at this early stage, the empirical flaws in such accounts are evident: the claims seem, at best, overstated. Heiskala (2011: 12) notes these stark oppositions obscure “manifold continuities between societies placed on the opposite sides of the line of transformation”. Similarly, Crow (2005) warns that “much is lost when complex analyses are reduced to the stark opposition of change or continuity”. Alexander (1995: 44–5) goes further, accusing Giddens of restaging the alternatives of modernisation theory in an “even more arbitrary way”. In their enthusiasm for epochal diagnosis, these theorists skip over obvious conceptual questions, leaving us with an evocative narrative that has cracks which become apparent as soon as we look closely at it.

While dismissing it is tempting, we risk missing something deeper. We must acknowledge its influence, particularly within sociological sub-disciplines and nascent fields of inquiry. Indeed these ideas align with a much longer modernisation tradition in sociology, particularly in Britain, where theoretical engagement with social change has special disciplinary significance (Heiskala 2011; Savage 2010b). In this sense, we can view the detraditionalisation thesis as a neo-modernisation theory (Alexander 1995), one that has influenced a wide range of substantive inquiries. Smart (2007: 24) notes how this body of work has “injected debate and excitement into the field of families, intimacy and relationships” (see also Heaphy 2007; Roseneil and Budgeon 2004; Roseneil 2000, 2007). A similar degree appears within Youth Studies, including, for example, Dillabough and Kennelly (2010), France (2007), Green (2008) and Jones (2009). As I’ve explained, enthusiasm for this body of work led to my own move into sociology, even if then I spent a part-time PhD attempting to understand the weaknesses I began to perceive in this body of work.

Its influence is not uniform and some subsequent research is admirably critical, yet there is a consistent pattern: researchers repeatedly find conceptual or ideational use in this framework. This is what I’m arguing we need to take seriously, alongside a robust engagement with the weakness of the literature. Nonetheless, we might question whether this value outweighs the difficulties of employing these concepts operationally. Brannen and Nilsen (2005: 412) observe that the decontextualised nature of the detraditionalisation thesis creates “difficulties attached to making use of its concepts for analytical purposes in empirical research”. Rather than being a basis for dismissal, this specific weakness could be seen to invite reparative work in order to understand how researchers have sought to apply it in empirical research. Despite serious issues with detraditionalisation theory, which I explore further, it remains an important part of the

sociological canon (Outhwaite 2009). Smart (2007) offers an interesting attempt to theorise its place in empirical research, while Hepp (2009: 141) similarly suggests:

[W]ith their approach to individualization, Ulrich Beck and Elisabeth Beck-Gernsheim outline an explanation of the present social change that cannot be proven by any single survey. Rather, we have to understand their theory of individualization as a meta approach that makes it possible to integrate very different results of surveys and qualitative investigations into an overall coherent understanding.

Heiskala (2011) argues that the modernisation perspective, with this literature constituting a final display of intellectual life in an otherwise moribund tradition, has been gradually overshadowed by the spatial (rather than temporal) framework of globalisation. Still, elements persist as “something like a family secret” that “most sociologists use” as a “background understanding”. It retains value as a “useful tool for framing research questions” and “contributing to the diagnosis of the era”, enabling broad introductory accounts that can then be explored empirically via other approaches (Heiskala 2011: 14). Precisely because it continues to operate as a “frame of orientation”, we must understand how and why it does so, as well as the consequences which follow. The attitude I adopt towards this literature mirrors Giddens’s stance on functionalism: “it is essential to understand the attractions ... while still holding that conceptually its influence has been largely pernicious” (Giddens 1984: xxxi). This body of work was evidently appealing across multiple disciplines, a fact underscored by the high citation counts of core texts and their cross-domain reach.

Much of the empirical work drawing on this literature does so in the way that Heiskala (2011) indicates: it treats it as a conceptual framework for shaping research questions and contextualising empirical data. This approach makes sense, given Reed and Alexander’s (2009: 24) comment that “Giddens’ idea of ‘late modernity’ could organise myriad case studies”. The framework seems well-suited to providing a thematic lens for empirical research, linking individual findings to a broader context. The problem is that, as Brannen and Nilsen (2005: 413) suggest, often “the theory is imported at the analysis phase of the research in order to make generalisations across cases rather than being applied to distinguish differences between cases”. In other words, it becomes a tool for thematising rather than rigorous theorising. It presents itself as available for a purpose which it’s unable to adequately serve for reasons which are important to understand.

Much of the literature concerns the outcome of detraditionalisation rather than the process itself. For example, Hopper (2003: 29) argues that detraditionalisation entails a “number of developments and processes ... that each in some way challenge traditions and traditional forms of authority”. He suggests that examining institutions such as organised religion, political authority, class and the family shows their relevance diminishing alongside their authority and status. As an empirical example, Hopper cites declining church attendance to

illustrate detraditionalisation at work in a traditional institution. Labelling an institution “traditional” in this context is problematic, since it defines tradition as something in decline, operating with a circular definition which presupposes its conclusion. It assumes a linear trajectory, crowding out other interpretations (e.g. a decline in church attendance might indicate *transformation* rather than diminishment). In this sense, the detraditionalisation thesis exemplifies Taylor’s (2007: 22) “subtraction story”: grand accounts which explain processes by which “human beings have lost, or sloughed off, or liberated themselves from certain earlier, confining horizons, or illusions, or limitations of knowledge”. It paints humanity as historically burdened by tradition, until late modernity when we finally see through the received authority that once reproduced tradition. Beyond its conceptual issues, this treatment of “tradition” is also questionable empirically and politically. As Adams (2004) remarks:

It is a common cliché to imagine the Victorian self as bound by strict civil codes, obsessed with manners, hierarchy and social position, whilst in thrall to scientific rationalism, Reason, and the repressive caricature of selfhood all these factors combined to encourage. Accounts of post-traditional theorists may not be so coarse in their portrayal, but as has been suggested already, its advocates rarely consider any historical period in enough detail to produce meaningful portraits of experience, stereotyped or otherwise.

(Adams 2004: 5)

Temporal Ontology and the Poetics of Social Change

The point is not that social theorists must match the epistemological standards of historians. Rather, we must temper sweeping pronouncements with a curiosity about the empirical variability of historical change. The problem, as Savage (2021: 185–188) explains, arises from the conception of the “modern” itself, whereby sociologists specialise in “differentiating complex modern societies (which they research) compared to ‘traditional’ ones (which historians, anthropologists, archaeologists and so forth can analyse)”. This implies “modern dynamic societies break from an older, stable, and fixed society” (Savage 2021: 186) suggesting that detraditionalisation literature reiterates a temporal ontology rooted in classical sociology. These are familiar assumptions which are drawn out in a newly stylised form within this once influential literature. Indeed Savage (2021: 191) calls, “the last effort to shore up a modernist temporal ontology at the very moment that it was breaking down”. He notes this creates a dilemma because that ontology is still woven into the sociological categories in use today:

This temporal ontology is locked into key analytical moves in sociology, such as the distinction between structure and agency, which is premised on this ontological temporal difference between past, enduring structures, and a contemporary, contingent agency that breaks from them.

(Savage 2021: 352)

The difficulty with Savage's view is that it conflates structure/agency as a conceptual schema with the varied ways these categories have been used in practice. Although a central logic (objective/subjective, past/present and micro/macro) underpins the debate, there are many interpretations of what structure and agency entail. Indeed it would be hard to understand the "structure/agency debate" if there were not disagreements about how these categories should be defined and operationalised. Failing to acknowledge this plurality shows a surprising lack of nuance in Savage's (2021) otherwise incisive and insightful analysis of ontological reasoning. My aim here is not to score conceptual points but to highlight the role these concepts often play in applied analysis, rather than the textual disputes of theorists. Savage (2021) skilfully explains how the modernist temporal ontology shapes methodology, yet he does not fully acknowledge the distinct instantiations of the structure/agency divide across a sprawling literature, implying an inevitability that the issue does not warrant.

A similar observation applies to concepts like *institutions*, *networks* or *relations*. Using the same term does not guarantee the same meaning, given that the cultural system is always socio-culturally mediated (Archer 1988). The ideas are put to work in contextually sensitive ways, conditioned but not determined by the logical relations between ideas. Hence, examining how these categories circulate and evolve is as crucial as considering their assumptions and corollaries. This requires recognising empirical variability in their definitions and usage. This is particularly important for how we conceive of agency, given what Archer (1995: 1–2) described as the vexatious fact of society:

An inescapable part of our inescapably social condition is to be aware of its constraints, sanctions and restrictions on our ambitions – be they for good or for evil. Equally, we acknowledge certain social blessings such as medication, transportation and education: without their enablements our lives and hopes would both be vastly more circumscribed. At the same time, an inalienable part of our human condition is the feeling of freedom: we are 'sovereign artificers' responsible for our own destinies, and capable of re-making our social environment to befit human habitation.

This creates an "ambivalence in the daily experience of ordinary people" which, Archer stresses, "is fully authentic". The theoretical, methodological and empirical challenge inherent to sociological inquiry is how we account adequately for this ambivalence, resisting the intellectual temptation to resolve it in a theoretical schema which emphasises one dimension rather than another. This is what I think detraditionalisation theorists have done in the stories they tell about agency, preoccupied by an exhilarating panorama in which an old world is dying while a new one struggles to be born. The individualised subject stands at this precipice, with a horizon of opportunity open before them. If they can exercise enough self-mastery they can be whatever they dream, yet if they fail vertigo awaits as the familiar parameters of their upbringing have faded away into the background. It's an existential fable for boomer theorists

whose careers are on a steep upwards trajectory which is as evocative, if you really listen to it, as it is flawed.

In this book, I'll try to avoid constructing a parallel millennial fable about the opportunities and ordeals of a platformised lifeworld, instead exploring how we might treat the epochal in an *analytical* rather than *poetic* register, in the sense mapped out by Archer (2013), with a particular focus on the fabric of everyday life. The conceptual work needed for this is the concern of the next four chapters. My more immediate point is that epochalism is less bounded than Savage implies, leaving more space for engagement and recovery than he suggests. While I share some of his criticisms, I do not seek to dismiss the detraditionalisation literature or the structure/agency question he sees as bound to it. Rather, I argue that an alternative is both possible and necessary, if we are to grasp the sociotechnical shifts remaking the lifeworld and their implications for self-formation. If we dispense with it entirely we lose a significant feature of a sociological, rather than historical, account of change. But equally we cannot be satisfied conceptually or methodologically with the treatment of meta-process we find within this literature, even if it remains the most influential example of this concern in sociological thought over recent decades.

My disagreement with Savage (2021) is that he fails to acknowledge conceptions of agency that avoid the pitfalls of epochal theorising: those seeing agency as historically grounded rather than a purely present-tense negation of the past. This view aligns with the realist account of agency developed primarily by Archer (2003, 2007, 2012) and extended by Elder-Vass (2010), Sayer (2011), Smith (2010), Layder (1998) and Porpora (2015) in different ways. I contend this approach to agency can sidestep the difficulties Savage (2021) identifies while also illuminating the sociotechnical shifts defining the last two decades, which are the main focus of the book's second section. My approach aims for an epochal horizon in its argument but does so by examining the changing parameters of individual life, rather than reaching directly for a broader transformation still unfolding in these lived experiences. It aspires towards a more epistemically modest and methodologically cautious approach to grasping the meta-process which the detraditionalisation theorists enthusiastically seized in order to begin their overly hasty narrations.

Understanding the changing sociotechnical context of self-formation inevitably raises two questions: *what it means for a context to be sociotechnical* and *how to define the changes underway within it*. These issues will be addressed in depth in the second section, yet it is necessary to preview them here because they lie at the heart of recovering structure and agency from a modernist temporal ontology. Rather than discarding these categories, on the assumption we need entirely new ones for a new reality, we need to consider how we adapt them to draw out the continuities underpinning the “striking” changes we can observe (Archer 2013; Crow 2005).

There are many labels for these changes: *digitalisation*, *deep mediatisation*, *platformisation*, *digital capitalism*, *surveillance capitalism*, *platform capitalism*, etc. I don't explore them with the depth that would ideal, simply because it

would mean this book was consumed by literature review. However, my own approach draws heavily on Srnicek's (2016) concept of *platform capitalism* with a particular emphasis on the peculiar intimacy of a sociotechnical environment saturated by what Seymour (2016) calls the "social industries": cultural-economic behemoths that have penetrated every facet of our lifeworld under the banner of "social media". This forms the panorama I aim to depict throughout the book, even though my principal subject is the *becoming* of agents within this domain, suggesting how microsociological categories might be recalibrated for these new conditions.

I will argue that a profound shift is underway in the plate tectonics of agency, operating at micro, meso and macro levels. I propose we retain the categories of structure and agency, but "remaster" them, following Housley et al.'s (2014) notion of putting established concepts into dialogue with the changing affordances and constraints of our sociotechnical environment. Through what I term **platform and agency**, I am to spotlight the new sociotechnical infrastructures intersecting with the "past, enduring structures" which Savage (2021) identifies as the preoccupation of the detraditionalisation theorists, examining them from the standpoint of differently situated agents interacting over time. Any attempt to characterise a still unfolding process of change will necessarily be incomplete, but I hope to contribute to the challenge of theorising sociotechnical change. Gillespie (2018: 42) aptly notes that "It takes a while – years, decades – for a culture to adjust itself to the subtle workings of a new information system, and to stop expecting from it what traditional systems provided". For an agent-oriented ontology, this adaptation is best studied through the mundane realities of being an agent in a social world where inherited expectations are quickly destabilising.

The next chapter lays this foundation by examining how Giddens conceptualises agency and how that concept is tied to the detraditionalisation literature. While I acknowledge much of this literature feels dated, it still holds elements that might guide our conceptual understanding of platformisation as a societal phenomenon. This is not about finding direct answers in the literature, but rather about exploring the kinds of questions it raises and discovering what we can learn from engaging with it.

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2 Personal Reflexivity and Social Change

It is striking to revisit the work of Beck, Bauman and Giddens from a contemporary vantage point. Their ideas are rooted in the seemingly distant “roaring 1990s”, an era when, as Giddens (2003) described it, the “juggernaut of modernity” was racing forward at what many believed to be the end of history (Stiglitz 2003). Vostal (2014) identifies such imagined processes as a “mega force”, suggesting that one must either adapt or capitulate. This is a view shaped by the hegemonic climate in which these authors wrote, and by Giddens’s proximity to power as a New Labour intellectual. This all preceded what Žižek (2009) termed the “one-two punch of history”: 9/11 and the 2008/09 financial crisis, events that shook the hegemony presumed by these theories and were later aggravated by authoritarian populism, the COVID-19 crisis, and a deeply altered global economy. In retrospect, that allegedly disruptive decade appears almost halcyon, a realisation Beck (2016) was approaching in an unfinished, posthumously published text. Yet the current turmoil, to use Beck’s term, casts doubt on the “fatefulness” these authors had attached to the 1990s, when their most influential works were produced. We continue to grapple with their epochal baggage, even if their narratives seem ever less persuasive with the passage of time.

However, despite the epochal poetics surrounding what Giddens called the “juggernaut of modernity”, he provides a notably clear account of how social change unfolds. He argued that, as capitalism extends spatially across the globe, modernity enters a new phase: its “pattern of expansionism” having become “much more decentred as well as more all-enveloping”, with an “overall movement ... towards much greater interdependence” (Giddens 1994: 57). Accompanying this is an “extraordinary, and still accelerating, connectedness between every-day decisions and global outcomes, together with its reverse, the influence of global orders over individual life” (Giddens 1994: 58). Our growing awareness of the potentially global impact of our actions goes hand-in-hand with recognising that distant events exert an ever-increasing influence on our day-to-day deliberations. Central to this discussion is Giddens’s (1991) notion of “disembedding”: the processes by which social activity is “lifted out” of concrete spacetime. These are “mechanisms which prise social relations free from the hold of specific locales, recombining them across wide time-space

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distances” (Giddens 1991: 2). As we will see, digital platforms exemplify such disembedding, reshaping local routines into globally networked interactions (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 3).

In his original account, Giddens (1991) identifies two kinds of disembedding mechanisms: the creation of symbolic tokens and the establishment of expert systems. Symbolic tokens are media of exchange with standardised value (such as money) that bracket time and space through their interchangeability. This will tend to engender an awareness of global ramifications for our actions, underscoring how distant events can shape everyday deliberations. Expert systems, meanwhile, are institutional deployments of knowledge that stand independently of the practitioners and clients who use them, encompassing “all aspects of social life in conditions of modernity – in respect of the food we eat, the medicines we take, the buildings we inhabit, the forms of transport we use and a multiplicity of other phenomena” (Giddens 1991: 18). Giddens argues that such abstract systems, eluding the particular concerns of micro-social contexts, necessitate trust. As these systems permeate broader swathes of human life, we must rely on processes and knowledge that we neither fully see nor understand. In late modernity, both forms of disembedding intensify and expand, profoundly destabilising the previously secure (i.e. “traditional”) relations that once reproduced social life.

A core argument of this book is that digital platforms can be fruitfully understood in terms of this concept of disembedding mechanisms. Take Uber, for instance: it lifts a set of routine social interactions (consumer engagement with local taxi services, economic relations between drivers and firms, and the broader organisation of transport in everyday life) out of their microsocial contexts, placing a Silicon Valley corporation at a crucial nexus of global capital accumulation and making it a constitutive intermediary across a dizzying range of local settings. This can generate trust for many Uber drivers and riders, since not only it reduces uncertainty in certain aspects of the interaction, but it also poses a range of new problems, as evidenced by the firm’s political trajectory (Isaac 2019). I offer this example here to illustrate Giddens’s enduring relevance, even if my engagement with his ideas will be critical. The conceptual tools he offers for explaining change can be separated from the epochal poetics in which they originally appeared. In fact they can be particularly useful for overcoming the tendency to see technological innovation as constituting an epochal break with a term before the “disruption” happened (Mosco 2005). Even if I don’t think it’s straightforwardly the case that platforms *are* disembedding mechanisms in this sense, they can be understood in terms of a genealogy of mechanisms which predate the most recent phase of sociotechnical development. This is a useful move in its own right because it identifies continuity where the prevailing orthodoxy tends to assert rupture.

According to the detraditionalisation thesis, “destabilizing these social relationships likewise destabilizes the traditions that they embody and the practices that sustain the traditions” (Carroll 2000: 18). Essentially, this is a statement about social reproduction: the varied phenomena we group under

“globalisation” comprise disembedding mechanisms that disrupt the transmission of “tradition”. Although this process is recognised as uneven, it is deemed widespread enough that whatever sociocultural reproduction persists often lacks sufficient cohesion, rapidly eroding the authority of tradition in the process. Consequently “their authority over us is weakened, and we are thrown back reflexively on the authority of our own experience to make the multiple choices that are open to us” (Carroll 2000: 18). In such circumstances, tradition no longer effectively guides social life. While cultural elements labelled “traditional” may still survive, in fact Gorski (2017) shows they can even thrive in certain locales, but they tend to be defensive and self-contained, at least until they pursue a more public role using the affordances of digital platforms.

This argument concerns the transition from traditional modernity, in which pre-modern traditions were supplanted by distinctly modern ones, to a post-traditional social order. The “traditions” in question thus encompass a broad spectrum of phenomena: class position, gender, religion, neighbourhood, nationalism, and science. Traditions do persist and can even be rearticulated as religious or political fundamentalisms, which strive to counter the complexity and ambiguity of contemporary capitalism by cultivating moral certainty (Barber 2010). Yet their role in human life is transformed: they may remain, but “the signposts of tradition now are blank” (Giddens 1991: 82). Even where they linger on, their efficacy in providing guides for action (“*What to do? How to act? Who to be?*”) can no longer be assumed. In fact it must be worked at in a way which is, ironically, reflexive. Under these circumstances tradition comes to feel problematic and unreliable. It comes to feel like one more option amongst others, a choice imminent within a framework of alternative choices, rather than something “outside” with the capacity to underwrite the choices we make (Taylor 2007).

Once its utility as a guide to action is exhausted, each individual is left to face the existential questions posed with growing intensity by global capitalism. If inherited tradition can’t answer the question of how to respond to the novel challenges of the present then what can? Inherited resources are increasingly incongruent with present conditions in ways which invite reflexive responses, even if they do not determine them. Consider, for example, the SARS-CoV-2 virus and the radical shift it induced in everyday life, especially during lockdown phases (Fuchs 2021). The virus itself exemplifies a globalised process, both in its origin (an accelerating rate of zoonotic transmission tied to global agribusiness) and subsequent spread through the arteries of an interconnected world (Davis 2022). Moreover, digital platforms became critical for managing everyday life during these crises, reflecting both new forms of trust and new forms of disembedding. It’s difficult to see how “tradition” could prepare for us for these experiences, particularly with a startling lack of interest shown in the historical lessons which could be learned from past pandemics (de Waal 2021).

While I’m sceptical of much of this framing, considering the example of the pandemic illustrates the contemporary relevance of the *concerns*, if not the diagnosis. If the past decreasingly provides a (workable) guide to the present,

given the novelty of those present circumstances, it clearly entails significant challenges for human agency. The problem arises with this literature because of how those challenges are conceived at the ontological level, that is, imagining “global forces” primarily as external pressures on a subject’s internal life, rather than phenomena that exist “out there” in the world. As Elliott and Lemert (2008: 94) argue:

the central conceptual and political limitation of conceptualizing globalization purely as an external force, however, is that it prevents us from seeing with sufficient clarity the myriad ways in which individuals engage, respond, escape, reproduce or transform the whole gamut of globalizing forces that they necessarily encounter in their everyday lives.

On their account, drawing heavily on Giddens, globalisation includes fundamental psychic dimensions, obscured if we treat the underlying changes purely as reorganising an external social world. Their approach to this issue involves a psychoanalytic exploration of the “new individualism” they take to ensue from this process, predicated on an understanding that this process is “built upon operations of fantasy and its unconscious contortions – anxieties about difference, about otherness and strangeness, about intimacy and proximity” (Elliott and Lemert 2008: 73). Addressing phenomena such as “compulsive consumerism”, “cybersex” and “therapy culture”, they repeatedly assert that global forces mould psychic life. Yet they seldom analyse these phenomena in detail, instead mapping causal links, often derived from fictional vignettes treated as empirical data, between the global and the psychic. As I will show, Giddens attempts to address the psychic realism in a more robust way, but still faces similar challenges in explaining how global and local dimensions genuinely intersect. There clearly *are* psychic dimensions to these processes but a rush to depth psychology risks becoming a conceptual black hole which eats up the empirical substance of social life in the process (Layder 2004). There’s an awful lot which happens between the psychic life of the individual and the global forces “out there” which these theorists seem weirdly incurious about.

Although an interface between these levels is theoretically posited, there is little effort made to conceptualise how it actually operates. Consequently, the individual becomes a cipher: individuality is perpetually emphasised yet somehow lacks real significance. It’s vacuous and monadic, a kaleidoscopic self-prone to continual change without any real stakes. Elliott and Lemert (2008: 56) even embrace this stance, contending that “in current social circumstances – in which our lives are reshaped by technology-induced globalization and the transformation of capitalism – it is not the particular individuality of an individual that is most important” but, rather, the *process* by which that individuality is produced. This leaves us with the curious phenomenon of an *individualism* disinterested in *individuality*, as opposed to the realist alternative which matches an interest in individuality with a rejection of individualism.

The perspective of Elliott and Lemert (2008) assumes a sparse ontology, leaving no space between the “global forces” outside and the “psychic life” inside. The relational complexity of the world, particularly at the meso-social level, stands eviscerated by a putative mechanism in which “psychic life” is ultimately an outcome of “global forces”. Deprived of such a space, they cannot meaningfully explain the phenomena they discuss in any specific detail, nor ultimately are they actually trying to as strange as that might seem. While the book raises compelling questions about shifting human experience (likely part of its appeal), it is systematically unable to resolve them (Carrigan 2010). Unless we adequately account for this *interface* we will be prone to overstatement, particularly with regards to how it comes to be mediated by digital platforms. If there are changes at the individual level these can’t simply be understood as an outcome or adaptation to changes in external conditions.

Giddens (1991) likewise incorporates psychoanalytical theory, but, at least on the surface, his account appears more plausible. Elliott and Lemert (2008) aimed at highlighting the fantasy and trauma embedded in how subjects navigate a precarious social world, yet Lasch (1985, 1991) had already provided a more comprehensive treatment of these topics. Consequently, Elliott and Lemert’s work should not be viewed as either novel or especially enlightening, even if it’s a pleasingly modish example of the sensibility which dominated this strand of social thought at the time. It remains relevant here because I argue that its core deficiency epitomises a broader issue in the late modernity literature: the ambiguous interface between the “global” and the “personal” which theorists such as Bauman (2001, 2013), Beck and Beck-Gernsheim (2001) and Giddens (1991, 1992) all address in some way. Elliott and Lemert (2008) illustrate how inadequately this interface can be conceptualised; a shortfall that led me to examine them first, before turning to Giddens. Through this critical engagement, two meta-theoretical questions guiding this project become clearer: *what do theories of social change assume about persons*, and *what implications do these assumptions have for analysing social change?* In examining Giddens’s approach more closely, I show how reflexivity becomes central yet remains misconstrued, highlighting the need for an alternative model of agency.

Late Modernity in the Roaring 1990s

We find a more nuanced ontology in Giddens (1991) than in Elliott and Lemert (2008), with explicit mechanisms invoked to explain putative changes. As noted earlier, disembedding mechanisms unsettle the routine reproduction of the life-world on which tradition depends. Giddens’s account emphasises the creation of symbolic tokens and the deployment of expert systems, both of which appear in the constitution of digital platforms. The familiar character of social reproduction thus becomes marked by a certain patchiness, reflecting shifting spatial and temporal dynamics which preclude change unfolding in a uniform way. This raises the question of why change happens more in some contexts than others, though I’ll argue the approach lacks the tools to explain either the

intensiveness or the extensiveness of the change it identifies. Underlying this deficiency is the modernist temporal ontology critiqued by Savage (2021) in the previous chapter, described here by Mouzelis (1999: 83):

Whereas in pre-modern contexts individual conduct – in such crucial areas as work, marriage, the socialisation of children, entertainment, and so on – was regulated routinely but meaningfully through traditional moral codes, in detraditionalized social contexts all the mechanisms of social regulation extrinsic to the individual become weaker, and people are forced to confront a situation that urgently asks them to make choices, to decide about their career, their lifestyles, their diets, the number of children they wish to have, the way they will raise them and so on.

The detraditionalisation process imposes a normative vacuum, since the expansion of personal choice simultaneously dismantles the social and cultural guides to action that once offered stability. In earlier phases of modernity, new collective forms, such as the nation, the party or the class, partially filled that gap, providing fresh certainties in place of those eroded by modernisation. When these are lost, each individual must rely on their own resources, facing two possible behavioural paths for resolving the existential questions posed by life:

In detraditionalised contexts, there are two distinct possibilities in terms of responses to opportunities and anxieties: one is a move towards greater autonomy on the part of the individual, and the other a relapse into some form of compulsive behaviour.

(Giddens 1999: 202)

It should strike us as odd that a condition of expanding freedom produces “two distinct possibilities”. Surely there are a range of ways in which subjects could respond to these changes? These divergent pathways, autonomy or compulsion, will later be examined in how individuals with data-driven platforms. What is striking in this account is how individual agency appears to be an all-or-nothing affair: one is either a self-monitoring, autonomous individual or passively controlled by mindless compulsions. Using anorexia as an example, Giddens (1991: 105) describes compulsion as “a pathology of reflexive self-control, operating around an axis of self-identity and bodily appearance”. Many compulsions include a reflexive element, in the Giddensian sense of self-monitoring, as he shows when discussing a specific auto-ethnographic study of anorexia:

Her concern to become thin emerged, not as a sudden antipathy towards food, but as a controlled and progressive phenomenon, which happened ‘little by little’; she devoted a great deal of care and concern to her diet, a deliberate asceticism in bodily regime amid the plural choices of food available; there was a marked reflexive component, as signalled by her determination to ‘eat up’ all the information about calories she could

obtain; awareness of the need to forge a distinctive lifestyle, in relation to her self-identity, emerges very clearly; and a polarity comes out plainly in the 'façade she sought to construct as contrasted to her eventual conviction that she could 'nourish her self-esteem rather than 'starve' it.

(Giddens 1991: 105–106)

Such a case, Giddens argues, exemplifies the “dark side” of the heightened reflexivity demanded by late modernity. Confronted by a plethora of options (so that, in his memorable phrase, “one has no choice but to choose”) the individual shoulders the emotional burden of reflexivity: the struggle to know *what to do and who to be* in a post-traditional order. The same process that broadens choice also erodes authoritative guidance on how to choose. In Giddens’s view, the anorexic represents one extreme (yet perpetually possible) response to this predicament: a turn inward towards an intense disciplinary regime, where “compulsive mastery” replaces “authentic reflexive monitoring” (Giddens 1991: 107). The ease with which these categories could be invoked at a pricey business seminar, perhaps with the proclamation that “you’re either winning or you’re losing”, raises a deeper question about how social thought relates to common sense. Were these theorists articulating assumption “in the air” in an abstract vocabulary, or were they contributing to shape these assumptions? This possibility is another reason to examine the conceptual structure of epochal accounts, rather than merely discarding them as artefacts of a time that has passed. For example, such extremes of choice and compulsion can be seen today in digital self-tracking cultures, where reflexive monitoring can become a new form of compulsive mastery (Lupton 2016). These dichotomies persist in a manner which suggests a failure to directly come to terms with a dimension of the social world, oscillating in the face of complexity rather than gaining purchase upon it (Alexander 1987).

Giddens presents his version of reflexivity partly as a critique of other conceptualisations of human agency. He cites Lasch (1985, 1991) specifically but argues that a similar take on agency is shared by other authors who reach comparable conclusions, ones which Giddens deems inadequate. As he puts it:

[I]n the work of Lasch, and many others who have produced rather similar cultural diagnoses, one can discern an inadequate account of the human agent. The individual appears essentially passive in relation to overwhelming external forces, and a misleading or false view is adopted of the connections between micro-settings of action and more encompassing social influences.

(Giddens 1991: 175)

He thus seeks to underscore the *active* role of agents, which is at the heart of his structurationist view. For Giddens, the late modern subject is anything but passive before external forces. He proactively constructs his future through strategic conduct that pervades everyday life. If he fails in this, it is due to

compulsions that can, in principle, be overcome through earnest engagement with therapeutic expert systems. In his account, human agents never merely accept external influences, they constantly reflect on and reshape them through their actions. Although this does not figure explicitly in the detraditionalisation literature, his broader theoretical stance implies the degree of reflection involved will vary over different stages of modernisation. From his claim that agents actively reproduce and transform external forces, it follows that “it is not valid to argue that, while the micro-settings of action are malleable, larger social systems form an uncontrolled background environment” (Giddens 1991: 175). The remaining empirical question is how aware agents are of their role in modifying the wider environment, the “discursive penetration” concerning structural features which accompanies reflection. Such questions become especially pressing when individuals navigate algorithmic environments that seem to shape, but also be reshaped by, their daily actions (Bucher 2018). The opacity of these environments precludes certain knowledge of their structural influences while also inviting reflection, not least of all because one of the things users reliably do on social platforms is discuss the constraints and enablements of those very platforms (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 3).

These claims flow from Giddens’s structurationist perspective, which, as Mouzelis (1999: 94) notes, “tries to transcend the divide between objectivist sociologies (structural and structuralist) and subjectivist ones (interpretive sociologies)”. Giddens focuses on how practical human action reproduces structure in the mundane flow of daily life. However, his notion of the “duality of structure” implies denying any relative autonomy for both structure *and* agency: the former only becomes real when activated by human activity, while the latter only becomes real when structure is used to enable practice (Archer 1995: 101). Although structures are rightly recognised as dependent on human activity, Giddens frames this largely in *present-tense* terms, such that current structures depend on the actions of current agents, rather than highlighting the actions of past agents in shaping the structural environment faced by today’s individuals (Cruickshank 2010). This is what Savage (2021) dubs the *temporal ontology of modernity* embedded in Giddens’s view of agency: the historical link between present agents and past structures drops out. As a result, agents appear as a “contemporary, contingent agency that breaks from” past structures, or else become trapped by compulsions if modernity’s subject loses the existential efficacy Giddens attributes to him (Savage 2021: 191). The temporal character of our agency, coping with the past as we are orientated towards the future, finds itself reduced to a hyperactive presentism. It’s a sophisticated presentism but a presentism nonetheless, reducing the temporal extension of the subject into a path-dependent sequence, with important implications we will explore in the coming chapters.

Archer (1995: 117) contends that structurationist theory accommodates certain aspects of humans as *actors* (e.g. organisational role-playing and interaction dynamics) but not as agents or as persons. As a result, individuals are *over-socialised* in one sense and *under-socialised* in another. There are certainly virtues to the theoretical hybridity underpinning the account, developed as

part of a synthetic project which led Giddens to prominence through the early decades of his career. However, under such a view, it becomes difficult to see how collective agents might transform structures, or how subjects might develop any independent interiority, given that structures only exist through persons and persons seemingly only exist through structures. The process can seem aptly characterised but it leaves us wondering where the shifts and transformations which shape the direction of that process ultimately come from. Archer (1995) maintains that by refusing to separate structure and agency, structurationism effectively denies *both* their autonomy. It can point to an interface between structure and agency but cannot unpack it. It cannot investigate how this interplay evolves over time. As Kaspersen (2000: 162) observes, “the theory never produces a concrete analytical instrument with which to grasp the problem”. The outcome is a vacillation between voluntarism and determinism, with no clear indication of when one prevails over the other. While structurationism admits there is a crucial interface between structure and agency, it fails to offer genuine explanatory traction for analysing it. This is problematic in own terms but it would also leave us unable to grasp the specificity of digital platforms in the manner I’ll argue we urgently need to.

As we’ve seen, Giddens’s (1991) late modern subject toggles between two poles: pinned in place by self-generated compulsions (determinism) or seizing the future via instrumental rationality (voluntarism). The rather flat way Giddens discusses actual compulsions, more like a descriptive summary than genuine analytical purchase, reveals this conceptual flaw. For a thinker with such an interest in the psychic, his account is oddly devoid of the turmoil and excess which is such a defining feature of psychoanalytical theory and clinical practice (Fink 1999, 2017). Understanding such compulsions in a sociological register necessitates exploring how the individual’s context triggers them and how, in turn, they shape that context. Yet this is precisely what Giddens (1991) omits, an omission consistent with Archer’s (1995) critique, which gets to the core problem at the heart of structurationist theory. The tendency towards compulsion becomes a generic response to the challenges of the modern age, rather than being rooted in the specificity of their circumstances. The intermediate layers through which “global forces” come to influence “psychic life” are again missing, even if they are missing in a theoretically richer manner in Giddens than they were in Elliott and Lemert (2008). This gap becomes particularly important when consider new forms of compulsive online behaviour, illustrating the need for a theoretical framework adequate for sociotechnical change.

There is an ambiguous relationship between Giddens’s earlier and later work. Some have argued that his later writings mark a departure from the structurationist approach he developed in the 1970s and 1980s (King 2010; Ritzer 2007). Certainly, there are thematic shifts, and although a thorough textual analysis of these continuities and discontinuities is beyond our scope here, I would argue there are substantial continuities. Throughout this chapter, I have treated these two phases of his work as relatively consistent, partly in line with the principle of charity and partly because Giddens (1979, 1984)

displays a level of sophistication and rigour in philosophical debates that is absent in some of his later material. Furthermore, I believe the explanatory implications of structurationist theory are evident in Giddens's portrayal of human agency in late modern society, even if there are shifts in emphasis as his work develops. The core problem rests in structuration theory itself, rather than in the epochal twist introduced during the 1990s.

As mentioned, Giddens's dispute with theorists like Lasch (1985, 1991) hinges on the passivity they ascribe to human beings, limiting individuals to mere defensive adaptation. Yet Giddens himself acknowledges the possibility of such passivity, devoting considerable attention to the mindless compulsions too often characteristic of late modern life. Despite aiming to defend the reflexive capacities of human agents against critics like Lasch, Giddens nonetheless denies the efficacy of reasons compared to motives. He calls reasons an "on-going feature of action" that "all competent agents routinely 'keep in touch' with ... as an aspect of producing and reproducing that behaviour" noting they are "not definite 'presences' which lurk behind human social activity" but are instead instantiated recursively within that activity (Giddens 1979: 39–40). Motives, by contrast, are the "wellsprings of action" which "do not impinge chronically on action in the manner in which reasons do" (Giddens 1991: 63). This view makes reasons effectively incidental to action, an awareness or understanding that agents articulate in relation to their practices. Discrete intentions fold into a "continuous flow of intentionality in time", which can be reconstructed in deliberate statements, but only via a "background" of shared social practices, that is, "stocks of knowledge" (Giddens 1979: 40). Giddens sees individual agency as a "continuous flow of conduct" comprising the "causal interventions of corporeal beings in the ongoing processes of events-in-the-world", rather than a "series of discrete acts combined together" (Giddens 1979: 55–6).

Despite seeking to affirm human agency, and despite the strong liberal humanist impulse underlying his late modern writings, Giddens appears unable to take reflexivity fully seriously. While he emphasises the agent's capacity for action, his reliance on structural rules and resources means he doesn't ascribe any intrinsic property of agency to individuals as such. If reasons are collapsed into action, leaving motives to depth psychology, we are left with a vivid conception of practice which allows for nothing outside of it. The reflexive monitoring he attributes to agents remains secondary, embedded in practice and dependent on it. In this sense, individual reflexivity becomes akin to a steering wheel: it can adjust direction, but nothing more. Any articulated explanation of why or how one steers merely abstracts from the practical awareness in which Giddens situates reflexivity (Giddens 1979: 56). The rest is attributed to depth psychology, which certainly has a place in social explanation but not at the cost of social reflexivity. He describes his view of reflexivity as follows:

To be a human being is to be a purposive agent, who both has reasons for his or her activities and is able, if asked, to elaborate discursively upon those reasons (including lying about them). But terms such as 'purpose'

or ‘intention’, ‘reason’, ‘motive’ and so on have to be treated with caution, since their usage in the philosophical literature has very often been associated with a hermeneutical voluntarism and because they extricate human action from the contextuality of time-space.

(Giddens 1984: 3)

In his pursuit to “promote a recovery of the subject without lapsing into subjectivism”, Giddens commits something akin to the very philosophical error he attributes to structuralists: he superficially retains the “reflexive components of human conduct” while effectively reducing reflexivity to a “sort of epiphenomena of deeper structures” (Giddens 1979: 47). His formulation is indeed more dynamic than the structuralist subject-position, but it still leaves the individual oversocialised, lacking the possibility of being a truly self-originating locus of action. Those moments of distance, in which we can stand back from our lives and grasp their facticity rather than being tangled up in it, get lost on this picture. While Giddens successfully avoids a purely vanishing subject, he does so by subsuming agency under the duality of structure. Reasons either become part of the agent’s practical knowledge or end up as discursive material for interaction, with any notion of reasons as genuine causes of action largely abandoned. Meanwhile, motives, “the organisation of an actor’s wants”, are said to “straddle conscious and unconscious aspects of cognition and emotion” (Giddens 1979: 58). Under Giddens’s scheme, these causes of action reside below reflexive monitoring, with the real motivations often lying “‘outside’ the range of the self-understanding of the agent” (Giddens 1979: 59) and exerting a direct influence primarily in unusual or disrupted scenarios. They “supply overall plans [...] within which a range of conduct is enacted” but “much of our day-to-day conduct is not directly motivated” (Giddens 1984: 6). This framework would leave little room for analysing how users deliberate or modify motives in platform contexts, which I’ll argue in later chapters is crucial for understanding platform and agency.

Any notion that deliberation might proceed relatively independently, rather than being irrevocably entangled with the social, appears not just obscure but almost impossible within Giddens’s framework. In his ontology of the person, we find discursive consciousness, practical consciousness and unconscious motivation, but no deliberative consciousness existing autonomously from the discursive (Giddens 1984: 7). Although Giddens presents a stratified ontology with more theoretical depth than Elliott and Lemert (2008), it is still a stratified ontology of the agent (rather than, as realists might prefer, a stratified ontology of the *person*). He makes the cuts in different places, with important consequences for how people grapple with social and cultural change. Furthermore because Giddens views agency as intrinsically woven into structure, all pertinent features collapse into the duality of structure. For him, “human social activities ... are not brought into being by social actors but continually recreated by them via the very means whereby they express themselves as actors” (Giddens 1984: 2). As he explains, the “decentering of the subject” is “basic to

structuration theory”, and “social practices, biting into space and time, are considered to be at the root of the constitution of both subject and social object” (Giddens 1984: xxii). We may not be social all the way down, but the distinct powers of individuals mostly reside in depth psychology, especially the affective mechanisms that produce what Giddens calls “motive”. In his analytical toolkit, there are concepts tied to the duality of structure and separate psychoanalytic elements borrowed from other thinkers. Thus, any transformation at the individual level that goes beyond the duality of structure must be unpacked through psychoanalysis rather than within structuration itself. The psychic is invoked to account for what cannot be handled within his sociological register, in a manner which at points can feel as if it’s being used to fill explanatory holes that should be addressed. This leaves us lacking a framework for analysing how individuals develop or revise motives in *deliberate* ways, a gap that becomes crucial in platform-mediated contexts with their subtle balance of constraint and enablement.

Although Giddens’s account is far more sophisticated than that of Elliott and Lemert (2008), the same foundational defect appears: *insufficient ontological space between structure and agency* makes it impossible to analyse their interaction in a deep and substantive way. As Archer (2009: 9) notes (in agreement with Mouzelis), there is a “distance required between ourselves and our circumstances, which is necessary for reflexivity”. This gap is vital for studying reflexivity because, as Mouzelis (2008: 75) insightfully observes, “the way in which subjects relate to virtual or actual social structures is not constant but variable”. Yet the conceptual frameworks we have seen erase this empirical variability, reducing it to a narrow pattern embodying an underlying logic. A structuralist sensibility lurks behind the Giddensian subject, one worth dissecting, especially given how widely this concept has been deployed across various empirical fields. Rattansi (2014) similarly notes the poetic dimension of Bauman’s late modernity, in which symbolic characters often play out a kind of morality fable.

Unless we can conceptually disentangle structure and agency, we risk what Layder calls “conceptual singularities” and their “black holes”. As he puts it,

the argument that the social world can be represented by conceptual singularities means that the black holes that surround them ‘eat up’ large chunks of social reality and leave us with a severely impoverished, emptied-out vision of the social world.

In other words, approaches that claim to “transcend” the structure-agency dichotomy obliterate the empirical variability of how people navigate objective features of their social environment. The putative feature which negates the dichotomy (such as the duality of structure or habitus) consumes the empirical detail which was previously dichotomised. Layder suggests abandoning unifying principles in favour of “unpack[ing] and open[ing] up the explanatory range and power of social analysis” (Layder 2004: 8–9). These “conceptual black

holes” cause empirical variety to vanish into an assumed mechanism or logic spanning multiple contexts. At its worst, this produces what Pickering (2010) calls “ontological veiling” in which certain real-world phenomena become unrepresentable due to prior conceptual commitments. For example, how does one study *durable* “traditional” communities if one has declared by definition that anything so labelled is already in decline? The possibility of such a research object is denied from the outset by the conceptual framework. To the extent it can be constructed and stabilised this initial formulation will tend to lead to a superficial gloss on existing explanations, applied after the fact to provide a broader context for empirical findings. Such “black holes” become especially problematic if we want to understand evolving, stratified and relational phenomena such as everyday entanglement with digital platforms.

This literature raises evocative questions but it ultimately fails to answer them in an adequate way. Even though it identifies the interface between structure and agency, it cannot analyse such interactions in depth with collapsing these elements into each other. This means that substantive accounts of detraditionalisation tend to rapidly reach an impasse, unable to connect the general to the specific in non-platitudinous ways. Without the capacity to examine processes of change over time, we are left with either grand but empirically hollow claims about change or extremely specific examples deemed *illustrative* of these shifts. Yet these two sides are never joined: there is no concrete explanation of how one level’s change shapes that of the other, in order to account for meta-process in a way that incrementally links these examples together. Moreover, its reliance on structurationist theory leaves it subject to the weaknesses of Archer (1995) calls central conflation, even if this manifests in a slightly different way in this latter phase of Giddens’s work. In the following chapters, I propose an approach that addresses these questions by restoring temporal depth to agents and their interaction with social structures, which I argue is crucial for studying sociotechnical transformation and its implications for human agency.

While structurationist theory bypasses certain pitfalls in theorising structure and agency, like denying agents *any* causal power (economic and historical determinism) or denying structures *any* power (rational choice theory), it still commits a related error: merging structure and agency so thoroughly that, although an interface is acknowledged, concrete explanation becomes impossible. Archer (1995, 80) contends that the problem lies in not recognising the distinct time horizons of structure and agency. Even though there is an obvious truth to the “duality” of structure and agency (i.e. without agents and no structures exist), it does not follow that the two can’t be distinguished *analytically*. They can be ontologically interdependent without it being impossible to unpick actually existing instances of this interdependence in order to explain why they have unfolded in one way rather than another. Failing to acknowledge this distinction between structure and agency, especially their operation over different time intervals, blocks any meaningful investigation of their interaction, effectively compressing the moment of interplay into a single point. This prevents us

from specifying *when*, *why* and *how* structure is transformed or reproduced by human action. Consequently, Giddens must emphasise the “quintessential polyvalence of each ‘moment’, both replicatory and transformatory” without furnishing the analytical tools to explain the balance (Archer 1995: 89).

Despite the conceptual and empirical drawbacks we’ve noted, this literature captured attention across a diverse range of disciplines and fields of inquiry. Part of its appeal lay in its apparent capacity to explain how personal life is changing, continually posing the question: *what is it like to be a person now?* This urgency echoes C. Wright Mills’s idea that “the individual can understand his own experience and gauge his own fate only by locating himself within the period”, acknowledging how “by the fact of his living he contributes, however minutely, to the shaping of the society and to the course of its history” (Wright Mills 2000: 5). In practice, however, the effort to link what Wright Mills famously called “personal troubles” and “public issues” can falter when that interface remains theoretically incomplete. It’s not enough to gesture towards this connection, the real challenge lies in how we explain it. This empirical undertaking obviously relies on theoretical tools which can either facilitate or frustrate this process, leaving concept work with a deeply practical role to play in supporting the study of social change.

Dismissing this literature outright would overlook how it continues to inform present-day discussions. We can learn from its shortcomings, mindful of Smart’s (2007: 25) point that even broad, sometimes imprecise theorising can conceptualise large-scale changes and connect micro- to meso-level analyses, provided it adapts to fresh evidence. If these concepts appear irrelevant to platformisation at this stage, the coming chapters will illustrate how the questions they pose, on reflexivity and personal change, remain pertinent to our evolving sociotechnical landscape. While we should be wary of epochal language, I argue there is worth in holding onto an epochal *horizon*, meaning we stay alert to possible radical transformations in personal life and social organisation. Accordingly, the next chapter turns to formulating a more robust theory of agency more capable of clarifying how personal life and structural forces interact through sociotechnical change.

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3 The Realist Account of Reflexivity

What should I do? Who should I be? How should I live my life? Theorists of late modernity present these queries as core existential challenges posed by social and cultural change. Collective identities appear to dissolve, normative life courses unravel and existence becomes a do-it-yourself project in which we are forced to make choices that might once have been unthinkable (Giddens 1991; Beck and Beck-Gernsheim 2001; Bauman 2000). However, without a robust notion of personal reflexivity and personal change, these theorists cannot genuinely address the existential questions they themselves raise. Without a theory of the *concerns* which people develop and sustain, responding to but irreducible to their circumstances, there are simply no stakes attached to the choices they make (Sayer 2011). Elliott and Lemert (2008) bluntly concede this, claiming that “in current social circumstances... it is not the particular individuality of an individual that is most important” but rather “how individuals create identities, the cultural forms through which people symbolize individual expressions and desire, and perhaps above all the speed with which identities can be reinvented and instantly transformed” (Elliott and Lemert 2008: 53). Thus, the focal point becomes the form taken by serial reinvention and its implications for “globalisation”, ignoring the complex interplay of structure and agency through which these changes are constituted.

It’s a curious puzzle that theorists of individualisation rarely take individuality seriously. For instance, Bauman depicts a world where people passively reproduce commodification, shaped by “liquefying” economic forces operating almost deterministically. As Rattansi (2014: 909) astutely observes, “it is archetypes such as ‘strangers,’ ‘nomads’ and ‘vagabonds’ who populate Bauman’s world” rather than tangible individuals. Bauman’s narrative plays out like a morality tale, iterated across numerous books, some of which rely on extensive self-plagiarism (Walsh and Lehmann 2015). Giddens offers a slightly more substantial subject, yet one that is oddly divided between autonomously “colonising the future” or succumbing to mindless compulsion. Adams (2004: 393) calls Giddens’s depiction a “peculiarly arid picture of the processes we utilize to make sense of the world and of ourselves” casting us either as controllers of our fates or passive bystanders. This is a person who is normatively adrift,

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without the second-order properties which enable things to matter to them. Without such a constellation of concerns, future outcomes will not be personally meaningful (Archer 2000; Maccarini 2012: 109; Sayer 2011).

All the approaches critiqued here assume a zero-sum dynamic between traditionalism and reflexivity, such that less tradition means more reflexivity, yet they fail to consider how reflexivity might vary or how people's relations of concern anchor more or less enduring aspects of their environment. Hence, any "choice" offered by reflexivity under these accounts seems arbitrary, as Archer (2007: 37) suggests about Beck's model: "The decisions taken, and what reflexively went into their making, become uninteresting because they are given all the interest of people playing the lottery". These theorists raise significant and interesting questions while setting up their accounts in a way that makes it impossible to provide adequate answers for them.

Archer's Realist Alternative

In the previous chapter, we explored the shortcomings of Giddens's approach to agency, most notably the oscillation between voluntarism and determinism that emerges when his frameworks intersects with accounts of social and cultural change. This produces a troubling image of subjects vacillating between rational self-mastery and passive subordination to their circumstances. Such a viewpoint hampers our ability to see the myriad ways individuals can engage with their environments, across different people and within a single life-course. To move beyond these constraints, we must revisit the core question of *what* persons are and *how* they change. In particular, we must reject any model that neglects the "obvious multidimensional variability of the subject-object relationship" as Mouzelis (2008: 17) puts it, thereby obscuring how social change is inflected through *biographical* responses to it, that is, the accumulating consequences within an individual life, rather than a particular action they take at the present moment. This is precisely why Archer's (2007: 15) conception of reflexivity "as a personal property of human subjects, which is prior to, relatively autonomous from and possess[ing] causal efficacy in relation to structural or cultural properties" is crucial to this project.

In contrast to Giddens's conception of reflexivity as mere monitoring, Archer (2007: 4) defines it as "the regular exercise of the mental ability, shared by all normal people, to consider themselves in relation to their social contexts and vice versa". She frames this definition within her "three-stage model" of structure and agency, set against what she calls the "two-stage model". Under the two-stage model, "structural and/or cultural properties objectively shape the situations that agents confront involuntarily and exercise powers of constraint and enablement in relation to subjective properties imputed to agents and assumed to govern their actions" (Archer 2007: 15). Which subjective properties are assumed depends on the theory in question: vested interests in critical realism, instrumental rationality in rational choice, or habitus in Bourdieusian thought. By contrast, Archer's three-stage model

avoids imputing subjective properties to agents and instead allows for empirical variability. As she puts it:

structural and cultural properties objectively shape the situations that agents confront involuntarily, and *inter alia* possess generative powers of constraint and enablement in relation to subjects' own constellations of concerns, as subjectively defined in relation to the three orders of natural reality: nature, practice and the social' and that 'courses of action are produced through the reflexive deliberations of subjects who subjectively determine their practical projects in relation to their objective circumstances.

(Archer 2007: 18)

The two-stage model acknowledges the causal role of subjective deliberations but dictates their content via theoretical assumptions. It effectively "black boxes" reflexivity, treating it as a given rather than an empirically variable feature central to social explanation. Conversely, the three-stage model insists that such assumptions are, at best, empirical generalisations, which become less reliable as routine action proves inadequate in new situations. As Archer (2003: 133) notes:

This final stage of mediation is indispensable because without it we can have no explanatory purchase upon what exactly agents do. Deprived of such explanations, sociology has to settle for empirical generalisation about 'what most of the people do most of the time'. Indeed, without a real explanatory handle, sociologists often settle for much less: 'under circumstances x, a statistically significant number of agents do y'. These, of course, are not real explanations at all.

Archer's (2003, 2007) approach insists that sociological explanations depend on knowing *what* agents do and *why*. For these to be adequate, we need to comprehend the deliberations of real people. The two-stage model cannot deliver on this because it overlooks individuals' causal power to set their goals according to personal concerns and contextual circumstances. Instead, it treats agents' plans and reasons as a sediment of past contexts (*habitus*) or an *a priori* characteristic of the subject (*instrumental reason*). Archer's core claim is that subjects *actively* shape their pathways through the social world, though under conditions not of their own choosing. This power, she argues, belongs to the subject even if it is exercised continually in relation to objective reality. Structurationist methods, by contrast, fold it into the duality of structure and agency, yielding a thin sense of personhood tied mostly to depth psychology and self-monitoring.

Archer maintains that the individual remains a legitimate category of social analysis, while avoiding the idea the social can be reduced to micro-level phenomena in an *individualist* manner. Indeed, Alexander (1987: 258) notes that, "patterning exists outside of any specific situation" forcing the purely individualist stance into either "fantastic randomness" or "residual" references to the collective. In contrast, Archer (2007) supplies a framework to examine how that patterning

both constrains individuals and is reshaped by them, thus recovering the individual as a category without adopting an individualist ontology. In doing so, she provides microfoundations for social analysis without reducing society to nothing but micro-processes. There has been a tendency to frame Archer's work on reflexivity as abandoning her early macro sociology. See, for example, King's (2010) claim that Archer "moved from a structural orientation in the 1980s to a preoccupation with reflexive individual agent in the late 1990s and early 2000s". He argues that she moved from an "ontological dualism, in which structural conditions seemed to have been given the primary weight" to a subsequent prioritisation of "the autonomous self". It's such a weird misreading of her earlier work, with its focus on how the interaction between agents produces or transforms structure, that it's easy to see how the alleged flip could be imputed to her on this basis, in spite of the many pages of her later work which are an explicit critique of the position King is imputing to her. I suggest therefore we can treat such misreadings symptomatically, illustrating the conceptual difficulties which pervade discussions of the individual, as if invoking the category necessitates *individualism*.

Reflexivity proceeds through what Archer calls the *internal conversation*, in which "people talk to themselves within their own heads, usually silently and usually from an early age" (Archer 2007: 2). This dialogue comprises many activities, taking different forms for different people across the many situations they encounter. She identifies four main modes (*communicative*, *autonomous*, *meta-reflexive* and *fractured*) each arising from how a person's concerns intersect with their social context over time. These modes operate as a personal emergent property, with internal and external causal outcomes. While she argues that most people will have a dominant mode, each of us will tend to fall back on the other modes in at least some situations. The dominant mode shapes people's responses to structural and cultural circumstances, with important implications for their social mobility patterns, patterns of relating and propensity to engage in collective action (Archer 2007, 2012). The central claim is that "the interplay between people's nascent 'concerns' (the importance of what they care about) and their 'context' (the continuity or discontinuity of their social environment) shapes the mode of reflexivity they regularly practice" (Archer 2007: 96). Unlike standard socialisation theories, Archer posits that even children actively evaluate their social environments; these evaluative engagements, as well as the relational contexts in which they unfold, contribute to the development of their reflexive capacities as they move into adulthood. As social change intensifies, "there is less and less to normalize", so the traditional "agencies of socialisation" become largely nominal: "socialization can no longer be credibly conceptualized as a largely passive process of 'internalization'". This "relative absence of authoritative sources of normativity" leads young people to "reflexively assessing how to realize their personal concerns in order to make their way through the world" (Archer 2012: 96–97).

Communication reflexives rely on close friends and family, "similar and familiar", to finalise and validate their internal deliberations. While anyone

may occasionally externalise inner thoughts, communicative reflexives do so habitually, *needing* these familiar interlocutors to reach definitive conclusions which they can commit to with confidence. This means they require relationships with “people who can understand and enter into the subject’s concerns and preoccupations to such an extent that they can complete and confirm their friend’s tentative thoughts by their talk together” (Archer 2012: 147). Where no suitable interlocutors exist, communicative reflexivity becomes unsustainable, since it repeatedly depends on others to move from tentative ideas to concrete decisions. Depending on how intensely it’s relied upon, this reflexivity can forgo “the inner speculative freedom to envisage the mid-term and long-term scenarios which could unfurl from following a single ‘first reaction’” (Archer 2007: 274). Because it requires continuous dialogical closure, the individual’s reflections typically align with shared normative horizons, grounding them in a particular relational context which provides enough overlapping “mental furniture” to turn private musings into mutually meaningful conversation.

Autonomous reflexivity arises when contextual discontinuity undercuts the shared commonalities required by communicative reflexivity, forcing individuals back on their own internal resources. They may still share thoughts with others, but unlike communicative reflexives, this sharing is primarily for information gathering or retrospective discussion, rather than co-producing decisions. Biographical factors influencing the development of autonomous reflexivity will tend to include moving frequently or experiencing fragmented family relations. Yet as with communicative reflexivity, the roots of autonomous reflexivity lie in the relational quality of one’s natal environment. Archer (2012) suggests these contexts lack both the relational harms found among fractured reflexives and the relational goods typical of communicative reflexives. Unlike communicative reflexives, who invest in their early settings and replicate cherished elements, autonomous reflexives lack coherent background messages to reproduce, creating a tendency towards independence.

Meta-reflexives consider their decisions in terms of the ethical, social and/or political commitments that fundamentally shape their lives. At some point, they absorbed an ideal or principle from their context, using it to filter new experiences which creates a contextual incongruity (as opposed to the contextual discontinuity of autonomous reflexivity or the contextual continuity of communicative reflexivity). This incongruity emerges when their personal commitment clashes with “an incongruity between what they would become – their aspirant vocation or the preconditions for it – and their social context, which impeded its realisation” (Archer 2007: 155). Rather than normalising the social order, meta-reflexives problematises it, producing a tendency towards vocation over mere career. Accordingly, they often exhibit occupational volatility rather than the upwards mobility of autonomous reflexives or the relative immobility of communicative ones.

Fractured reflexives struggle to maintain a functional internal conversation. Their self-deliberation often heightens distress and confusion instead of guiding them from subjective concerns to practical plans. *Impeded* fractured reflexives show a marked leaning towards a specific mode, which might evolve into a stable pattern under the right circumstances. *Displaced* fractured reflexives once practiced a given mode but were knocked out of it by circumstances that erased its supporting conditions. By contrast *expressive* reflexivity denotes a lack of any sustained pattern, relying on “gut feelings” and intuition to deal with daily challenges. This results in a more episodic life trajectory and a lasting inability to exercise agency over one’s life situation.

It could be objected here that social factors *must* be internalised into dispositions to wield real influence, that is, the social must get “inside” us in order to exercise an influence. This is certainly the thrust of the argument made by a critic such as King (2010) in his accusation that Archer is preoccupied with the “autonomous self”. However, rejecting internalisation as a universal principle does not deny that constraints or enablements *sometimes* operate this way, it merely refuses to treat it as an absolute, a priori rule. Without that caveat, we cannot explain why similar individuals respond so differently to the same circumstances and opportunity costs. Structural deterrents remain empirical patterns, and citing personal properties or powers to account for why certain people do or don’t accept these costs is not voluntarism, it’s merely non-deterministic. As Archer (2007: 18–22) notes, “we are fallible, can get it wrong and have to pay the objective price for doing so”. Recognising the force of structural and cultural factors does not oblige us to assume they are always internalised. Much of our own deliberation would be inexplicable if we denied the “large tract of life in which things do happen to us involuntarily, such as our initial social placement, the life chances ‘assigned to us’, and the opportunity costs attaching to various courses of action” (Archer 2003: 75). These unchosen realities do not erase reflexivity, in fact they are its *content*. They are what people grapple with as they make their way through the world, in a manner more variable and multifaceted than existing sociological accounts of agency have done justice to.

From early development onwards, we sift pleasant from unpleasant, desirable from undesirable, forging a first-order emotional awareness that soon raises questions of compatibility or incompatibility. In the process we begin to orientate ourselves to what *matters* to us, even if our articulation of this remains partial, fallible and subject to revision (Archer 2000; Sayer 2011). Over time these orientations become sounding boards, shaping our (internal) responses according to whether new stimuli “[resonate] harmoniously or discordantly with what we care about most” (Archer 2012: 22). This intensifies path-dependency because the development of our evaluative orientations in response to novelty guides our future trajectory: some possibilities are “shunned, repudiated or negatively sanctioned” while others are “welcomed, encouraged or positively sanctioned” (Archer 2012: 23). This is essentially a *selective* trajectory, a

progressively patterned way of filtering variety, an iterative becoming of who we are. As we move through the world, we acquire a direction and style that we misrepresent if we depict it as an endless confrontation with “a plurality of uncertain life course options”, a “reflexive project”, or individuals “continuously forced to organise the future and reconstruct their own biographies” (Mills 2007: 67–68). Such a picture overlooks how past experiences accumulate, shaping present orientations to future possibilities. These changes matter to us in fundamental ways, as a particular person with *these concerns* who has *led this life* emerges from the broader space of potentiality afforded by our social and cultural circumstances.

If we assume internalisation as a uniform and necessary dynamic we miss a crucial dimension of personal–social transformation: *the temporal sequencing of constraints and enablements*. If we imagine persons as fixed while depicting social change as dynamic, we inevitably misrepresent them both. The internalisation thesis disproportionately highlights a single temporal relation through which structural and cultural forces exert influence (the conditioned “me” confronting present circumstances) while disregarding what the realist approach argues are the other two temporal relations. Recovering these nuances for the purposes of biographical analysis demands we examine how both *relationships* and *ideas* exercise causal power throughout an individual’s life course.

The Causal Power of Relations

Relations have long been central to sociology, but in recent years their importance has been reasserted from multiple perspectives. Social network analysis best illustrates this trend, generating extensive empirical findings that show how “different patterns of connection generate different opportunities, constraints and dynamics for those connected in them, both generically and according to the actor’s specific location in the pattern” (Crossley 2010: 14). With a diverse and rich history, social network analysis partially arose as a critique of “variables sociology” which commonly uses a priori socio-demographic categorisations in a manner that be vacuously generalising (Scott and Carrington 2011). Instead, network analysts shifted attention to “relations or links between units” advancing an inductive explanatory programme on how structured interaction patterns shape social outcomes (Degenne and Forse 1999: 1–3). In doing so, they confronted the classic macro/micro and holist/individualist divides, albeit unevenly across a broad literature that lacks a single theory of social networks (Donati 2010: 92). Crossley (2010: 13–14) describes this confrontation in terms of substantialism, which he sees as the fundamental problem of both holist and individualist sociology:

The holist envisages society as a given, a pre-constituted entity or ‘substance’ with an underlying and determinate essence which can be invoked to explain what happens within it. They treat ‘society’, ‘capitalism’ or whatever as something which somehow lies beyond or behind the relations

and interaction which instantiate and which explain those relations and interactions [...] The holist fails to see that society is constantly in the making, always becoming, that it is wholly dependent upon what happens within it for its identity, form and existence [...] Individualism, especially in its ontological form, is no less substantialist than holism, focused as it is upon ‘the individual’ as a supposed underlying bedrock of social life [...] the irreducibility of interaction, the significance of networks and their centrality to sociology suggest that our basic unit of analysis is not or at least should not be individuals but rather structures of interaction [...] the individual is not the most basic unit of social life but rather a unit too basic to capture much that is most significant about the social world.

A clear parallel can be seen here between Crossley’s critique of substantialism and Archer’s (1995) critique of upwards and downwards conflation. Relational sociology, as Crossley (2010) describes it, accurately flags how reductive approaches deny autonomy to either the parts or the whole. Identifying a problem with the ontological commitments made within holist and individualist accounts is one which realists endorse enthusiastically (Smith 2010: 232). But certain relational sociologies perform what Sayer (2004) calls a “PoMo flip”: inverting a problematic stance in a way that sustains the conceptual structure which created it. In this case, critiquing the prioritisation of *substance over relations* instead leads to a prioritisation of *relations over substance*. In the process we lose our grasp on the interaction between the two, particularly as these unfold over time in contexts shaped by these interactions.

But what *are* relations? For Crossley (2010) relations are “lived trajectories of iterated interaction”. As he puts it “to say that two actors are related is to say that they have a history of past and an expectation of future interaction and that this shapes their current interactions” (Crossley 2010: 28). Such relationships are path-dependent, each with its own history, encompassing “the sedimented past and projected future of a stream of interaction” (Crossley 2010: 35). In this sense relations have a shared, though contestable, past. The relation has its own history of emergence, apprehended internally by each party, which can be understood subjectively or intersubjectively: “we can and do tell stories about our relationships, for example, relating how we met and what events we have been through together” (Crossley 2010: 36). Our own history, as beings orientated towards others, carries the traces of past relations within it:

Relations can become latent in the sense that we no longer interact with another on the basis that we once did. But relations can never be undone. If John and Jane part ways and do not meet for 25 years, they will still meet as two people who knew each other 25 years previously. Time is irreversible and though they go through ups and downs and may change radically, so too, therefore, are relationships. We cannot return to a point where the other is unknown to us.

(Crossley 2010: 35)

Archer (2014: 160) contests this is a transactional sociology in which “relations” are reduced to patterns of interaction, denying the reality of relations *in themselves*, beyond the empirical actions associated with them. They are treated as iterative interactions and the narratives people construct about them. Although these narratives are crucial to describing relationships, Donati and Archer (2015) argue we must also attend to the relational bond: its origins, reproduction, changes and possible dissolution (Donati 2010). Without this it is difficult to clarify interaction patterns, the interpretations actors give them, and the stories built around them. We risk attributing excessive voluntarism to actors, which can slip into monadism when intersubjectivity is sidelined by an overemphasis on individual interpretation.

For this reason we should reject a view that relations are simply *constituted* through repeated interaction, rather than reproduced or transformed. The claim is not the outlook of a relationist like Crossley is inaccurate in its own terms, but rather it obscures the context of those patterns of interaction in a problematic way. Crossley, for instance, claims that

[m]uch of our interaction in everyday life and much of our interaction in situations involving conflicts of interest is interaction with others with whom we are likely to interact on an indefinite number of occasions in the future, that is, others with whom we have relationships.

While it’s true that most one-shot interactions are “relatively infrequent and usually trivial” (with rare but notable exceptions), “[t]he vast majority of our meaningful interaction is with neighbours, family members, colleagues, friends and associates” (Crossley 2010: 60) and precisely this ubiquity and meaningfulness cry out for explanation. This is the substance of our life and content of our reflexivity, the bonds which give existence meaning and keep us up at night worrying when things are going wrong.

What makes these relations “meaningful” and significant? Simply citing their recurrence risks circularity, using the outcome (ongoing interaction) to explain its own causes. It leaves unexplained *why* these interactions occur so often, or how some relationships drift into the background only to re-emerge later. The key question is what prompts a particular set of individuals to maintain “a history of past and an expectation of future interaction” that “shape[s] their current interactions” (Crossley 2010: 28). Crossley himself acknowledges the necessity of such an explanation, without which interaction appears “either a random and inexplicable happening or the caused effect of something preceding it” (Crossley 2010: 112). Yet in challenging substantialism, he contends that “interaction is a whole greater than the sum of the separate individuals who constitute its parts”, leading to actors who are “entangled within it to the point of inseparability” (Crossley 2010: 32). While this may capture the psychodynamics and phenomenology of certain relationships (e.g. romantic or parent–child bonds) everyday life also involves repeated interactions not marked by that sense of inseparability. Furthermore, the psychic complexity of these

relationships is not an adequate basis for characterising their social ontology. There's an important sense in which I am entangled with my most significant others in a way that is constitutive, that is, I cannot fully understand who I am without understanding my relationship to them. But where this entanglement precludes separability, we would tend to regard this as pathological as in popular notions of "co-dependency" and their more precise, though not unproblematic, clinical corollaries.

The claim Crossley is making is not wrong, so much as that it's an overstatement which we need to treat extremely carefully at the level of social ontology. Just as many accounts of reflexivity overlook the variable distance between subject and object (and thus underestimate what that means for their relationships), this prominent way of theorising relations overlooks the variable distance between subject and subject. If inseparability is intrinsic to interaction, we lose purchase upon the psychological and sociological significance of how this inseparability demonstrably does vary at an empirical. I spoke more frequently with a barista in the coffee shop by my office last week than I did with my parents. However, if I were to never interact with him again it wouldn't trouble me, whereas obviously if I were to never speak with my parents again it would. This is such a banal observation that it can feel uncomfortable to make but it's precisely this level of quotidian experience which the realist approach to reflexivity can help us recover. The degree to which we are entangled within our relations self-evidently varies.

How do we account for this if we construe it as an "inseparability" *intrinsic* to interaction, rather than a contingent outcome of a particular pattern of interaction and the *bonds* which have emerged through it? He recognises that purposes have a role in explaining interaction but the logic of "inseparability" means these must also be an outcome of interaction, leaving us unable to distinguish explanandum (what needs explaining) from explanans (the explanation). The problem is not purposes in themselves but the absence of anything beyond interaction to which people direct those purposes. This is precisely where "relational goods" come in, which, as Archer explains,

have the generative tendency to create bonds and interdependencies at the empirical level amongst the persons involved that denote more than 'good interpersonal relations'. They indicate something in excess of a degree of warmth and some regularity of contact. That 'something' refers to emergent properties, namely 'internal goods' (such as love, reliance, caring and trust) that cannot be produced by aggregation and are also deemed highly worthwhile in themselves.

(2012: 99)

Adopting relational goods in Donati and Archer's (2015) sense does not neglect interaction but rather qualifies its significance. It introduces a new explanatory object that can clarify why interaction patterns converge or diverge, the meanings participants derive, and the shared narratives they build. The relational

goods (and evils) young people encounter in their natal environment are integral to their evolving connection to the social world and to the reflexivity that emerges in the process (Archer 2012). Situated interaction undeniably shapes these relations, unfolding within home, school, neighbourhood and so forth. But it is the relations themselves, as much as the interactions reproducing or changing them, that exert causal impact on personal biographies. It's a matter of both/and rather than either/or in a manner we will unpack in greater deal in subsequent chapters.

The Relationality of Culture

In their empirical investigation of American middle-class moral life, Bellah et al. (1985) compellingly illustrate how the cultural resources available to individuals influence the trajectory of their lives. The terms through which one reflects on life's ultimate aims, and how they might be pursued, profoundly affect the direction each life takes. As Bellah et al. (1985: x) state, they "wanted to know what resources Americans have for making sense of their lives, how they think about themselves and their society, and how their ideas relate to their actions". Through this study, they sought to illuminate "the tension between how we live and what our culture allows us to say" (Bellah et al. 1985: viii). Yet despite their vivid empirical depiction of cultural resources, their conceptual understanding of such resources remains underdeveloped. It is sophisticated in parts but lacking a crucial dimensions concerning personal reflexivity. They develop the notion of "languages", which they define as "modes of moral discourse that include distinct vocabularies and characteristic patterns of moral reasoning" (Bellah et al. 1985: 334). These "languages" belong to what they call "culture", referring to "those patterns of meaning that any group or society uses to interpret and evaluate itself and its situation" (Bellah et al. 1985: 333). While Bellah et al. focus on analogue cultural resources, we can see how "languages" also proliferate in platform environments, with communities coalescing around moral and political questions (Carrigan 2011). In fact the contribution platforms make to the generation, circulation and encounter with such "languages" will be a crucial feature of my argument in the book's second section.

Although their network of concepts might be incomplete, Bellah et al. (1985) are hardly incoherent. Their strength lies in spotlighting the interpretative resources available to individuals, viewed as deliberative moral agents, at any given historical moment. This adds variability to interpersonal relations, since each actor brings different cultural assets to the narrative co-construction Crossley (2010) describes, including resources they might accrue independently, even as their relationship continues. New relations are shaped by the distinctive cultural items we bring to them (knowledge, worldview, beliefs, tastes, sensibility, etc.) as "baggage" already accumulated, often involving past relations. Existing relations are enriched, forced to change and sometimes disintegrate as a result of the complementarity or tension of the interpretive resources accumulated by each party, in spite of the "inseparability" posited by Crossley (2010).

Consider, for example, the implications for families of being drawn into online conspiracy theories, documented by Cook (2024) in a powerful work of journalism. It's an extreme example but it illustrates how an individual accumulating new interpretive resources, in this case relating to the QAnon conspiracy theory, can entirely transform their entire network of relations.

What Bellah et al. (1985) introduce here, the interpersonal variability ensuing from distinctive patterns of interpretive resources, will be crucial to the argument I am developing. It brings an important dimension to interaction, recognising how we have the distinctive ideational patterns which condition our relations, as well as how we reflexively orientate ourselves to ideas in a manner shaped by relational encounters. The orientation we adopt towards future cultural encounters is shaped by the evolving interactions themselves, as our experiences lead us to highlight certain features and be drawn to certain questions. As people engage with others, new issues arise, prompting them to seek ideas (directly or indirectly) from the cultural milieu in a manner which will then feed back into relational patterns. The time-bound character of how relations and ideas intersect is central to the realist approach: a dynamic that has profound implications for digital life, the focus of the second half of this book. For now, it suffices to note that the narratives Crossley (2010) describes do not spring up *ex nihilo*, but rather draw on a cultural repertoire that actors develop *partly* outside the confines of the relationships in which that repertoire is ultimately deployed. If the ideas people rely upon are developed *wholly* within the context of a set of relations, enabling nothing from the outside to be incorporated, we would be talking about a "cult" in the academic sense of the term (Stein 2021).

It could be argued that Bellah et al. (1985) proceed in an implicitly realist mode, distinguishing between the *cultural resources* and the *contingent ways particular subjects use them*. However, there are conceptual ambiguities which create problems when trying to deploy the distinction in a more explicitly realist way. The main ambiguity stems from Bellah et al.'s failure to theorise explicitly how cultural resources link to the *situated* use subjects make of them, creating a paradoxically structuralist slant in their analysis, despite their professed focus on moral agency. Though they note different "languages" dominating various participants' cultural environments, they do not clarify how these forms are *filtered* by individual capacities. How are the languages drawn upon by people in different settings, in ways that reflect their specific biographies and context? Unless we can answer these questions then individuals appear as if locked inside the moral logic of a given language. While Bellah et al. do affirm agential capacities (recognising the diachronic significance of a synchronic gap between what a person *wants* to say and what cultural resources *allow* them to say) that affirmation remains almost purely abstract. It's unclear how these "languages" vary in practical usage, how they first emerged, or how they might transform over time. Even if they acknowledge these "languages" arose in a specific historical moment, there is minimal room for novelty. Similarly we might ask how new digital "languages", such as online vocabularies and social media norms, arise, transform and mediate individual expression in ways Bellah et al. did not

anticipate. Under these circumstances the individual capacity to find and appropriate cultural novelty takes on an unprecedented significance, simply because it is a ready-to-hand possibility in a new way.

Bellah et al.'s acknowledgement that people's cultural resources can prove insufficient for their moral needs is a crucial observation. In doing so they expose a vital dynamic underpinning progressive cultural critiques: a culture may stifle or diminish individuals, restricting their aspirations and hindering them from becoming who they could be. Yet the strong cultural politics shaping their project leave them fixated on the inadequacy of the individualist languages they discuss, overlooking how these languages might also enable (rather than merely constrain) some forms of agency, particularly when contrasted with more collectivist vocabularies. As a sociologist born in the year the book was published, it was hard not to feel like I have been constitutively shaped by exactly the tendency they are critiquing. As a leftist millennial it's hard not to mourn a collectivist horizon which has faded from view but, qua sociologist, I'm conscious of what a more individualist horizon as enabled for me as well. If we accept Taylor's (2007) warning about "subtraction stories" then we need to insist on looking for what has been opened up when we encounter a narrative that is purely about loss and closure.

The problem arises because, lacking a theory of constraint or enablement, Bellah et al. (1985) cannot fully detail how these languages function *synchronically* in specific projects of articulation, nor how they shape an individual's *diachronic* biographical course. How does the language constrain and enable my agency in this present moment? How has this causal influence shaped the unfolding of my biography over time? These questions are crucial if we are to account for how these micro-cultural dynamics contribute to macro-cultural outcomes: how the existential adequacy (or lack thereof) of cultural forms at the individual level shapes, and is shaped by, broader sociocultural change. Admittedly, one could call this critique unfair, since they never intended to offer a complete theory of cultural mediation. Nonetheless, highlighting these conceptual gaps underscores a dimension of cultural agency that is frequently overlooked, one crucial to this book's argument, particularly regarding how digital platforms mediate access to cultural novelty and the significance of this for socialisation processes.

Porpora (2003) explores a similar dynamic in his account of "resources of the self". He proposes that identification with certain political or demographic groups is a well-studied case of how individuals draw upon culture to articulate their unfolding sense of self (Porpora 2003: 238). Likewise, concepts like "calling", "journey" or "quest" can clarify life's continuity and aims. Porpora also examines less everyday phenomena, such as astrology or tarot, which for one of his interviewees, provide "a device for the self-reflexive monitoring of her life" (Porpora 2003: 240). Examples like this emphasise the need to explicitly affirm that culture is more than propositional content, the latter being only a subset of the wider cultural domain in which logical relations hold, always potentially relevant to the subject's concrete circumstances (Archer 1988). For

instance, Marsh and Roberts (2011) show how internal conversation and music fandom intersect empirically. Although music's meaning for an individual isn't reducible to cultural resources, it still constitutes a form of engagement shaped by the dominant reflexive practice in that person's life (Marsh and Roberts 2011). The inner world of many fans is saturated by lyrics, tunes and experiences appropriated from a trajectory of engagement with their favourite bands. This is a dimension of digital life which the second half of the book will seek to recover and open up in a systematic way.

The suggestion here is that culture as a whole, the potentially intelligible contents of the multimodal archive, compose what the pragmatist Peirce once called "booty" (Archer 2003). I will argue that "signs, symbols and languages given to us through paperbacks, soap operas, chat shows, docudramas, film, video, self help manuals, therapy workshops, music videos and the like" stand as "the resources from which we tell our stories" (Plummer 1995: 137). These resources are the raw materials enabling our inner lives to assume form and texture, letting us creatively respond to daily challenges. But if we reduce social relations to a quasi-constitutive entanglement, we risk overlooking how cultural repertoires shape the meanings that emerge *from* interactions, as well as the narratives individuals form around them. Recognising the ideational dimension of reflexivity is crucial, since reflexive processes behind biographical development use descriptions that are, at least partially, unique to each subject. As Archer (2000: 238) writes of prioritising one's concerns, "this is done in their own conversational terms (i.e. under their own descriptions) and it is intrinsically fallible, yet corrigible". This raises critical questions: how do these particular descriptions constrain and enable the shape and substance of someone's reflexive deliberation? Do they produce different levels of fallibility and corrigibility within those processes? While it's clear that these ideational raw materials matter, explaining precisely *how* this relation works in practice proves more challenging. In a platform environment access to this multimodal archive expands dramatically, intensifying the opportunity for reflexive identity construction while creating new challenges. This renders these conceptual questions more urgent than ever.

In a thoughtful investigation of how we connect with cultural objects, Bollas (2013) highlights their role in fostering personhood. The responses these objects evoke help us discover the "underlying 'I'" that acts back upon us, refining our subjective reality. Bollas argues that "[c]ertain objects, like psychic 'keys' open doors to unconsciously intense – and rich – experience in which we articulate the self that we are through the elaborating character of our response" (Bollas 2013: 17). These chosen objects (or perhaps, in some sense, objects that have "chosen" us) can "release us into intense inner experiencings which somehow emphasize us". They become routes into our interiority through external engagement. He describes "a form of lifting, as encounters with objects lift us into some utterance of self available for deep knowing" (Bollas 2013: 29).

This underscores how we might treat culture as objects of reflexivity, not merely external commodities (such as buying a concert ticket) but an element

in our world *through* which we become ourselves. In this category fall the books, films, music and art that deeply matter to us. Bollas (2013) provides a conceptual language for grasping the depth of that mattering, wherein the relationship with a cultural object (and the changes we undergo through it) can be partly constitutive of who we are. Nonetheless, it remains a relationship with something outside us, distinct from the cultural elements we internalise into our *inner world* which contribute to the form and content of our deliberations. These two dimensions help illustrate how we reflexively engage with cultural forms. The digital environment hosts many such objects, with the potential to radically pluralise Bollas's "keys", to the point of complicating and unsettling previously familiar psychosocial mechanisms. Later, we'll see how algorithmic filtering shapes which cultural objects become available for reflexive self-discovery, with often difficult and sometimes destructive consequences.

Meaningful activity is invariably "mediated by interpretations of the action environment coloured by actors' past experiences and self-understandings" shaping both the reflexive formulation of projects and subsequent action paths (Gross 2019: 260–3). Acknowledging the part cultural resources play in this mediation helps us avoid voluntarism, serving as another vector through which the past constrains the present: a corrective to the constant self-reinvention motif in detraditionalisation theory. The cultural resources we have appropriated in this way, which by definition *matter* to us, cannot be easily aside if they become inconvenient or undesirable. The person I am is partly constituted by the bundle of influences I have cobbled together over my life heretofore, furnishing my inner world in a manner which can be reviewed and revised but always from the starting point of being this person with these ideas.

These issues remain insufficiently theorised within realist theory. Their neglect might reflect what Al-Amoudi and Willmott (2011) identify as a broader tendency in critical realism to downplay epistemic relativism: paying "lip service to a stance that, in practice, is mobilised to brush off" critics of realism (Al-Amoudi and Willmott 2011: 39) rather than fleshing out its conceptual implications. Although their analysis pursues different aims, their assertion that "concept dependency implies more than a mere acknowledge of fallibility" (Al-Amoudi and Willmott 2011: 34) has important implications for the present argument. We must therefore consider the substantive implications of epistemic relativism, as Lawson (2003) usefully articulates below, to see how ideational influences function as independent variables in the unfolding of each person's biography:

[O]ur categories, frameworks of thinking, modes of analysis, ways of seeing things, habits of thought, dispositions of every kind, motivating concerns, interests, values, and so forth, are affected by our life paths and socio-cultural situations, and thereby make a difference in how we can and do 'see' or know or approach things, and indeed they bear on what we seek to know.

(Lawson 2003: 162)

This claim should not be seen as deterministic, in the Whorfian sense that language dictates cognitive boundaries. As Archer (2003: 69) clarifies, “our reliance upon the public domain of culture for thinking can be upheld, without this determining what we do with it – that is the content of our mental activities” (Archer 2003: 69). Approaching reflexive cultural meditation in this manner sensitises us to the historical emergence of each individual’s life path. This shift allows us to move from broad potentially deterministic declarations about ideational influence to more empirically nuance claims about *conditioning*. External cultural objects of attachments (resources of the self) and internalised cultural raw materials (cultural resources) represent two avenues through which past experience shapes our present action, affecting how we perceive, deliberate and respond to the environments we encounter.

Navigating the world entails internal conversation, especially as late capitalism amplifies individual choices, placing myriad practical and existential questions on our daily agenda (Archer 2012). At the same time, because we are irreducibly social, we engage in external dialogue too, continually accounting for ourselves and managing how others account for us (Hacking 2002). In each setting, we draw on cultural resources (categories, metaphors, analogies, etc.) that both constrain and enable our attempts to articulate or expand our lived reality. Reflexivity thus involves cognitive and cultural affordances (Mutch 2004, 2007): each can loom larger or smaller at different points in an individual’s life, exerting significant causal impact on how their biography unfolds. Digital platforms intensify this interplay, furnishing new categories and modes of encounter which shape how individuals articulate experience and reflexively respond to their circumstances.

Our ability to interpret our own experience is conditioned by both *resources of the self* and the *cultural resources* at our disposal. We rely on these resources when “modelling our options, internally, so we can visualise the choices that lie before us” (Wiley 2006: 14), shaping the decisional premises (conscious or otherwise) that guide our deliberations (Mouzelis 1995: 113). These cultural resources carry their own histories of emergence and exert a relatively autonomous power, influencing how individuals selectively use them as they navigate their biographies. Cultural resources may also be deliberately created with reflexive individuals in mind, modes of mobilisation which become increasingly significant in a digital environment. For example, Mouzelis (2010: 272) notes “the phenomenal spread of ‘self-help’ or ‘do-it-yourself’ manuals” which advise subjects on achieving both external aims, such as accumulating economic or political capital, and internal ones, such as boosting self-confidence. Likewise the surge of management consultancy and business coaching outlined by Thrift (2005) can be read similarly: “business fads” reveal a pragmatic orientation towards the role of cultural resources and reflexive technologies in organisational life. A political economy of reflexive technology is clearly at work, underpinned by a thriving industry that produces, circulates and popularises these materials (Thrift 2005: 147). The scope of this political economy has expanded vastly in the influencer economy, as strategic conduct becomes a

ubiquitous response to the opportunities for influence which present themselves across social life (Hund 2023). As we shall see in the ensuing chapters, the role of these cultural resources raises new questions about how reflexive agents access, interpret and deploy them.

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4 Biography as an Ontological Category

Over the preceding chapters, I have contended that Anthony Giddens's influential account of detraditionalisation, viewed here as the prime example of a broader scholarly trend, raises pivotal questions about social transformation and how it shapes the lives of reflexive individuals. However, it also displays fundamental deficiencies, traceable to deeper issues within structurationist theory, which significantly undermine its usefulness when deployed within empirical research. This shortfall is concerning, given the longstanding appeal of this theoretical framework to researchers across a range of sub-disciplines and fields. Despite its analytical shortcomings, I suggest it remains valuable at the level of sensibility, how we perceive and respond to social change, even though it falls short as a comprehensive tool for analysis. Its sensitivity towards meta-process is analytically important even as the framework itself hinders attempts to grasp that overarching transformation in a robust and analytically useful manner.

I propose a biographical approach that treats persons as socially situated and temporally extended processes of becoming, rather than simply individuals in a static sense. This strategy aims to separate the “individual” as a persistent meta-category in social thought from the *individualism* that often saturates it. My approach resonates with a wider biographical research tradition, which experienced renewed interest around the time I began this study. See, for example, Chamberlayne, Bornat, and Wengraf's (2000) notion of a “biographical turn”, partly motivated by dissatisfaction with mainstream sociological models of agency. Although we should be cautious about rhetorical “turns”, which have proliferated ad nauseam in recent decades, it is still worthwhile to consider the intellectual convergence they are seeking to name, representing a gathering of diverse perspectives rather than a tight-knit movement. This biographical lens will help us examine how digital experiences contribute to a person's ongoing *becoming* rather than reduce them to atomistic users or data points.

Unfortunately, this biographical perspective has often followed a Giddensian approach, holding that an apparent “detachment from traditional ideas, values, norms, beliefs, and ideologies generates greater individual autonomy and freedom of choice for individuals to shape their lives” (Mills 2007: 65). This leaves individuals “continuously confronted with a plurality of uncertain life course options” such that life becomes a “reflexive project” and “individuals are continuously

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forced to organise the future and reconstruct their own biographies in light of rapidly changing information and experiences” (Mills 2007: 67–8). Such an account yields a strongly individualistic notion of biography, where the subject appears as a decision-maker in an environment that seems progressively less constraining. By contrast, I aim to develop a biographical model emphasising relationality rather than portraying the subject as a spatially and temporally mobile monad (Brock and Carrigan 2015). Decisions undoubtedly matter for how one’s biography unfolds, but it is crucial to see that *what* is being decided upon precedes the *act* of deciding. The entire process remains contextual and in motion, shaped by our “thrownness” into a world we did not choose (King 2001: 171). This embedded quality of biography is key to a realist conception of life course and biography, understood as two distinct aspects of our temporal extension.

Reflexivity and the Lifespan

In the previous chapter, I contrasted Archer’s (2003, 2007) idea of *reflexivity-as-deliberation* with the *reflexivity-as-monitoring* model common in detraditionalisation literature. According to Archer, reflexivity can manifest in four distinct modes (communicative, autonomous, meta-reflexive and fractured) with most adults showing one predominant style but engaging in all modes to varying degrees across different contexts and life stages. Recognising this internal diversity in reflexive life, both across individuals and within any single lifespan, breaks open a conceptual space closed off by the central conflation typical of detraditionalisation theory. This new space enables us to examine the causal routes by which structural and cultural forces shape reflexive practice, as well as how these varying forms of reflexivity feedback to either reproduce or transform those social conditions.

Archer (2003, 2007) situates these issues within three core concepts; *contextual continuity*, *contextual discontinuity* and *contextual incongruity*. Her primary assertion is that “the interplay between people’s nascent ‘concerns’ (the importance of what they care about) and their ‘context’ (the continuity or discontinuity of their social environment) shapes the mode of reflexivity they regularly practice” (Archer 2007: 96). Rejecting the logic of many socialisation theories, she contends that even young individuals proactively evaluate their surroundings. Both this evaluative process and the specific features of their environment shape their emerging practice of reflexivity as they move into adulthood. However, with social change intensifying, “there is less and less to normalize” and the traditionally invoked agencies of socialisation come to stand as cyphers: “socialization can no longer be credibly conceptualized as a largely passive process of ‘internalization’”. This “relative absence of authoritative sources of normativity” means “young people are increasingly thrown back upon reflexively assessing how to realize their personal concerns in order to make their way through the world” (Archer 2012: 96–7).

Archer frames this development around “three significant moments that can be distinguished as phases of the life-long internal conversation: discernment,

deliberation and dedication” (Archer 2007: 20). The **discernment** phase centres on the “reflective, retrospective and prospective” identification of what we deem to be worthwhile. During this stage, individuals reflect on their past, present and future actions, weaving the “reflective, retrospective and prospective through a dialogue which compares and contrasts them” (Archer 2000: 233). It is an “inconclusive moment of review” which clarifies “our reigning concerns” by surfacing what satisfies and troubles us about our present life (Archer 2000: 235). Essentially, discernment operates as an existential stocktaking, whereby we fallibly gauge the concerns emerging from our current situation.

The **deliberation** phase transitions from a broad review to a more specific evaluation, as we assess the consequences of backing or pursuing the concerns we identified. This step features a “very provisional ranking of the concerns with which a subject feels that she should and can live” (Archer 2007: 20). We explore how our concerns intersect, from discarding certain projects entirely to tentatively endorsing others (Archer 2000: 236). Often this entails “a visual projection of scenarios seeking to capture, as best the subject is able, the *modus vivendi* that would be involved, whilst listening to the emotional commentary that is provoked and evoked when imagining that particular way of life” (Archer 2007: 20). Platforms can provide the *objects* of such deliberation as well as the *medium* for it through the reflection and conversation which their use elicits.

The **dedication** stage marks the processes’s conclusion, when the subject determines “not only whether a particular *modus vivendi* is, in her view, worth living, but also whether not she is capable of living such a life” (Archer 2007: 21). At this stage, concerns are solidified, and the corresponding way of life often demands letting go or reordering any incompatible priorities. Crucially, this entire process is both temporal and provisional, as Archer (2003) underscores:

[T]here is a life-long dialectic between objectivity and subjectivity because circumstances can change (necessarily or contingently) and so can we (again necessarily), as we move through the life cycle, and contingently because we can reassess our concerns.

(Archer 2003: 141)

These three-phase DDD movements are *real* in that each stage involves generative mechanisms, activated according to the subject’s powers and those of their social context, that propel individuals forward. However, each project we invest in requires social and self-knowledge, which remain fallible and subject to revision whenever circumstances or the self evolve. The practicalities of such knowledge are rendered even more complicated by the epistemology of the platform environment, as we’ll explore in later chapters. This explains why real-world reflexivity is messy and particular, spurring continual re-evaluation and re-commitment as both we and our contexts transform. This is something which Archer (2003, 2007) underemphasised in the earlier phase of the reflexivity project, developing greater sensitivity in response to the later encounter with what she termed *expressive* reflexivity (Archer 2012). Differentiating these stages does not

downplay that messiness; rather, it provides a structural map. It helps us dissect the temporal dimension of agency, clarifying how we respond to changing conditions and how these responses shape our biography over time. Although each life has idiographic complexity, the mechanisms underlying it rest on varying links between subjective concerns and objective social and cultural factors.

Various factors spanning different social domains account for this ideographic complexity, and we must address them specifically to avoid “drifting into an unacceptable monadism or slipping into Beck’s portrayal of subjects’ capricious and serial self-reinvention” when analysing reflexivity (Archer 2012: 97). Doing so clarifies what Archer calls the *necessity of selection and shaping a life*: the unavoidable requirement to choose among options we encounter throughout the life course, along with the challenges of forming a coherent and enduring way of living from these choices. Crucially, “selection” and “variety” should not be misunderstood as purely detached choices. Instead, they arise from a path-dependent expansion of our evaluative stances towards new possibilities. My reaction to present circumstances emerges from the past contexts I faced, how I reacted then, and how I changed in the process. Ultimately, this is how we *become who we are*, through cumulative engagements with the world, rather than behaving as monadic actors endlessly reinventing ourselves as we move through time and space. As we’ll see in later chapters, digital platforms complicate and accelerate these path-dependent processes, as online traces mean our past choices are more likely to linger on in the present.

As we develop by reacting to our environment, discerning the pleasant from the unpleasant and the desirable from the undesirable, we become conscious of our first-order emotions, which pose compatibility questions that prompt deeper reflection on what we value (Archer 2000; Sayer 2011). We first exist as beings with such concerns, only later recognising ourselves as such, so that these evaluative stances serve as “sounding-boards, affecting our (internal) responses to anything we encounter, according to it resonating harmoniously or discordantly with what we care about most” (Archer 2012: 22). It’s not just that things matter to us but rather that we come over time to know ourselves as people for whom these particular things matter (Frankfurt 1988). This further tightens path dependency: as we refine our evaluative positions in response to novel situations, we shape our future direction, shunning or repudiating some prospects while welcoming and positively sanctioning others (Archer 2012: 23).

This trajectory of selectivity reflects how our evaluative stances filter life’s variety in increasingly patterned ways. Even impeded or displaced fractured reflexives exhibit a discernible structure, albeit one that may be truncated. An expanding array of biographical outcomes does not necessarily imply a destructuring of social life; rather, it signals changing patterns in how people respond to their surroundings, driven by deeper forces. As we traverse the world, we acquire a direction and style that cannot be reduced to a simple iterative encounter “with a plurality of uncertain life course options” such that life becomes a “reflexive project” and “individuals are continuously forced to organise the future and reconstruct their own biographies in light of rapidly changing information and experiences” (Mills

2007: 67–8). This characterisation might capture the superficial appearance of our biographies but it fails to grapple with the deep structure that explains the shape of the lives we lead.

Reflexivity and Character

Reflexivity depends on both self-knowledge and social knowledge. Although purely expressive acts do occur, such instances are understood by Archer to be relatively uncommon, even if there are reasons to consider that digital platforms are leading them to become more commonplace. In most reflexive actions, we inevitably draw upon understandings about our distinct capacities and powers, even if these remain tacit or inarticulate unless triggered by specific situations. Our actions are informed by a sense of *who we are* and *what we can do*, even if we are rarely moved to express this understanding in a discursive manner. Our deliberations rely on such a fallible impressions of our concerns, abilities and limits. At the heart of this process lies *character*, understood in a neo-Aristotelian vein as embodied habits of thought and action (Flanagan 2007; Franklin 2010; Sayer 2011; Smith 2003, 2010). Character, in this sense, serves as a non-deterministic concept of socially oriented dispositions; ways of acting oriented towards others, rather than dispositions strictly rooted in the natural or practical domains (Archer 2000: 132). Such dispositions exist within the subject and push them towards particular ends (Archer 2000: 140), yet they do not operate pre-reflexively. They guide how experiences accumulate, shaping who we become through our interactions with the world and how these encounters transform us. Our experiences, particularly in childhood, strongly shape our character; a view Sayer underscores with evidence from developmental psychology:

It depends on the quality of care and the formation of supportive attachments that both protect and nurture the development of responsible autonomy. The experience of being valued, cared for and loved - or being neglected, abused and unloved - shapes how we value others and our relation to self, and hence our ability to relate to others and form mutually beneficial attachments.

(Sayer 2011: 148)

Attachment theory provides a thorough and nuanced approach to these ideas, explaining how natal dependence influences later attachment patterns, without assuming that early relationships mechanically determine adult behaviour. As Bowlby (1988: 73) explains

A principal means by which such experiences influence personality development is held to be through their effects on how a person construes the world about him and on how he expects persons to whom he might become attached to behave, both of which are derivatives of the representational models that he built up during his childhood.

(Bowlby 1988: 73)

Notably, while attachment theory uses a psychological register, its claims can readily be framed in reflexive terms, where mental processes link self and context. This underscores how reflexivity bridges psychological and sociological domains, inviting insights from both disciplines. We can extend this recognition to online attachments, treating them in ways which bridge the divide between (cyber)psychology and (digital) sociology (Lupton 2014; Selwyn 2019). In this light, attachment theory demonstrates how natal relationships spur reflexivity, as our evaluative stances shape tendencies that, in turn, transform both self and circumstances. Hence, as Mouzelis (2008) suggests, we must acknowledge the internal constraints and enablements (an “internal environment of action”) while still upholding reflexivity’s ontogenetic importance in forming personhood (Archer 2012: 98–101). Recognising that natal ties are formative does not discredit reflexivity but rather prompts deeper investigation into the objects of early reflexive engagement.

Although character can be shaped through reflexive deliberation, such awareness is both fallible and retrospective. This is not to suggest character is non-cognitive or removed from reflexive projects, for our internal conversations often revolve around who we are, especially among meta-reflexives who question their motives and potential transformations. These formative influences typically become something we aim to grasp or even overcome, illustrating our capacity to view ourselves as objects of inquiry, beyond the pragmatist take on self-reflection prompted by problematic circumstances (Elkjaer 2009). Sayer (2011: 133) captures this dynamic vividly:

We may intermittently ‘take stock’ and evaluate our virtues and vices, or more simply our character ... We may feel we must be more assertive, more outgoing, less lazy, etc., and try to change ourselves through repeated practice in the hope that we become habituated to acting in these ways, so that it becomes ‘second nature’. This can be difficult not only because of the inertia of our existing embodied dispositions but because it may fail to bring the hoped-for effects and positive feedback.

When we deliberate about our character, we often launch self-care or self-improvement projects. These ventures are reflexive because they emerge from reflection on subjective concerns and objective conditions, yet they also explicitly aim to transform the person undertaking them. Crossley (2004, 2006) usefully investigates a subcategory of such self-projects related to exercise and “reflexive body techniques” (RBTs). He warns against treating these as purely instrumental endeavours: the pursuit or maintenance of physical fitness can intersect with other motives, such as social engagement or simply “letting off steam”. Still, these projects fuse reflexive and bodily dimensions, as Roseneil (2007: 92) observes: “psychic conflict and distress could not straightforwardly be banished through the reflexive address of a rational internal conversation. Mental states were frequently and effectively shifted by somatic or relational practices, when attempts at cognitive reorientation failed”. Thus, our relationship of care, or its

absence, towards ourselves generally spans the mental, affective, and corporeal. Such practices frequently interweave these aspects, either stated (e.g. a weight loss goal) or diffusely recognised (e.g. establishing routines which are emotionally comforting). This is a rich field of digital activity which increasingly constitutes an enormous international market, built around the digital mediation of self-improvement projects (Lupton 2016). The influencer economy facilitated by social platforms plays an increasingly dominant role in mediating this market (Hund 2023).

Crossley (2005) elaborates the concept of RBTs, showing how reflexivity and embodiment can be analytically distinguished. His research on RBTs uncovered near-universal adoption of basic daily routines (e.g. handwashing, tooth brushing and bathing) suggesting that an even broader scope might reveal more. Notably, these RBTs entail *maintaining* rather than *transforming* the body. Yet historical shifts in such practices, or patterns within groups, cannot be explained purely by each individual's natural or practical drives. Moreover, as Crossley (2005) proposes, distinguishing reproductive bodily techniques from those pursuing transformation clarifies how each type is distributed, whether at the individual or population level. This may be recast in terms of morphogenetic (transformative) and morphostatic (maintenance) projects, of which bodily changes are just one possibility. In each case, the concern bends back on the subject, confirming its reflexive nature, even if the relevant practices are not always explicitly deliberated, though they may have been at some earlier point.

Although projects stem from deliberation, their eventual success or abandonment partially reflects the internal conversations that preceded them, yet they also achieve a measure of autonomy over time. New motivations may arise, or goals might shift as one acquires fresh personal goods which become objects of concern. Equally, as the project unfolds, so does the person who began it, meaning that someone pursuing a goal under particular assumptions may change significantly along the way. This is especially true for therapeutic projects tackling one's inner life: that "work" changes us as we do it. At times, the goal may be negative, removing constraints, rather than pursuing a specific outcome (Mouzelis 2010). It's striking to consider how much social reflexivity is assumed by clinical practice, even if the dominant thrust of psychoanalytical theory entails a hermeneutics of suspicion which tends to (epistemologically) dissolve reflexivity. But identifying a "symptom", ultimately the responsibility of the analysand rather than the analyst, as well formulating the project of entering analysis requires a sustained trajectory of reflexivity. This is not a cheap or easy undertaking, particularly when it is pursued consistently over years with all the possible interruptions and tensions involved in keeping to such a commitment (Fink 1999, 2017).

Even if modifications are minor, their possibility remains integral to what self-project involves. Attempting to transform the self only makes sense given some perception of constraints on that transformation: people start "self-work" with at least a vague or flawed sense of who they are and what needs

changing. This recognition involves a fallible view of our “embodied capacities, susceptibilities, needs and concerns”, central to our drive for “flourishing or suffering” (Sayer 2011: 120; MacIntyre 1984). While character channels or restricts us in the present, shaping inclinations that may either hamper or help us, it also concerns the future. The self we believe ourselves to be is inherently tied to the self we hope to become.

Possible Selves

Any self-work project, however, loosely defined, presupposes some notion of a desirable change. Yet our sense of temporal extension, who we *might* become and who we *wish* to become, extends beyond self-work in a narrow sense. The concept of *possible selves* provides a productive lens for unpacking this future dimension, as Stevenson and Clegg explain:

Possible selves are future representations of the self including those that are desired and those that are not. They can be experienced singly or multiply, and may be highly elaborated or unelaborated. They may relate to those selves we desire to become or those we wish to avoid. Possible selves play both a cognitive and an affective role in motivation, influencing expectations by facilitating a belief that some selves are possible whereas others are not and, by functioning as incentive for future behaviour, providing clear goals to facilitate the achievement of a desired future self, or the avoidance of a negative one. More significantly the possible selves construct holds that individuals actively manage their actions in order to attain desirable selves and evade less-desirable selves. As representations of the self in possible future states, possible selves give form, specificity and direction to an individual’s goals, aspirations or fears. In other words, elaborated possible selves influence the development of specific strategies for action, focus an individual’s activities, give direction in the pursuit of these goals and energise the person to achieve them. Not unsurprisingly research has shown that those with highly developed career-possible selves are more motivated, goal orientated and energetic than those with less or unelaborated ones. These individuals are a lot more likely, when confronted with a threat to the possibility of achieving a desired career-possible self, to either persist with their goals and strategies or develop new career-possible selves.

(Stevenson and Clegg 2011: 19)

Reflexivity invariably involves future orientation, even if it manifests as a mere dismissal of the future’s importance. Wiley (2006: 9) suggests that “if we attempt to foresee the various paths along which we might go, we can clearly see what is right for us”, emphasising the practical impetus rooted in our human condition. Confronting an array of decisions, each tied to different life “issues” we naturally project ourselves into varied potential selves, some clearer

or more laden with significance than others. Such decision points arise so persistently that they may seem trivial, appearing in daily routines or across the steady passage of time. Yet our attempts to take stock of our actions reveal intricate repercussions stemming from our own and others' choices, as well as the countless ways these choices interlock, thereby placing genuine "control" of our lives ever beyond reach. Even the most stable existence brims with predicaments about what to do and who to be. In platform environments, these potential selves are increasingly mediated by online content and interaction, with the potential to dramatise our choices in new and efficacious ways.

Building on their empirical work Stevenson and Clegg (2011: 23) observe that

when we begin to look in more detail at the trajectories and at how past, present and future relate and at how constraints both continue to impact on choices, particularly in relation to locality and place, we can see how different forms of reflexivity account for the ways participants are envisaging their futures.

Not only does reflexivity shape how individuals picture their potential futures, it also influences how they pursue or avoid those imagined paths. In other words, it's not merely how they conceive possible selves, but how they act, or fail to act, towards them. Brannen and Nilsen's (2005) study of young people's varied temporal outlooks illustrates one way the possible selves concept might be put into practice. It's a concept which has been operationalised across an enormous range of studies, bridging the gap between ontology and methodology in an effective manner.

The ongoing interplay between a past "me", a present "I", and a future "you" (Archer 2003: 108–16) unfolds in a richly idiomatic way, with linguistic resources taking on their own personal connotations. Even when our internal dialogues display a certain articulacy, we are not bound to be "dispassionate conversationalists" because "words themselves can be infused with passion" and they "depend upon the nonverbal images they summon-up" Archer (2000: 231). This idiomatic quality of our inner speech fosters varying degrees of clarity. Occasionally we can articulate our thoughts with satisfying precision; more often we cannot, and the shift from inarticulate to articulate may be pivotal in how we transform over time. As Taylor explains:

[I]t is quite a common experience for us to feel remorse without being able fully to articulate what is wrong about what we have done. In these cases we may seek to understand further. And if we succeed, our feelings may alter. The remorse may dissipate altogether, if we come to see that our sense of wrong doing is unfounded; or it may alter in other ways, as we come to understand what is wrong; perhaps it will be more acute as we see how grave the offence was; perhaps it will be less as we see how hard it was to avoid.

(Taylor 1985: 63)

Taylor's anecdote underscores that such experiences cannot be reduced to mere serial self-interpretations. The subject of interpretation also evolves, so this is no protean self endlessly reinventing itself but instead a prolonged and dialectical process. By its nature this is messy yet retains a certain unity at the ontological level, if not at the epistemic one. The sequence of self-interpretations shapes how we respond emotionally, sometimes intensifying or alleviating remorse. While our feelings might change through deliberation, it is not a simple Rortian process of redescription in which we switch through successive vocabularies (Bhaskar 1989). As Taylor puts it, "the attempt to articulate further is potentially a life-time process. At each stage, what we feel is a function of what we have already articulated and evokes the puzzlement and complexities which further understanding may unravel" (Taylor 1985: 65). He goes on to offer an evocative example:

Thus consider someone who has been ashamed of his background. This is what we say (and also he says) retrospectively; at the time, this was not at all clear to him. He feels unease, lack of confidence, a vague sense of unworthiness. Then he is brought to reflect on this. He comes to feel that being ashamed for what you are, apologizing for your existence, is senseless. That on the contrary, there is something demeaning precisely about feeling such shame, something degrading, merely supine, craven. So he goes through a revolution like that expressed in the phrase 'black is beautiful'. Now the shame disappears; or sinks to a merely residual unease like the craving for a cigarette after meals of the ex-smoker; and is judged as merely another such nagging emotional kink, not as a voice telling him something about his predicament.

(Taylor 1985: 69)

Considering such a revolution highlights two temporal horizons at once: *past habits affecting present judgments*, and *present judgments influencing the person we might become*. While Taylor treats such change in relative isolation, it is easy to imagine embedding this evolving individual in a broader social setting, where external circumstances shape present evaluations and, in turn, those evaluations transform future contexts. Consider, for example, how the self-conception of an early career academic can shift as they move through multiple institutions, particularly if they might cross disciplines in the process. The first half of this book aims to develop a conceptual model of these internal relations, one that we will then apply to how people negotiate digital platforms in the second section of the book. Taylor's concept of "conceptual revolutions" has overly cognitive implications but it captures an important feature of the moments that shape who we are. Next, I will examine Giddens's influential notion of fateful moments to see what further insight it provides in order to construct a more robust and realist conception of biography.

Fateful Moments

A central feature of Giddens's (1991) expanded view of reflexivity is his concept of *fateful moments*, which appears to connect biographical narrative and social transformation in a way that underscores individual agency (Holland and Thomson 2009). Giddens defines fateful moments as "those when individuals are called on to take decisions that are particularly consequential for their ambitions, or more generally for their future lives". In his schema, much of life is either non-routinised or non-consequential ("free" time we "kill") or routinised and consequential (where "difficult decisions may often have to be taken" but are usually "handled by strategies evolved to cope with them"). By contrast, fateful moments are non-routinised yet consequential. Giddens explains how "these are 'times when events come together in such a way that an individual stands, as it were, at a crossroads in his existence'" including instances like deciding to marry, taking exams, selecting a career path, going on strike, switching jobs, receiving major medical news, or encountering large financial gains or losses (Giddens 1991: 112–13).

At these junctures individuals might consult "abstract systems" to "help in risk assessment" because "fateful decisions are usually almost by definition difficult to take". These are "moments when the individual must launch out into something new, knowing that a decision made, or a specific course of action followed, has an irreversible quality, or at least that it will be difficult thereafter to revert to the old paths" (Giddens 1991: 113). This inherent difficulty, Giddens suggests, explains why pre-traditional societies often leaned on ideas of fortune or providence: fateful moments overflow with potential consequences, weighing heavily on anyone who grasps their significance. However, "in so far as conceptions of *fortuna* are completely abandoned" the individual must rely on the "assessment of risk" because "at fateful moments, the individual is likely to recognise that she is faced with an altered set of risks and possibilities" and at such times "she is called on to question routinised habits of relevant kinds, even sometimes those most closely integrated with self-identity" (Giddens 1991: 129–31). Invariably, fateful moments prompt us to reassess our character: understanding who we are, how we arrived here and what it means for the crossroads we face. This draws out the features of fateful moments that most concern the present project: objectively changing circumstances and the identity work that results as we strive to handle these changes. Yet the concept itself harbours several complexities.

A core problem with the concept concerns how Giddens distinguishes between fateful and non-fateful moments. Fateful moments appear as rare junctures where reflexivity reshapes life, while the rest is portrayed as large swaths of existence in which reflexivity is minimal and affect dominates (Plumridge and Thomson 2003). As Adams (2004: 393) aptly describes it, Giddens paints a "peculiarly arid picture" of how we interpret ourselves and the world, one in which life becomes either dramatic or mundane, without

sufficient attention to the role of concern in even the most quotidian tracts of our lived experience. Rather than acknowledging affective, second-order responses, we see individuals either seizing reflexive control or surrendering to chance (Archer 2000; Taylor 1989). This binary is phenomenologically suspect, given that people can simultaneously feel confident mastery *and* existential anxiety. Consider, for example, a skilled professional who feels mastery over their craft while still wondering if this is how they want to spend the rest of their life. They might be plagued by a sense of pointlessness while still being utterly attuned to the practical challenges of their work. The way Giddens conceives of agency betrays a fantasy of total agency in one instance and the trauma of disempowerment in the other, leaving little room for the everyday middle ground (Craib 1994). It is particularly curious from the perspective of psychoanalytical practice where a failure to find energy and animation in everyday life, to “enjoy their enjoyment”, frequently constitutes a symptom which leads subjects to seek analysis (Fink 1999, 2017). From a Lacanian perspective the restriction of fatefulness to isolated moments would be seen as a form of mortification, an escape into “fixed compulsive rituals”, rather a routine feature of lived experience (Žižek 1997: 113). This split between fateful and non-fateful takes treats the libidinal economy of the (neurotic obsessive) subject as if it were a feature of their social environment, in the process obscuring the variety which characterises psychic structure just as it obscures the variety which characterises reflexivity.

Such an arid portrayal stems logically from Giddens’s sparse ontology, which overlooks second-order personal emergent properties. The result is a Giddensian subject who either rationally controls events or fatalistically yields to them, lacking any normative anchor beyond these extremes. The individual is simultaneously caught in affective “intimacies of the self” and risk analysis of “distant happenings” yet without the emergent web of personal concerns that lend real weight to future outcomes (Archer 2000; Maccarini 2012: 109; Sayer 2011). This creates an implausible image of a person who “rationally separates out the world into things he or she can control, and things he or she cannot control” (Adams 2004: 393), possibly influenced by Giddens’s (1991) engagement with popular self-help literature (Atkinson 2010: 33). It is striking how the rich, if not unproblematic, psychoanalytic engagements of his earlier work were replaced by engagements with self-help literature in this later work. Furthermore, the approach here clashes with Giddens’s earlier arguments, since risk assessment presupposes “the possibility of actors distancing themselves from roles and resources in order to view them strategically”, precisely what structurationist theory disallows (Mouzelis 1995: 118–25).

In a longitudinal qualitative study, Plumridge and Thomson (2003) attempted to operationalise the concept and found it initially appealing for its “dynamic” character and apparent ability to “make sense of the process of change at a biographical scale”. Yet while it provided “an interesting starting point and some useful tools” it eventually became “unsatisfactory both for descriptive and explanatory purposes” (Plumridge and Thomson 2003: 221).

The complexity of real lives, especially over extended timelines, often stretches beyond the analytical bounds of such models. Plumridge and Thomson (2003: 217) note that “qualitative material exposes the limitations of such individualized explanatory models, pointing to the importance of processes rather than isolated moments, and to collective resources rather than simply to individual resourcefulness”. This also highlighted “the provisionality of the kind of identity work that is captured in this method” revealing how an event that once matched Giddens’s definition of a “fateful moment” could appear far more messy when revisited later.

In a subsequent paper, Thomson argues that the concept’s emphasis on individual choice “obscures relationships, investments and the wider power structures that might constrain choice in practice”, creating a tendency for researchers working within the model to take “professions of agency at face value” (Holland and Thomson 2009: 459–64). Consequently, efforts to understand “times when events come together in such a way that an individual stands, as it were, at a crossroads in his existence: or where a person learns of information with fateful consequences” (Giddens 1991: 113) risk devolving into voluntaristic readings of participants’ responses. This underplays contextual constraints and enablements, focusing mainly on the subject’s retrospective framing. In other words, the subjective sense of fatefulness offers a deeply unreliable yardstick for objective impact, further complicated by the self-centring tendency of autobiographical narration. There’s clearly a crucial role for such narrative in qualitative research but we need to recognise the epistemological complexity of it, particularly when seeking to work in a longitudinal register.

Many of the challenges noted by Holland and Thomson (2009) and Plumridge and Thomson (2003) arise from an actualist bias in the fateful moments concept: it centres on events *as experienced* by the subject, often neglecting the deeper causal structures behind them (Bhaskar 1978). This bias appears when Giddens switches between “fateful circumstances”, “fateful moments” and “fateful decisions” or in his claim that such moments are “formed” of “episodes” wherein a “particular situation or episode may be both highly consequential and problematic” (Giddens 1991: 112–14). The intent here is not to fault Giddens for loose phrasing but to show how fuzzy the concept becomes when we attempt to pin down specifics. Are these “circumstances”, “moments” or “decisions”? Do they consist of “episodes” or “situations”? Or is there an additional mechanism that “forms” a fateful moment? The temporal vocabulary (“moments” and “episodes”) obscures the fact that time itself is not treated as a variable a broader issue within structurationist theory (Archer 1995: 89). The intuition we should preserve is that biographies are non-linear and uneven: not all points matter equally for shaping the life course. The problem is construing this in a narrowly phenomenological manner, particularly without accounting for the range of psychic structures which can underpin these features of experience. The experience of fatefulness can be intense, and certain biographical episodes do carry more weight than others. But if we rely on naive self-narration, we risk conflating that subjective sense with the actual, objective significance of an event.

The conceptual problems with fateful moments go hand-in-hand with methodological weaknesses when we put the concept into practice.

From a textual standpoint, fateful moments align closely with Giddens's (1990, 1991, 1992) overall narrative of late modernity, being the chief intersection between "intimacies of the self" and "distant happenings" (Giddens 1991: 4). Yet that very tidiness amplifies the explanatory gaps encountered when researchers try to apply the concept empirically. If it is employed post-analysis to contextualise data within a macro account of social change, the outcome often merges macro and micro perspectives into an amalgamation rather than a rigorous explanation. It provides evocative themes through which findings can be narrated, rather than analytical instruments which can contribute to explaining why things are so rather than otherwise. If, on the other hand, we invoke it during the analytical process, the concept's many operational shortcomings can undermine our findings. Giddens's discussion of circumstances, decision-making, risk assessment, expert systems, and self-projects tends to collapse into a loosely connected cluster, lacking clarity on how these elements unfold in actual "fateful moments". Once we try to pin it down empirically, fateful moments prove distinctly slippery. This actualist inclination is not unique to Giddens; his work merely helped popularise fateful moments. A comparable bias arises in Palmer, O'Kane and Owens (2009), who employed the idea of "turning points" in their study of first-year university transitions. They define a turning point as:

For the purposes of this study, a turning point is defined as an event(s) or an experience(s) in the first six to eight weeks at university that stands out, and which triggers and results in the student developing (or not) a sense of belonging to university life. There can, therefore, be individual differences in the experience of the turning point, including the development before the transition, the timing of the transition for the individual, the individual's experience of navigating the transition, and the context in which the transition occurs.

(Palmer, O'Kane and Owen 2009: 41)

The challenge mirrors that of fateful moments. Because "stand out" events are labelled retrospectively, the inquiry veers into an actualist mode: only the subject's pre-classified "turning points" get studied. Despite the creative methods used to contextualise and interpret participants' accounts, two distinct questions become conflated: the "turning point" itself and its subjective significance. The issue is not that researchers rely on participants for data, obviously fundamental to qualitative research, but that these "turning points" hinge entirely on the subject's self-recognition of them as such. Some reported turning points might be less consequential in objective terms than participants claim, while truly pivotal shifts may remain obscure until one has the benefit of hindsight, if they emerge at all.

Still, biographical researchers do need some concept that serves a parallel function, especially given the practicalities of qualitative interviews. Most of what happens in a participant's life before the interview will inevitably be mundane; from the perspective of the research questions, while certain portions will be particularly significant. Distinguishing the latter from the former poses two main hurdles: (1) it's impossible to cover every event in detail and (2) it's unclear how to classify events as mundane or significant. Tools like "fateful moments" or "turning points". Aim to isolate the key stretches of a life story to probe further. They are analytical devices that intend to help provide a focal point for a complex research object. The critique here is not the ambition itself, but the conflationary way it often proceeds, treating objectively pivotal events as identical to subjectively labelled moments. Consequently, these reported turning points or fateful moments become the default unit of analysis, echoing the troubles noted by Plumridge and Thomson (2003). Merging subjective narration with objective biography at the ontological level inevitably spawns methodological issues, most glaringly in longitudinal studies. When returning to interview participants, we see how self-narration shifts, exposing a bigger dynamic that would have remained hidden in a one-off interview. We need to begin with self-narration but we should never end there. When we rely on the participant's retrospective depiction of an event, pinpointing the multiple causal forces shaping it becomes difficult. The resulting approach to "fateful moments" or "turning points" can easily take participants' "professions of agency at face value" (Holland and Thomson 2009: 459–64), and avoiding that pitfall often occurs *despite* rather than because of these concepts.

This problem is magnified by what Furlong and Cartmel (2006) term the "epistemological fallacy of late modernity" in which ever-more individualised self-interpretations are prompted by experiences with their roots in social structure. Essentially, "fateful moments" operate on a narratological level, picking out "fateful" markers in personal stories to explain a seemingly linear biographical course. It invites the interviewee to tell stories. While stories can certainly include material factors that lend themselves to realist analysis, these narratives are ultimately retrospective attempts to interpret an objective chain of events and how the subject responded (Plummer 1995). Emphasising how stories arise from the interview context is not a criticism of interviewing itself, but rather a reminder that we must acknowledge this generative dynamic in our methods (Savage 2013; Law and Ruppert 2013). It's only a problem for qualitative research if we fail to engage with it in a (methodologically) reflexive way, which is exactly what these concepts make difficult through their epistemic weaknesses.

An alternative analytical route calls for two additional concepts: *psychobiography* and *personal morphogenesis*. The former conceptualises what actually emerges from "fateful moments" and their more ordinary counterparts, insisting that repeated reflexive cycles shape a life as it unfolds: how a person navigates the world and changes in doing so. Presenting these concepts also concludes the first section of this book, after which the framework of personal morphogenesis will be deployed to interpret the digital transformations overtaking

social life. In the second section, we'll see how psychobiography and personal morphogenesis help avoid a tendency towards causal overstatement in claims about digital change, focusing on underlying shifts in the *parameters* of choice rather than the outcomes, of those choices. Taken together, these concepts provide a richer lens for understanding how subjective narratives, reflexive deliberation and broader sociotechnical shifts intersect in the lives we lead within a changing world.

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5 Personal Morphogenesis

A persistent worry throughout this project is that emphasising the “individual” might be misconstrued as a commitment to individualism. Such a reading is understandable, given how often individual categories feature in frameworks treating society as a mere aggregate of individuals. Yet the ontological domain we explore here is highly contested: not only regarding the individual’s status but also the boundary between psychology and sociology. My goal, however, is not to reinstate the individual as the bedrock of social order. Instead I want to reclaim it as an analytic category, helping us unravel the “digital revolution” at the everyday level. There is, of course, a vast literature that already addresses these issues, with ethnographic work especially illuminating how digital technology use is inseparable from context, contradicting the so-called “move fast and break things” ideology espoused by certain digital elites. As Van Dijck (2013: loc 1357) observes, “[w]hat used to be informal social activities in the private sphere – friends hanging out together and exchanging ideas on what they like – have become algorithmically mediated interacts in the corporate sphere”.

The implications of this transformation have been obscured through the “common vernacular of sharing, friending and liking” such that “the meaning of ‘sharing’, once understood as user-to-user information exchange, has subtly been replaced by a meaning that naturalises the sharing of personal data with anyone on the planet”. This means that “the social has become a site of new economic value and intense redefinition – when the term ‘social media’ is not a description but an appropriation of the social” (Couldry and Van Dijck 2015: 1). To grasp this appropriation, I suggest the category of *platform* must enter sociological analysis, identifying an emergent facet of social reality that structures our everyday life in novel yet pervasive ways.

Yet any meaningful analysis of how platforms shape social life must also address how actual persons, rather than “users” as aggregates of data, take up, resist or adapt to these novel digital conditions (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021). Once we recognise “platforms’ rich cultures of use – how they are given form and meaning through everyday life, and through the practices of diverse individuals, communities, and publics” as Burgess and Baym (2020: 18) put it, we confront the analytical challenge of connecting *platform* and *agency* through

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ensuing cycles of their interaction. This is what the concepts of *psychobiography* and *personal morphogenesis* which I develop in this chapter can enable, illuminating the subtle causality operative as platforms reshape the parameters of agency. The following sections enable this idea in more depth, demonstrating how psychobiography helps explain the interplay between structural processes of platformisation and microsocial shifts in the condition of everyday life.

Psychobiography

Layder (1997) introduces the idea of psychobiography to sidestep conflationism when interpreting individual transitions over the life course. By acknowledging the “linked series of evolutionary transitions” that occur at “various significant junctures in the lives of individuals”, psychobiography strives to unify “both the subjective and objective facts of an individual’s experience” (Layder 1997: 47). Drawing significantly on Goffman’s notion of “moral careers”, Layder aims to develop a model that does not privilege either commonalities or divergences. Instead, psychobiography “recognize[s] shared or common elements in people’s careers” without ignoring “unique configurations of experience” (Layder 1997: 47). It’s a specific formulation of a familiar sociological concept which seeks to address the analytical weaknesses which have been attached to existing accounts of biography.

As Layder (1997: 48) puts it, by emphasising “the common features of the social context of careers”, sociologists have often overlooked psychological dimensions and individual life paths, thereby overemphasising “the socially constructed nature of the self as it unfolds over time”. The intention is not to replace a sociological concept of biography with a psychological concept but rather to expand the former by incorporating aspects of the latter, recognising this distinction as an artefact of disciplinary splits rather than a fault line in the ontology of the subject. Alongside this downwards conflation, there is also the upwards danger: neglecting how social structure conditions individual psychology over the life course (Archer 1995). This is the obvious risk if we construe biography in narrowly psychological terms, sidelining the social referents without which the unfolding of a life becomes inexplicable.

Psychobiography’s conceptual strength lies in fusing subjective and objective, structural and agential, facets at a foundational level. As Layder (1997: 50–51) states, “by identifying psycho biographies as units of analysis, we are concentrating on the intersection or join between two fundamental features of the human social world”. Without such a move, linking the personal to the social remains difficult, because we inevitably rely on postulated relations between micro and macro phenomena, with the risk of denying each domain’s relative autonomy. Yet both domains actively shape how lives unfold as individuals traverse the social world in a manner which needs to be integrated into our concept work (Archer 2007). This is a methodological point as much as an

ontological one, with implications for explaining observable biographical patterns, as Layder (1997: 48) further argues:

[T]here is a general need for sociological conceptions of the self to take account of the way in which individual psychology and personality factors interact with the changing personal and social circumstances of the lifecareer as they unfold over time and affect self identity.

Yet acknowledging this interdependence of the psychological and sociological in biographical unfolding, while averting upwards and downwards conflation, raises a third danger: *central conflation*. How do we move beyond merely affirming interdependence to unpacking and explaining it? How do we ensure that recognising the connection between the psychological and the sociological doesn't lead us to collapse the two categories into each other? For that, we must clarify the "evolutionary transitions" Layder mentions, along with how they form "linked" series. What exactly changes, and what propels that change? Further, we need to define the ontological status of psychobiography. While Layder treats it as a "unit of analysis" that alerts us to the interplay between psychological and social factors, this chapter contends that psychobiographies are genuine emergent phenomena in themselves, not simply an analytic lens for dissecting an individual's complexity. Indeed, if psychobiography is analytically potent, it follows that it must also be ontologically robust, rather than just a convenient descriptive device. It follows from this that we could, in principle, trace platform-induced transitions that become linked in a person's biography, recognising accumulation of changes which might not be legible at a particular moment in time.

Goffman (1968: 81) offers a telling remark about biographical claims:

No matter how big a scoundrel a man is, no matter how false, secretive, or disjointed his existence, or how governed by fits, starts and reversals, the true facts of his activity cannot be contradictory or unconnected with each other

From a realist perspective, the epistemological import of such claims stems from biography's ontological grounding. This logical coherence of someone's story only makes sense if, as MacIntyre (1984: 204–25) puts it, we grant the "unity of life". Similarly, Sayer (2011: 116) notes that

people tend to have a sense of 'leading a life' which may include moral learning, revising and developing their commitments, a sense of movement combined with trying to control and guide it in a way that makes sense and is valued by them, though of course it may not be controllable.

Even if the experience of platformised existence might be fragmentary or incoherent, philosophical anthropology would suggest a unified biography underpinning these experiences. This ontological claim about the unity of a biography

doesn't imply an epistemological claim that subjects experience this unity *as a* unity. In fact I will argue that recognising how these two dimensions can come loose from each other is crucial, for understanding the complex and messy reality of the lives we lead and how we change as people through the process of leading them.

Yet explaining how people evolve over time requires that psychobiography not be reduced to mere self-continuity: if that were so, it would be hard to see how one's past might constrain or enable the present in any real sense. The result would be a simple accrual of biographical facts rather than the operative constraints and enablements that exceed both our volition and awareness. Our past is something we live with in the present rather than simply things which have happened to us. This insight is key to the second half of this book, which contrasts different ontological scales for analysing technology's causal influence on personhood, ranging from the present-tense individual through to collective agency and biographical development over time. The first two scales can overstate technology's role by depicting individuals as continuously shaped by digital devices, for example, "hacking the lizard brain" or other simplistic behaviourist notions (Tarnoff and Weigel 2018). By contrast, the third scale underscores how the trajectory of development shifts over time, rather than presuming that technology unavoidably produces distinct "types" of people. It highlights the biographical transitions that proliferate in lifeworlds saturated with digital devices and social platforms.

Layder's "evolutionary transitions" should be reframed as part of a *real* psychobiography that emerges over the life course, simultaneously constraining and enabling present actions and shaping how future developments unfold. Through this lens, we can avoid the pitfalls of "fateful moments" and "turning points" while retaining the pragmatic function of identifying significant life-course "chunks". Instead of "fateful moments" we identify conjunctions of factors that generate a given situation, with agency reshaping self and environment in ways that modify the constraints and enablements of future fateful episodes. The issue is not the recognition that such moments exist, but the conceptual tendency to rely solely on the subject's narrative. This restricts our explanatory range to transitions labelled as fateful within the subject's discursive reach. We should not discard these self-narratives but contextualise them as subjective accounts of objective transitions. To do so requires maintaining a conceptual distinction between them. This means we need a further concept to clarify the cycles of change and stability that shape psychobiography over the lifespan.

Personal Morphogenesis

Elaborating a theory of personal morphogenesis draws on Alford's (1995) coinage of the term. Building on Archer's ideas, Alford explored how mature students find their way into open-access courses, framing personal morphogenesis as the "journeys we travel". He describes a "biographical movement" in

which individuals evolve under “wider structural and cultural factors, themselves subject to structural and/or cultural morphogenetic change” (Alford 1995: 21). These biographical journeys, he insists, are distinct from purely physical movement:

whereas the concept of physical journeys means physical movement, from A to B, then the concept of biographical journeys centres on personal movement, the changing of personal ideas, as a result of socio-cultural interaction, from thinking one way to thinking another. From such an interactive process, both the traveller and the landscape are changed.

(Alford 1995: 53)

Notably, both the person and the context transform in the course of a biographical journey; the individual’s actions influence their environment without wholly determining it, since countless other agents also shape that same context.

From this perspective, biographical transitions unfold at the individual level but cannot be collapsed into personal properties or powers alone. As we move through the social world, our trajectory is shaped by both our prior traits and the circumstances we encounter at each juncture. At the same time, our personal attributes and the social context are themselves partially reconfigured, often beyond our immediate awareness, by the path we choose. Alford’s empirical work centres on why certain individuals (often later in life) seek Access courses, commonly aiming for university admission:

The hypothesis is that such decisions are made due to personal changes, anticipated or non-anticipated, in their life situation, such as children settled at school, children left home, redundancy prior to starting the course, ill-health, marital breakdown etc. and that such movement represents the end (and a new beginning) of a personal morphogenetic cycle. The trigger of change, the activation, the crisis, needs to be understood in relation to what had gone before, education and work for instance. Basically the students’ lives may well have been culturally knitted together, but faced with sudden change, what appeared to be ‘well knitted’ can, on reflection, appear to be ‘well knotted’.

(Alford 1995: 62)

Biographical changes, whether expected or unexpected, welcomed or dreaded, often generate repercussions that exceed the initial event. Alford (1995) identifies some of these transformations as “catalytic”, sparking “change or crisis” that compels a fresh look at one’s *modus vivendi*. He observes that “personal crisis can leave our biographical/cultural meaning in tatters, amidst the immensity of the structural environment, which at times of personal crisis, can appear hostile and alien; a state of personal, cultural and structural anomie by any Durkheimian standards” (Alford 1995: 288). This raises further questions: how do catalytic events emerge, and how do individuals detect and interpret

them? Not all catalytic shifts manifest as crisis: the significance of any change depends on a person's psychobiographical development and pattern of reflexivity. Equally, the desire for change may precede a crisis, with the latter simply acting as a prompt or an opportunity, a point Alford poignantly illustrates in his participants' narratives:

Sometimes by its very nature, routinization begets change, a desire for change that was laying dormant in the mind and cultural experience within the biography of the individual, which may then be triggered into activation by a concatenation of circumstances. Unanticipated crisis can break monotony and bring great change, anticipated change can bring realisation of monotony and bring crisis and bring greater change. The former may sometimes be the lot of the working class male factory worker, facing redundancy, or the working class woman facing marital breakdown; the latter may be the working class woman enrolling on Access as the children are settled in school, but that very enrolment may unsettle her own life circumstances.

(Alford 1995: 319)

Alford's example of dormant impulses for change underscores a possibility often dismissed in actualist frameworks reliant on "turning points" or "fateful moments". Recognising psychobiography's emergent quality clarifies how the sequence of (seemingly) flat facts shapes a person's trajectory. Pragmatist traditions emphasise how reflexivity arises when routine is disrupted, but psychobiography and personal morphogenesis highlight the underlying forces that may remain latent until activated. These concepts transcend specific change episodes, establishing a temporal reference point so that our analysis isn't confined to any single moment or a priori cycle imputed to personal change. Alford's theoretical approach builds on Archer's (1988, 1995, 2000) extensive contributions to the morphogenetic study of structure, culture and agency, shaped partly by the cybernetic ideas of Walter Buckley and others. She adopts the following definitions:

Thus 'Morphogenesis' refers to 'those processes which tend to elaborate or change a system's given form, state or structure'. Conversely 'morphostasis' refers to those processes in complex system-environmental exchanges which tend to preserve or maintain a system's given form, organization or state.

(Archer 1995: 166)

These categories can easily be applied to the personal to identify the stasis and change which occurs on this level. **Personal morphostasis** involves personal, relational, ideational and structural factors that collectively sustain an individual's intrapersonal structures: character, concerns and projects. By contrast, **personal morphogenesis** involves the same sets of factors, yet transforming those

intrapersonal structures in ways that alter one's character, concerns and projects. Essentially, morphostasis and morphogenesis represent two phases, one leading towards stability, the other towards change, whose sequence shapes an individual's psychobiography across the life course. Multiple cycles of each can overlap in a single person's life, yet we can trace distinct morphogenetic cycles because individuals, however, imperfectly, maintain a sense of past and present under their own descriptions. Personal morphogenesis arises when personal, relational, ideational and structural factors converge to form *issues* that demand some resolution. These issues can mirror pragmatist problem situations, yet they might also extend beyond any single context, reshaped as the individual continues living and re-evaluating them over time. It's a deliberately capacious definition intended to capture the empirical variability in how such issues are constituted, an approach I have refined across a number of empirical projects (Carrigan 2011, 2012).

When such issues become urgent, pressing matters which demand attention rather than features of the background which provoke a vague unease, it is due to the interplay of one's situation and one's concerns (Archer 2000, 2003). As Maccarini (2011: 110) points out, concern has a dual meaning: (1) that which inescapably demands our attention and (2) that which we care about or ideally invest in. Both senses combine in "what is urging us". When an issue is sufficiently compelling to occupy a subject's deliberations for a stretch of time, it can be addressed simply by asking, "what's on your mind?": a question that proved productive in the qualitative longitudinal study informing these ideas (Carrigan 2014). The topic becomes an "issue" precisely when structural or cultural elements predispose the subject's immediate concerns to interpret a situation as requiring reflection or action. It does not mandate a response, even an interpretation, only attention, that is, it is a matter arising in their context which the subject feels involuntarily drawn to in their internal conversation. Not every circumstance triggers an issue, but whenever it does, we can infer some prior structural and/or cultural factor, alone or combined, that prompted it to emerge in the form it did.

Sometimes these initiating factors are quite dramatic, "catastrophic" in Alford's sense, but often they merely spur reflexivity: some shift occurs whose implications remain partially unformed, yet internal dialogue begins to revolve around the resulting issue. There has been a change in our circumstances which in some diffuse sense seems to call for a change in us. This is why discursive elaboration is central. Our attempts to decode what troubles us and to name what matters are a continual, often messy, reflexive activity. We rarely achieve a transparent rational stance where we systematically assess the context and weigh our concerns. Autonomous reflexives approximate this ideal but only in certain domains, like workplace decisions with reasonably predictable outcomes. In practice, our self-knowledge and social understanding unfold under conditions of epistemic relativity: knowledge emerges in specific times and places, remains shaped by that history, and may be revised, or discarded, as our journey continues.

By contrast, Giddens (1984, 1991) interprets the repeated surfacing of issues as psychic (mal)adaptation to changes in personal and social life, ostensibly disrupting the "cocoon" of ontological security. Under his model, we pose

existential questions mainly when our sense of order collapses. From a Lacanian perspective this naturalisation of “order” is deeply suspect, as if our taken-for-granted experience of the world isn’t already saturated with existential content (Fink 1995). It’s a framing which downplays the subtler processes of inquiry many people sustain throughout life, as well as the incremental articulation of self-understanding and the conceptual tools that support it. If we follow Archer’s (2003, 2007) arguments on reflexivity’s ubiquity, Giddens’s near-exclusive reliance on (a particular form of) psychoanalytic logic appears extreme. Naturally, one cannot dismiss the possibility of pathological involuntary thoughts, yet Giddens’s ontological premises broaden that category so drastically that it becomes unwieldy. It empties the everyday of psychically challenging content while assuming the pathological character of those tracts of experience where the “everyday” breaks down.

Framing all cognitive preoccupation as pathological reduces it to a psychological problem, losing sight of the sociological insight these recurring worries can afford. While involuntary thought-cycles can indeed cause distress, they do not necessarily require psychoanalytic interpretation. The experience of obsesiveness (the difficulty in halting internal dialogues) actually reveals a core dynamic in meta-reflexivity and fractured reflexivity. Each struggles to end deliberations, though for different reasons: meta-reflexive conversation may spiral indefinitely because the subject keeps redefining the problem and its context, whereas fractured reflexivity fails to unify any sense of purpose behind those incessant musings.

People’s responses to issues vary considerably, partly shaped (but not determined) by their reflexive mode, and possibly differing across life domains (e.g. strategic at work and evasive at home). Likewise, how they frame these issues, internally or in conversations with others, reflects their psychobiographical past. In many instances, ideational dynamics alone can spur morphogenesis: a new cultural resource or social encounter disrupts one’s *modus vivendi* and prompts re-evaluation. For example, a new way of looking at oneself can be transformative, as encountering an identity category enables one to rearticulate a once pathologised feature as a legitimate part of who they are (Carrigan 2011). Such issues can remain “live” for extended periods, persisting in internal dialogues, sometimes only half-articulated, for example, there might be emotional discomfort in the absence of a clearly stated problem. External guidance may be sought from various sources. Eventually, if resolved, the individual’s personhood shifts, whether dramatically or in a mundane way, providing the starting point for future cycles. Personal traits themselves provide the context in which personal morphogenesis unfolds, shaping the constraints and enablements that govern subsequent transformations.

The Temporal Extension of Agency

This chapter has introduced the concepts of *psychobiography* and *personal morphogenesis* to account for both the lifecourse (the former) and individual

transitions (the latter). Psychobiography designates the overall unit of analysis (one's life and its linked transitions), whereas personal morphogenesis pinpoints the dynamics of specific changes. In doing so, this approach opens up the developmental paths outlined in Archer (2000) and the biographical trajectories in Archer (2007, 2012). Both examine lifecourse tendencies, notably Archer's take on the emergence of personal and social identity. Crucially, her framework "accentuates emergent properties and powers at every stage", endorsing the "primacy of practice" while also "giving due to everyone's societal encounter" (Archer 2000: 116). This developmental narrative, distinct from a purely life-long view, begins with one's involuntary embedding in social and cultural structures (Archer 2000: 261–68). Society's resource distribution entails causal powers that operate without our compliance, consent or complicity. Yet this involuntary location may evolve through childhood and adolescence, since neither families nor broader contexts remain static. The child depends on the caregiver "we" who themselves reflexively manage the child's social placement, but the child still gains awareness; not as a formal analyst, but as a feeling agent confronting everyday echoes of these structural constraints:

[t]he most basic of these reflections is an early recognition of constraints and enablements – as in the child who questions 'why can't I have more to eat, or a bike?', versus the one who learns that its 'wants list' is always much better satisfied than those of its peers. Both understand that they have a place in the social world which is independent of (and oblivious to) their own exertions. Scarce resources do not become less so through clamouring. Probably the recognition is earlier and easier where constraints are concerned, because the ready satisfaction of wants can more readily be mistaken for the effects of our egocentric powers.

(Archer 2000: 264)

Beyond realising that social circumstances can satisfy or frustrate different wants, the developing "I" also discovers that numerous personal attributes (accent, skin colour, gender, etc.) draw either positive or negative responses from others. Archer (2000: 264) notes how "the 'I' may be distressed to learn that its 'Me' is considered to speak with the wrong accent, to be of a disfavoured colour or gender" or "'I' may be gratified that there is something about 'Me' which is to be lived up to in order to keep my position" (Archer 2000: 264). Such normative judgments are shaped by a child's inherited social placement and mediated by the caregiving "We". This involuntary location also spawns the potential for primary agents, those passively sharing a given social position, to crystallise into corporate agents, who coordinate efforts to meet collective goals. Primary agents remain "confined to the 'Me'" operating "within ... existing socio-cultural structures"; corporate agents evolve into "an active 'We'" strategically seeking structural transformation (Archer 2000: 268–69). Both modes of agency, primary and corporate, help condition the actor each person becomes: primary agency through the constraints and enablements one meets daily, corporate

agency through reconfiguring available social roles and whether a person gains an articulate awareness of their interests sufficient to identify the role position that best fulfil them (Archer 2000: 284).

A pivotal point in Archer's framework is the empirical priority of agents over actors. As she explains, "agency makes more room for the actor" (Archer 2011: 86), meaning the mutable array of roles emerges from the struggles among corporate agents, shaping which roles an actor can adopt. Still, why do individuals choose particular roles? Such decisions reflect their formation as primary agents (life chances tied to their position, associated opportunity costs and normative judgments stemming from that position) and as corporate agents (the intended or unintended impact of their agency on the social order, role array or on themselves through participation). The register of choice here does not imply autonomous or freedom from social constraint, only that such constraint operates causally through its intersection with personal reflexivity over time. It's a sophisticated and multifactorial account of social conditioning rather than a denial that such conditioning takes place, as some critics have confusingly alleged (Atkinson 2010; King 2010). It stresses the variety of factors that constrain and enable individual reflexivity, as well as the temporal sequencing through which they operate.

Explaining how individuals become actors, gaining social identity, demands a theory of personal identity. People move tentatively among possible choices, refining their sense of self and understanding of their context. Our personal identity emerges by selecting from among our concerns, forging a project-based arrangement that can be sustained as coherent despite often contradictory demands from the natural, practical and social domains. This is a learning process in which adolescents "inspect not only their own involuntary roles but also the lifestyles of those who have put them there, which are sifted into elements worthy of replication versus others meriting rejection" (Archer 2000: 290). In discovering a "Me" that was involuntarily assigned and evaluated, "I" likewise begin evaluating both that placement and the "We" responsible for it. Through these initially uncertain steps, "I" develop into a being with specific concerns, seeking a social role that aligns with them.

Individuation arises from the dialectical interplay between personal identity and social identity (Maccarini 2011: 90). Our nascent personal identities guide which social roles we explore, while our natal environment filters potential options, supporting some while discouraging others. We exercise selectivity through negotiating these filters, with some individuals endorsing a *modus vivendi* within the natal framework, whereas others seek alternatives to clarify who they want to be and how they wish to live. Yet once we commit to a particular role, that engagement feeds back into our personal identity, reshaping it in turn. Adopting a new role often introduces fresh constraints and enablements, either igniting new concerns or prompting us to rethink the old ones. We might end up challenging the entire role array or social structure, potentially joining a corporate "We" in pursuit of social change. More prosaically, we might just discover we misjudged a role. In practice we enjoy it less than we expected to, particularly if we change and/or the role changes since our initial

commitment to it. As Archer remarks, “no job is as the neophyte sees it in prospect, and there can be unexpected satisfactions as well as dissatisfactions” (Archer 2000: 291). Both self-knowledge and social knowledge remain fallible, especially among emerging adults first entering the social order. Yet these involvements help expand our awareness, prompting us to re-evaluate prior assumptions about our desires or about a role’s true character.

Even successful role experiments compel a renewed internal conversation: how much energy should one invest in this role, and how does one reconcile it with other concerns? Some roles prove “greedy”, open-ended in their demands for time or commitment, such as the role of the contemporary academic which always offers additional projects we could take on, in a ceaseless cycle of acceleration (Mizen 2015; Vostal 2014; Müller 2019). We typically hold multiple roles, each requiring distinct negotiations, with complex interplay driving the “issues” which preoccupy our internal conversations. Underlying this dynamic is the personal capacity for reflexivity, the emergent power to balance competing priorities, as well as the necessity of exercising it in the mundane situations we confront in daily life. As Maccarini (2011: 109) observes, “the dreams, concerns and life projects of human beings are the place from which social conditions receive their ‘specific gravity’”.

Becoming Who We Are

This chapter weaves together the theoretical strands explored in earlier sections, proposing a theory of personal morphogenesis which is more expansive than projects that have sought cognitive micro-foundations for sociology (Lizardo 2004). It integrates personal-level change into a framework designed to analyse transformations in agency, culture and structure (Archer 2013). We introduced three relations through which personhood unfolds, with related concepts to analyse the interconnections:

- Conditioning “Me” → Present “I” (*character*)
- Present “I” → Related “We” (*relations and ideas*)
- Elaborating “I” → Future “You” (*possible selves*)

Each relation operates on a distinct time horizon. The conditioned “Me” shapes and constrains the present “I”, which in turn interacts with a “We” that contributes to the shaping of the future “You”. Incorporating these relations into a common analytical framework recognises the multifaceted ways in which social and cultural factors shape who we are and who we become. As Laing once observed, “our relatedness to others is an essential part of our being... but any particular person is not a necessary part of our being” (Laing 2010: 26). By mapping these relations and their time horizons, we affirm that personhood is inherently relational while avoiding the reduction of who we are to who we know. This preserves the relative autonomy of “I” vis-à-vis “We” highlighting how relationships shape persons, who in turn reshape future relationships.

Each phase of this interaction is tied up in an individual's own process of becoming, conditioning what they bring to the interaction and how they emerge from it. Psychobiography bridges being and becoming, which cannot be neatly separated even if social thought has tended to prioritise one over the other, depending on the theoretical influences involved. Our psychobiography unfolds "as we all journey – always necessarily – through the arrow of time of our life course" (Uprichard 2008: 307) becoming part of our deliberations under our own descriptions (Alford 1995). Although we interpret our past, present, and future through cultural lenses, we cannot assume these share a common meaning even if they might seem to have a common form (Archer 1988). The ideas we pick up while moving through the world reflect not only what we hold but when we held it and why it mattered at each juncture. Our engagements with culture are intensely personal, even intimate, in ways which matter even more when we consider the influence of platforms in later chapters. Our reflexive efforts are often untutored, improvised and sometimes hesitant, particularly amid rapid social or cultural shifts. Yet they are in a profound sense *ours*, tied up in who we have become and orientated towards the person we might one day be.

What Bauman (2013) terms "the art of life" becomes more challenging under detraditionalisation, as habits and customs lose traction in the face of novel situations. Increasingly, we must fall back on our own resources to figure out what to do and who to be. The strength of this literature, however flawed, lies in the way it forced these questions into sociological discourse. Yet as argued, the ontological and methodological baggage often means the applications of this approach remain thematic rather than deeply explanatory. It provides a poetic way to discuss social change, though that poetics can risk overshadowing how real people navigate such upheavals. This tension will be central in the next part of the book. Sociotechnical transformation drives new experiences and interactions that confound inherited social categories (whether lay or expert). Meanwhile, social media amplifies the intensity and scope of interactions about these changes, prompting relational reflexivity that may prove both fragile and self-defeating (Donati and Archer 2015).

This analytical framework aims to open up such inquiries rather than letting them dissolve into vague references to epochal transformation. It sensitises us to the modalities by which conditioning shapes a person's propensities (Me), how present capacities interact with others (I ↔) dynamic, and how we project ourselves into the person we may become (You). Far from a substantive theory, it's a heuristic for distinguishing phases of personal change and linking static ontologies of being (T1, T4) with processual ontologies of becoming (T2, T3). By identifying cycles of personal morphogenesis or morphostasis across the life course, we see how an emergent psychobiography acquires its particular shape: at any moment I am *this person*, formed by *this history*.

There is much more to say about these relations than this chapter permits. My goal has been to explicitly articulate a framework, originally developed through a longitudinal study of the reflexive development of undergraduate

students (Carrigan 2014). This scheme is an analytical tool for investigating personal morphogenesis, not a substantive claim about how people become who they are. Any robust theory requires substantive research on that very process, a domain where sociology has historically struggled. The aim here is not to promote psychobiography as a master category of micro-analysis but rather to recover a stratified view of the individual: unfolding over time, woven into relationships, and always evolving.

Rescuing “the individual” from the individualists remains a key concern. References to individuals in sociology often spark fears of individualism, partly due to the discipline’s historical demarcation from psychology (Layder 1997: 51). This conceptual tension has deepened, as the individual is a contested category mired in theoretical controversies that can make it difficult to map out the claims which are stake in them (Sayer 2011: 14). This book does not attempt a full-scale resolution of these issues but simply insists that people’s everyday lives consist of both external *and* internal dialogues (Chalari 2009). While external dialogues rarely bother sociologists, internal dialogues raise scepticism, whether from lingering doubts about “thinking” or from anti-Cartesian moves that deny an “inner theatre” (Rorty 2007; Swedberg 2011). Yet if we shift from inner observation to internal *conversation*, the force of those critiques diminishes as we leave behind the ontological baggage of ocular metaphors (Archer 2003: 21–33). To ignore this interiority is not just philosophically misguided but also methodologically impoverishing. We cede too much to psychology and lose a sociological handle on reflexivity and the role it plays in everyday life. As a result, variations in how subjects relate to their objects can remain unexamined, fuelling the false impression of a uniform mental life. This can be a lay assumption as much as an expert one, suggesting how folk theories might influence formal conceptualisation. It’s striking when conducting empirical research into the internal conversation how reliably participants assume other people’s inner lives are broadly similar to their own, in contrast to the differences which reveal themselves when you have substantial conversations with a range of people about their internal conversations (Carrigan 2014).

One risk in emphasising interiority is a collapse of disciplinary boundaries, losing touch with disciplinary expertise which has accumulated through this process of differentiation (MacIntyre 1984; Mouzelis 1995). Yet this project began at the interface of philosophy and sociology, and it concludes at the crossroads of psychology and sociology. Sociologists often sidestep questions about the origins of mental capacities that underlie social interaction, whereas psychologists typically assume reflexivity is universal, reinforcing that assumption via experimental designs (Archer 2003: 153; Sayer 2011: 118). Thus, reflexivity gets squeezed out by disciplinary boundaries, either confined to individual psychology (*intra-active*) or collapsed into social psychology (*interactive*) (Archer 2003: 64). Its specificity is lost, leaving crucial subject–object variability unexplained or explained away.

If we want to understand what it means to “live in a digital age” then we urgently need to recover this reflexive variability which has so often been lost.

Throughout this first section, I traced how personal and social change intersect by examining the detraditionalisation thesis, which centres that relationship yet struggles to support an analytical grasp on the specific forms it takes. I proposed an alternative grounded in Archer's (2003, 2007, 2012) social realist approach to human agency, particularly personal reflexivity. This approach sees agency as emergent, unfolding in a temporal context, with personal changes intricately connected to structural or cultural change. Our distinct temporal relations (Me→I, I↔We and I→You) have too frequently been merged into oversimplified statements about how the personal evolves in tandem with the social.

In the next section I apply these ideas to sociotechnical change, aiming to avoid empty "digital age" platitudes and grand epochal claims that overlook micro complexity. I approach the platformisation of personal life around these three intrapersonal relations in order to highlight the primary mechanisms which are generating transformation. My goal is not a taxonomy of claims about digital change but a deeper sense of how these processes collectively shift the parameters within which reflexivity is enacted. Building on earlier concepts, I also propose a fourth dimension, *platform*, alongside structure, culture and agency in Archer's (2011) sense. This extension underscores how the platform emerges at the confluence of structure and culture yet remains irreducible to either. I argue that Archer's (2011) stance that robust explanations must encompass structure (S), agency (A) and culture (C) now warrants incorporating platform (P) as a fourth analytical element. In this way, we can discuss *platform & agency* similarly to how Archer (1988) examines *culture & agency* and Archer (1995) addresses *structure & agency*. By tracing the diverse mechanisms through which platforms operate, I present a relational account locating platforms at the intersection of structure and culture but never collapsing them into either.

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Section Two

The Ontology of Platforms



6 Sociotechnical Transformation

In the first section of this book I argued for a biographical approach to human agency, suggesting we frame this category in terms of temporal extension rather than present capacities. The significance of our action in and towards the world accumulates over time: fateful moments and turning points coexist alongside inertia and routine to constitute the person we have become. I have proposed that Margaret Archer's (2003, 2007, 2012) concept of reflexivity provides a robust foundation for understanding how this accumulation takes place: something I called *personal morphogenesis*. In this second section of the book, I will place that conceptual framework against the backdrop of sociotechnical change, arguing that it is precisely these evolving parameters of the digital environment which now structure how this morphogenesis of the person unfolds.

To understand platform and agency means recognising how time mediates their relationship, while distinguishing platform influences from the older structural and cultural dynamics of social life. Although I centre my argument on the biographical dimension, these conceptual tools can be applied more broadly, becoming relevant for any inquiry into sociotechnical transformation. I do not present it as a grand theory but rather as a starting point, locating the individual's reflexivity amidst infrastructural change. This matters, I contend, because the cultural politics of digital technology (the dense tangle of imagination, investment and contestation) rests so heavily on claims about how we live now, or what it means to be an individual in a digital age. In this chapter, I review the complex inheritance of these debates in order to clear the ground for a more positive account in the following chapters.

From Technological Utopianism to Technological Pessimism

When I began this long-term project, a widespread belief held that digital technologies possessed an emancipatory potential, enabling new social movements to arise as the costs of organisation dropped. Such developments were hailed as a means to provide democratic steering over a capitalism seen as increasingly precarious, particularly in an era where history has returned with a vengeance. Though many of these technologies were nascent at the time, they seemed to promise an evocative, if chimerical, answer to the question of who might

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control our “runaway world” (Giddens 2002). The idea emerged that we, as lay actors, might do so: social media would free our collaborative capacities, casting platforms like Facebook and Twitter as incubators of collectivities, more authentic and liberated than anything possible with a legacy media system in a bureaucratised society (Couldry 2014, 2024).

Cyber optimists such as Clay Shirky (2008, 2010) illustrated this archetype. As Couldry (2014) suggests, we can treat such visions anthropologically, that is, as potent cultural myths that ascribes enormous normative value to these new spaces of discussion, sharing and creativity. Their result has been to downplay the underlying business models guiding digital corporations, who cleverly performed neutrality while monetising the assembling crowds inside walled gardens. This utopian storyline posited that the sociotechnical constraints of the analogue society had artificially curbed our potential. Once digital platforms arrived, we would connect freely, culminating in “Twitter revolutions” (Morozov 2011, 2013). In reality, this stance turned out to be vastly overblown, ignoring who really benefits and who is heard in these networked spaces (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: 52–54).

By the late 2010s, the breathless rhetoric of technological utopianism had begun to be widely rejected. As Selwyn (2021: 7) notes “the 2020s is turning out to be a decade when populations around the world ask serious questions about the implications of their technology consumption”. However the ensuing “tech lash”, in which large firms have received a critical backlash following multiple scandals over surveillance and election influence, might face the same kind of historical repudiation (Couldry 2024). This is not an invitation to suspend judgment about digital technologies or the corporate giants behind them. On the contrary, it underscores the vital need for sociological analysis. Couldry (2020) calls for a perspective that clarifies how digital “entanglements (and their outcomes)” measure up against “the goals that orientate human life”. Indeed, the major civic battle around “datafication” (and whose interests it serves) calls for a broader vantage point that avoids both utopian illusions and dystopian fatalisms. As Boyd (2014: loc 313) clarifies:

Both extremes depend on a form of magical thinking scholars call technological determinism. Utopian and dystopian views assume that technologies possess intrinsic powers that affect all people in all situations in the same way. Utopian rhetoric assumes that when a particular technology is broadly adopted it will transform society in magnificent ways, while dystopian visions focus on all of the terrible things that will happen because of the widespread adoption of a particular technology that ruins everything. These extreme rhetorics are equally unhelpful in understanding what actually happens when new technologies are broadly adopted. Reality is nuanced and messy, full of pros and cons. Living in a networked world is complicated.

Our challenge is to analyse these “nuanced and messy” realities, pushing beyond the simplifications which have too frequently dominated these debates. The

digital discourse over the last two decades has filled the intellectual field with conceptual detritus, residual ideas that linger in even sophisticated debates which prevent us move from making conceptual progress. Carr's (2018) phrase, "the wreckage of techno-progressive orthodoxy" captures the aftermath. One route to unpicking these influences is to examine countercultural influences on American techno-optimism, as Turner (2006) does, mapping how a 1960s bohemian belief in technology's emancipatory potential merged with the rise of Silicon Valley.

From John Perry Barlow's defiant "Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace" imagining "weary giants of flesh and steel" overshadowed by a free-floating new realm, through to the romantic idea of "virtual worlds" untainted by capitalism, the countercultural orientation made technology seem inherently radical. It was assumed to be inherently progressive, with the power to overturn inherited hierarchies and bring about a new kind of society. While these portentous statements soon felt dated, their spirit lingered, shaping academic and political discourse for years: scholars and activists could be seen hailing "participatory culture" as inherently emancipatory well into the last decade (Boyd 2017).

Yet if these visions foresaw disintermediation, the actual rise of platforms involved a radical new form of mediation: planetary-scale gatekeepers forcibly inserted into social life, replacing local or legacy institutions with hypergrowth ventures fed by impatient capital (Srnicek 2016). In the process, as Davies (2021: 16) and Marres (2018) note, platforms drove a wedge into existing social networks, feeding off the trust and meaning which could be found within them, inclining them towards newly commodified and extractive forms. Far from dissolving gatekeepers, they recast them in a new, more pervasive mould.

There's a crucial role for social theory in explaining why the platform society diverges so sharply from the original mythology of digital change. As Van Dijck, Poell, and De Waal (2018: 2) put it, "platforms have penetrated to the heart of societies" and are altering institutions, economic activities and cultural practices, raising new questions about governance which trouble our existing legal, economic and political categories. Couldry (2020) highlights how Actor Network Theory (ANT) has been particularly influential in analysing these changes, usefully expanding our descriptive repertoire to handle "the actual plurality of the world". Yet he also cautions that ANT can decentre the human to such an extent that any normative basis for critique is lost. This is why we urgently need to recover the reflexive subject often lost in accounts of epochal change, who is now entangled in platform infrastructures without being determined by them.

It helps to inspect the metaphors swirling around these technological developments. The language of the "cloud" is instructive: it conveys weightlessness and spatial freedom, consistent with a "liquid" view of contemporary capitalism (Archer 2013). In truth, the "cloud" is anchored in massive data centres, the enormous centralisation of computing that underpin everyday apps, including smartphone usage. It's a huge material project with a vast environmental toll,

recently accelerated by the arms race around large language models (LLMs) (Brevini 2022; Crawford 2021). None of this invalidates the first-person experience of frictionless digital experience, but it does mean we must link the user's perceptions (hopes, joys, illusions, etc.) to the infrastructural base. One user's "weightlessness" depends on another region's industrial scars, a mismatch that challenges us to scrutinise how these illusions shape agency.

The "front stage" of platform life is not unreal, it is simply incomplete. Platforms enable novel connectivity and can feel spontaneously liberating to individuals, but behind them stands the backstage complexity. Observing these layers draws us back to the structure-agency puzzle described by Archer (1995) as the vexatious fact of society. We need an ontological framework that acknowledges how digital architecture shapes user behaviour, while preserving room for real choices, albeit choices that can be manipulated by code and corporate strategy. Indeed, as Plantin et al. (2018: 297) observe, "their affordances support innovation and creativity – supplying a base for video games or new media forms - yet simultaneously constrain participation and channel it into modes that profit the platform's creators". Failing to capture such tension has historically led to either too much utopian or too much dystopian framing, precisely the technological determinism we want to avoid.

Even if we analytically identify a platform as an entity with specific features, that does not entail users interpret or experience it that way. For many users a social platform is just a practical route to communicate with friends, rather than an infrastructure which shapes (and harvests) interactions. However, if people aren't aware of the platform's subtle conditioning, they cannot resist or easily see the economic and algorithmic logic behind their feeds. Yet heightened awareness may not automatically help. A paranoid vision of the "algorithm" for instance, portrays an all-powerful secret manipulator while lacking a nuanced account of what these algorithms do or who controls them. The point is not to disregard the situated experience but to contextualise it, in a robust and careful manner. To recognise the context, its influence and the scope of action possible within it.

Despite illusions that still accompany the front stage, the evolving platform economy signals a stark shift in contemporary capitalism. Consider Lanchester's (2015) comparison: in 1960, General Motors made \$7.6 billion with 600,000 employees but by 2015, Apple was making \$89.9 billion with under 100,000 staff. Lanier (2014: 2) similarly notes how Kodak once employed 140,000 people and was worth \$28 billion, whereas Instagram was sold to Facebook for \$1 billion while employing only thirteen. This transformation shows up in severed ties between wages and productivity, as well as the fear that automation and advanced computing will render mass unemployment inevitable. Srnicek (2016: loc 157–178) draws attention to how the digital economy has become an infrastructure for the wider economy, as well as a hegemonic model which legitimates capitalism against a backdrop of secular stagnation. The platform emerged in this context as a sociotechnical infrastructure "that enable two or more groups to interact" positioning "themselves as intermediaries that bring

together different users: customers, advertisers, service providers, producers, suppliers, and even physical objects” (Srnicek 2016: loc 596). Their reliance on network effects, in which the value of the service increases proportionally as users grow, creates winner-takes-all or winner-takes-most dynamics leading to a rapid consolidation, which in turn increases the ability to raise capital in a virtuous cycle. It’s a model of capital accumulation that enables firms to scale to global operations in a handful of years. But it’s also an ideology about technology’s capacity to bring about “disruption” and the vulnerability of established firms, no matter how sound their underlying fundamentals, if they fail to adapt to this new sociotechnical reality.

What Is a Platform?

The concept of *platform* is notoriously slippery, encompassing multiple overlapping meanings. Analytically, it can be defined as “a programmable architecture designed to organize interactions between users” (van Dijck, Poell and de Waal 2018: 9). It enables users to interact at a distance in pre-determined yet flexible ways, generating data which feeds back into the interaction which is taking place. However, any neat definition quickly collides with a broader platform rhetoric emerging from the very social, economic and technological changes under scrutiny. Gillespie (2010) shows how today’s usage of “platform” knits together connotations that are computational (something you build software on), political (a standpoint you endorse), figurative (a stage for being seen and heard) and architectural (a surface to stand on). Historically, “platform” meant a foundation that let other things run on top. Now it also implies a raised surface from which we perform, a metaphor that merges seamlessly with the narrative of disintermediation. This underscores the notion of platforms as culturally neutral facilitators, merely enabling people to come together and have voice, in the process bypassing older gatekeepers like film studios or publishers (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 2). The promise claimed by social platforms was liberation from the limits that once siloed us, conjuring a bright vision where technology unlocks our latent creativity and sociability.

However, as Margetts (2017) notes, “social media has had a bad press recently”. The same infrastructure once hailed as revolutionary is now blamed for deep social harm: populism, disinformation, conspiracies, etc. (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 7). While Clay Shirky’s (2008, 2010) optimism (“Here comes everyone!”) accurately predicted how lowering transaction costs would transform collective action, it missed how that capacity can empower far-right or conspiratorial groups as easily as progressive movements. The rise of “Big Tech” as a political-economic force and a potent social discourse introduced a fresh lens of surveillance, manipulation and algorithmic intrusion into public discussion of platforms. It’s been a dramatic shift in how these issues are framed within the public sphere, creating a risk that we swing from one extreme to the other in a way which is analytically counterproductive.

In this context, the term platform remains valuable precisely because it signals a core fact about these firms: they *intervene*. Gillespie (2015) highlights how platforms act, influence and operate behind the scenes with motives often diverging from the user-facing promises. They involve a “front stage” and “back stage”, an environment in which user behaviour can be continually nudged by behind-the-scenes data analytics (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 3). This is apparent across social platforms like YouTube or Instagram, commerce platforms like Amazon, rental services such as Airbnb, and transport/delivery apps like Uber and Deliveroo. Each is “fuelled by data, automated and organized through algorithms and interfaces, formalized through ownership relations driven by business models, and governed through user agreements” (van Dijck, Poell and de Waal 2018: 9). Some data, like Uber’s passenger–driver ratings, becomes partially visible to participants. But the platform itself accumulates a vast dataset beyond this, fuelling proprietary functions like price optimisation or user-matching, all hidden from direct user scrutiny. In one infamous case, Uber executives reportedly showcased a “god view” where they tracked identifiable users around a city in real time.

These conditions can easily generate paranoia. People sense they are being subtly manipulated by unseen engineers, yet remain unsure who is responsible or how that manipulation occurs (Carrigan and Sylvia 2022). As the pandemic brought about a more aggressive platformisation of social and economic life, a new mediated power increasingly saturates the everyday, often outrunning older forms of regulation. No matter the hopeful slogans which accompanied their earlier years, these sociotechnical infrastructures have developed into large-scale privatised systems (Doctorow 2024). Van Dijck, Poell, and de Waal (2018: 2) caution that platforms “do not cause a revolution” but rather “are gradually infiltrating in, and converging with, the (offline, legacy) institutions and practices through which democratic societies are organised”.

One risk in focusing on the technology alone is overlooking the relationality that truly animates these systems. Platforms are, at heart, about relations: the interactions and ties that coalesce (and are enforced) through them. Some accounts see these are purely about coordinating disparate groups in an otherwise neutral space. This is what Couldry (2014, 2015) describes as the “myth of us”: the assumption that platforms simply provide a neutral space in which “we” can gather together. In reality, each platform is orchestrated by an operator who sets the rules, reaping asymmetrical benefits from their privileged access to the data which is generated. In Nielsen and Ganter’s (2022: loc 614) terms, a platform’s power is “contingent on their ability to maintain relations and sustain them over time” which can be done only by calibrating user behaviour through data science and persuasive design (Williams 2018; Marres 2018). But platforms are simultaneously dependent on the agency of their users, their capacity to think, feel, care and make (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: 63–65). They treat their users as vectors of behaviour to be influenced in strategic ways while also being dependent on their reflexivity for the content of the platform itself.

Platforms always pose questions of agency. Whether we talk about “riders” on Uber, “hosts” on Airbnb or the single monolithic “user” typical of social media, a platform defines roles with associated capabilities. Elon Musk’s transformation of Twitter to X, including subscription-based privileges in which visibility can in effect be purchased, reveals how quickly these roles can be reconfigured. Meanwhile, from the firm’s perspective, the system runs as a research-centric apparatus intentionally shaped by data scientists who track and optimise user activity. There is an asymmetry designed into these platforms because the users are related to as “influenceable subjects, not knowledgeable agents” (Marres 2018: 435). These create known, rather than knowing publics, defined by their aggregate characteristics and susceptibility to influence rather than capacity for collective action (Kennedy and Moss 2015). Kennedy, Poell and van Dijck (2015) explored these overlaps through the lens of structure and agency, recognising how “questions about agency have been overshadowed by a focus on oppressive techno-commercial strategies like data mining”. They seek instead to facilitate a conversation about the “dominance of structures of datafication, the possibility of agency, and the spaces in between” (Kennedy, Poell and van Dijck 2015). These are the meso- and macro-questions of platform and agency which are the counterpart to this book’s micro-social concerns.

Bringing people together on a platform is only the first step. The platform must keep them there to retain economic value. Thus, they facilitate *gathering* but also require *maintenance*, using the platform’s constraints and affordances to sustain engagement. Marres (2018: 437) vividly depicts an environment in two halves: on one side, users with “influence-able” preferences, while on the other, data analysts who can monitor and steer such preferences in near real time through their algorithmic intermediaries. This arrangement suggests an implicit authoritarian potential, through an infrastructural reliance on human agency which the firm is simultaneously seeking to mould to meet its commercial needs (Robinson 2018; Strittmatter 2018; Morozov 2019). However, this infrastructure does not, *could not*, ultimately determine what users do within the sociotechnical environment it constitutes. If it could the job of the platforms would be far more straightforward when it comes to matters such as content moderation (Gillespie 2018). If we overstate the causal force of the platform at any one moment, we risk obscuring the more subtle and diffuse ways in which this power might operate over time. The relevant modality is the *accumulation* of interventions rather than the individual interventions themselves.

We might well be in the early stages of a synergy between data-driven behavioural science and what Archer (2016) calls “anormative regulation”, enabling granular interventions legitimated by the aura of objectivity provided by “big data” (Lazega 2014; Couldry 2020). Unfortunately, the same affordances that activists and social movements harness for mobilisation can also be used to track or neutralise them (Tufekci 2014). In fact this is the paradox we need to grasp: the more radical the possibilities for bottom-up organisation, the more advanced the top-down interventions can become (Doctorow 2024). The net

result might be that certain forms of collective reflexivity weaken while others intensify. This is a dialectic we cannot capture if we flatten all digital technology into a single story of inevitability. However to ensure this we need a more careful delineation of the multiple developments being subsumed into a broader story of sociotechnical change.

From “Cyberspace” to the “Semantic Web” to “Generative AI”

Though any sequential typology is imperfect, the technological shifts highlighted here can still be grasped productively if we think in terms of subsequent iterations of end-user experience. This approach aligns with the agent-orientated ontology developed through this book, stressing how reflexive agents live with and adapt to new sociotechnical systems. By no means it is the only possible framework, but it helps us untangle the often contradictory nature of sociotechnical change, fulfilling the critical imperative suggested by Couldry (2020) to see things from the perspective of those forced to cope with the emergent platform society (Van Dijck, Poell and de Waal 2018).

The first wave of Web 1.0 required a desktop or laptop plugged into a modem, offering largely static pages viewed via a browser. That combination encouraged metaphors like “cyberspace” and “virtual worlds”, partly because physically tethered connections and pre-broadband setup reinforced a sense of entering a distinct “online” realm. There were distinct steps which had to be taken, creating a clearly delineated state of being connected or disconnected. People often talked about “surfing the net” while business leaders made proclamations about travelling on the “information superhighway”. These now cringe-worthy metaphors were suffused with a sense of intention. The internet was something you entered into in a deliberate way. This preceded what Rainie and Wellman (2012) term the “triple revolution” in social networking, mobile computing and ubiquitous internet access which led to the more diffuse or ambient modes of connectivity which are now the norm. Indeed, the confluence of these factors gave rise to the umbrella notion of “Web 2.0”, a label originally emerging from Silicon Valley’s early-2000s crash and subsequent rebranding to distinguish new firms from the economic carnage which surrounded them (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 2). While critics rightly point to the analytical limitations of this terminology, it still captures a shift in everyday user experience during this era. It *felt* different in non-trivial ways which we need to attend to analytically in order to gain purchase upon platform and agency over time.

The Web 2.0 phase grew from the affordances of mobile computing. Initially internet-enabled mobile phones, later smartphones, tablets and wearable devices. Simultaneously, wireless connectivity added new layers to how laptops could be used. Increasingly, users were regarded as “prosumers” who generated and shaped dynamic content rather than passively consuming it (Beer and Burrows 2007). Early icons of this era included the Wiki and the Social Networking Service, which then gave way to a more amorphous “social media”,

lately dominated by social video apps for creating and sharing multimedia. In reality this participation was always more branding than reality, offering a powerful frame through which claims about the revolutionary implications of these technologies could be made (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 2). Meanwhile, the rise of cloud computing undermined even the old spatial-temporal constraints: complex applications could now offload processing to distant servers, all accessible through a browser or specialised client. This shift underpins the platform ecosystem described above, connecting globally distributed infrastructures to user-facing devices for immersive, mobile and participatory engagement.

Only under these conditions could LLMs, like OpenAI's ChatGPT launched in November 2022, be developed into their current form. Their growth hinged on concentrated computational power and the vast datasets produced by the web and social networks, although innovations like the transformer architecture were equally critical. While they can generate strikingly coherent text in response to prompts, this shouldn't be confused with *Verstehen* or anything akin to it: these models remain grounded in mathematical formalisations of training data. In many respects, the development of LLMs continues the story of the "big data" which dominated the prior phase of digital change. This is the same register of infrastructural feedback loops which have now been the focus of political and economic competition for decades (Beer 2022; Morozov 2019). The novelty of LLMs lies less in displacing agency outright than in how they reorder when and where humans intervene in these data-driven processes. It is the sequence and intensity of that mediation which is shifting, rather than the fundamental interplay between system outputs and user agency. Even so, their natural language capacities create the possibility of a user-experience for digital systems which feels far more social, even if the underlying reality is much more ambiguous.

The Emergence of "Big Data"

In the summer of 2008, Wired editor-in-chief Chris Anderson (2008) published a widely circulated piece declaring that the "data deluge" entailed the "end of theory" and had rendered the "scientific method obsolete". Anderson offered a viewpoint frequently echoed in subsequent years: the sheer quantity of available data, combined with rapid computational advances, had moved us beyond a need for theoretical frameworks. That polemic thrust "big data" into popular discourse and has been cited thousands of times, even if many of these are critical engagements. Meanwhile, critical work on the topic emerged within the social sciences, alongside a data science which was widely framed as the defining occupation of platform capitalism, for example, Harvard Business Review's claim that data scientist was the "sexiest job of the 21st century" (Davenport and Patil 2012). In what follows I examine the sociology of this data evangelism, as it reflects transformations both within the academy and in a broader context of social change (Archer 2015; Lazega 2015; Carrigan 2017).

It illustrates the complex relationship between knowledge production and sociotechnical transformation, with our capacity to form knowledge *about* these changes itself being transformed by its own object of inquiry. While the terminology of “big data” has fallen out of use in recent years, it reflects the institutionalisation of these developments rather than their passing into historical obsolescence. What Fourcade and Healy (2024: loc 1237) describe as “the immense yield of the social substrate in the broadest sense, a source of data about what people are doing, writing, or saying ... that exists in a form that can be parsed, saved, and mined for information” is now so taken for granted that it doesn’t need to be designed in such a *gauche* manner as was the case in the early 2010s. The focus now is on “learning from data at any scale and scope” within real-world organisations with their “routines and managerial demands” in spite of tools which “are complex and often brittle” and data sources which are “incomplete, unrepresentative, internally incomparable, or subject to various forms of ‘drift’ over time” (Fourcade and Healy 2024: loc 1264). It’s no longer a matter of *preparing for the coming wave*, a rhetoric which prominently re-emerged in the LLM discourse, as much as grappling with the mundane challenges posed by a now familiar feature of any organisation which already relies on digital platforms.

If we historicise “big data” we can better explain the prestige of its practitioners and techniques, highlighting the social, cultural and technical conditions they are built upon. Through doing so we can better understand the organisational realities we now confront, as well as what they will mean for the institutionalisation of LLMs (Carrigan 2024: Chapter 8). As a concept “big data” often functions as a discursive shield, obscuring a host of problematic assumptions about both society and our ways of knowing it. To clarify these assumptions, we must disentangle the *epistemology* of transactional data from the advocacy circulating around it. I argue that transactional data fosters social asymmetries by institutionalising a divide between *engineers* and the *engineered*, though this is only one mechanism within an open system. Urgent questions remain about digitalisation’s political implications, which the social sciences must grapple with. Yet the accelerating influence of data science may erode the social science’s critical vantage point, risking a digital social science that cannot interrogate its own emergence under digital capitalism.

What does it mean for data to be “big”? Taken literally, it may seem nonsensical: data have no physical size, and so “big” or “small” can only be metaphors used for contrast. Usually, people invoke big data to suggest that new technologies have produced a volume outstripping prior storage and processing abilities. But “capacity” is inherently relative: think of the census as a kind of analogue of “big data”, covering entire populations rather than samples, which remains manageable for state agencies to conduct. Because volume alone can be slippery, other criteria have been proposed: velocity, variety, variability, veracity, visualisation and value. Such definitions feed into what Kitchin (2015) calls “data-boosterism” in which enthusiastic claims, rooted in commercial or institutional interests, shape how “big data” is marketed and deployed. There

is a parallel here to the elaborate languages of “prompt engineering” which have emerged around LLMs, inflating what is ultimately a literary form of engagement into something purporting to be an applied science (Carrigan 2024; Mollick 2024).

Beer (2016) suggests it helps to distinguish between “big data” as a material phenomenon (involving tangible social, technical and historical dimensions) and as an ideational one (constructing it philosophically and culturally). This dual lens clarifies how proponents gain traction within organisations by tapping into its symbolic power, even while its real structural affordances and constraints remain less examined. Every organisation needed to have a “big data” strategy just as every organisation is now expected to have an “AI” strategy, encouraging forms of strategic conduct associated with managing the organisational imperative rather than careful work with the sociotechnical reality underpinning it. Thus, the hyperbole surrounding “big data” often obscures the social contexts that shape its institutionalisation. We hear epochal pronouncements, “data is the new oil”, which blind us to the continuities with older forms of capitalism (Srnicek 2016). To understand how big data actually operates, we must locate it in historical perspective, not treat it as an epochal break.

The label can be misleading because it implies a stark break from earlier forms of data collection and analysis. In fact, large-scale data gathering (plus the use of databases, digital or analogue) has been part of governance, business and science for centuries. Williamson (2017: 30–31) propose two waves: the first wave being the “nineteenth-century avalanche of analogue numbers” tied to population management and rapid social transformation. The second wave emerged alongside modern digital infrastructure and devices, with transactional data generated as people engage with a panoply of networks and platforms. It’s these new forms of meditation, as well as the technical innovations leveraged for storage and analysis, that distinguished the “big data” of the 2010s from earlier forms of large-scale data gathering.

We can thus trace a material history of “big data” as social data, mapping its trajectory at the crossroads of technological development and the evolution of social statistics. But we also need to confront the notion itself, which in Beer’s (2016: 1–2) words “has achieved a profile and vitality that very few concepts attain”. This means grappling with its discursive power: why it resonates so strongly, often beyond its actual functionality in real-world applications. There is a risk of reducing methodological innovation into the social contexts that spawned it, yet ignoring what Savage (2013) terms *the social life of methods* would misread how techniques actually develop. Any credible account of how social knowledge arises must consider who invented these methods, what motivations drove them and how their deployment was driven by real-world imperatives. These methods emerge in a context and their development needs to be explained in terms of that context.

While Beer’s (2016: 2) analysis of “the discourse, terminology and rhetoric” of big data is illuminating, its Foucauldian orientation can overlook the people who enact these discourses in real-life contexts (Couldry 2020; Couldry and

Powell 2014). We can explore how “big data” conceptually partitions the social world in new ways, but translating that into actual social situations demands attention to structure, culture and agency (Archer 2013). We must see how “big data” is operationalised by organisations, experts and policy actors, with specific vested interests and ideological aims (Williamson 2019). Where do claims about methods and social data come from? What strategies do they enable? When “big data” is invoked, whose inferences gain legitimacy and which explanations are taken as authoritative?

Part of the difficulty for sociological analysis stems from the technical character of “big data”. Our disciplinary structures often segregate the “social” from the “technical”, creating a tendency to “black box” one or the other. Thus, we talk about “algorithms” or “big data” as if they were singular entities, ignoring how each remains contestable at the conceptual level and heavily shaped by social contexts (Gitelman 2013; Boyd and Crawford 2012). These phenomena have a sociocultural existence which cannot be reduced to technical categories, with “algorithms”, for example, figuring in the lifeworlds of agents in complex and multifaceted ways (Bucher 2018; Ruckenstein 2013). Staying within the black box leads us to a technical ontology that masks the deeper variability within sociotechnical systems, as well as what this means for the agents involved. The jargon we use, heavy with technicity, can obscure its social and cultural stakes. As Beer (2017) points out, the “algorithm” is a buzzword increasingly invoked amid anxieties about autonomy and control in digital capitalism. Resorting to purely technical language may inadvertently feed these narratives, while simultaneously obscuring where and how such systems sit in relation to the inherited categories of social theory.

Therefore the epistemic character of “big data”, the focus of the next section, must remain grounded in the context where data gets institutionalised. This inevitably involves confronting media infrastructure, a domain many social theorists have traditionally overlooked. As Couldry and Hepp (2017) discuss, there’s a historical rupture between social theory and media theory. Social theorists tend to either ignore media’s constitutive role or rely on outdated models of media systems. This disciplinary fragmentation is itself evolving in tandem with the phenomenon we seek to study. Not only are social platforms used by academics for networking and collaborating, increasingly they are institutionalised into structures of research evaluation and career development (Carrigan 2019; Carrigan and Jordan 2022). The danger is that digital social sciences forming under these conditions may drift towards a narrow empiricism, with a descriptive and explanatory horizon no broader than what registers as data on a given platform.

Without a diachronic perspective on what Pasquale (2015b) calls the “online order”, accounting for how it emerged over time, we treat the political economy of digital capitalism as an unacknowledged *condition for*, rather than *object of*, social scientific inquiry. This stifles the emancipatory potentials of social science, reducing digital inquiry as a mechanism through which present conditions can be reproduced by powerful actors. Despite talk of a “golden age

of social science” many older disciplines are being sidelined as corporate data science takes root in vast global firms. As Nielsen and Ganter (2022: loc 4583) note, it’s no wonder that quantitative experts gravitate towards the compensation and research advantages big companies offer. But this leaves academics in legacy institutions increasingly shut out from platform data, raising the prospect of “platformed research” with direct access available only to a limited cadre of academics (Nielsen and Ganter 2022: loc 4869).

The Epistemology of Transactional Data

We can understand the emergence of transactional data in historical terms, grounded in the rise of digitalisation to a point where vast portions of everyday life are now mediated by digital platforms. This new epistemological dimension to social life, where a growing majority of routine activities produce digital data as a by-product through public and private infrastructure, demands we rethink conventional social science methods in light of platform capitalism. As Savage and Burrows (2007: 892) put it in an early exploration of this question, “in the current situation, where data on whole populations are routinely gathered as a by-product of institutional transactions, the sample survey seems a very poor instrument”. Their argument that this inevitable moment of comparison is precipitating a crisis in empirical sociology brings into focus what Halford (2015) calls the “politics of discipline”: is it the remit of mathematicians and statisticians, computer scientists or “domain experts” such as sociologists and anthropologists? Who is regarded as having sufficient qualification to take advantage of the epistemic opportunities enabled by these developments?

The analytical challenge here is to disentangle the epistemological, technical and institutional forces in play. Transactional data is typically regarded as both an institutional opportunity and an epistemic gain, with real institutional stakes for those whose works and careers are bound up with these developments. In its most blunt form the argument suggests that transactional data is simply superior to legacy sampling methods: cheaper, more comprehensive and more revealing. But what underpins that superiority? Debates over the epistemic qualities of transactional data are inseparable from disciplinary politics in Halford’s (2015) sense because of their grounding in institutional realities concerning who can produce and deploy such data. Consequently how we frame “big data” carries more than intellectual weight, it can be existential for social science as a whole. It is implicated in questions of discipline, legitimacy and expertise which extend far beyond what might seem to be a superficially technical matter.

Although data evangelism may be philosophically dubious, it exerts powerful institutional leverage that even its critics can exploit. Meanwhile, the alleged radical break with prior approaches often erases historical continuities: evangelists proclaim a new epoch for social science, discarding all that came before. Take the example of unobtrusive measurement, often framed as capturing what people “really” do rather than what they “say” they do. This is often celebrated

as a revolution in social research, freeing us from a dangerous reliance on nebulous interpretation (Couldry 2014; Andrejevic 2013). Yet as Marres (2017) points out, unobtrusive methods have long existed in sociological toolkits, even if the ubiquity of digital platforms creates fresh opportunities. Furthermore, naturalising online behaviour in this way obscures the manifold ways in which platforms shape the action of their users (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 3). These are not “natural” actions unencumbered by context but rather a new register of action taking place in a new class of context. The problem lies in conflating data’s ontology (transactions occurring in a digital system) with data’s epistemic authority (the social truth carried in the ensuing data). This obscures the variable interaction between them, fuelling a destructive methodological rift which makes it difficult to grapple with a real and enduring development. The problem is not the claim that transactional data *can* offer an epistemic advantage vis-a-vis familiar forms of social data but rather that this advantage is necessary and inherent, rather than a contingent feature of particular relations.

Focusing on transactional data raises fundamental questions about data ontology that often remain obscure. While investigating data production is sometimes labelled as constructionist, critical realism from Bhaskar (1978, 1989) onwards has insisted on examining how “facts” come into being. We approach truth through facts which are socially constructed. It’s helpful here to distinguish the constitution of data (*where and how it is stored*) from the construction of data (*how it is created*). What’s special about transactional data does not lie in its constitution: digitised data storage is routine, even though the exact moment digitalisation occurs can vary widely. Nor is novelty found in it being digital from the start. For instance, qualitative interviews recorded via smartphone also yield content which is digital from the outset (Back 2020).

What is new about transactional data is how it blends digital constitution, digital construction and an absence of elicitation. Transactional data is inherently digital, born from the infrastructures mediating social actions. It resembles other digital data forms, but arises in situ as a by-product of existing processes rather than through deliberate or experimental intervention. Its epistemic status diverges from legacy forms of qualitative or quantitative research data for this reason. Though recognising this doesn’t negate the significant intervention, often referred to as a data carpentry or data munging, required to prepare it for analysis. These emergent properties are oversimplified if we just call them “behavioural traces” in the manner which has been dominant within the computational social sciences, for example, as Lazer et al. (2009: 721) frame it in an early account of how we “live life in the network”:

When we wake up in the morning, we check our e-mail, make a quick phone call, walk outside (our movements captured by a high definition video camera), get on the bus (swiping our RFID mass transit cards) or drive (using a transponder to zip through the tolls). We arrive at the airport, making sure to purchase a sandwich with a credit card before boarding the plane, and check our BlackBerries shortly before takeoff.

Or we visit the doctor or the car mechanic, generating digital records of what our medical or automotive problems are. We post Blog entries confiding to the world our thoughts and feelings, or maintain personal social network profiles revealing our friends and tastes.

By assembling the “digital breadcrumbs” each of these interactions yields, one can move beyond the limits of “one-shot self-reported data on relationships” in order to achieve “increasingly comprehensive pictures of both individuals and groups” (Lazer et al. 2009: 721). Each breadcrumb emerges from a digital action, embedded within and dependent upon a digital infrastructure, but the reflexive quality of these underlying actions diverges greatly. Identifying that someone has done something tells us nothing about *why* they have done it. Nor does it tell us about why the outcome *matters* to them (Sayer 2011). There are actions which often have a significant reflexive component, such as expressing our thoughts and feelings through social media. Even this can frequently be a form of pseudo-catharsis, as Winlow and Hall (2013: 73) put it, in which we scratching an itch or “filling the void” (Gilroy-Ware 2017; Williams 2018). In contrast there are seemingly minimally reflexive actions, such as choosing a convenience store, which can sometimes might be bound up in a deliberate project, such as boycotting a certain firm or collecting loyalty points for a particular reason. Not only is the reflexive dimension irreducible but it is deeply (and unpredictably) *variable* in a way which complicates attempts to eviscerate human agency: to reduce the ontology of our psychobiography to the epistemology of the traces our actions leaves when they intersect with digital platforms.

The Evisceration of Human Agency

In the previous section, we considered how, as Mouzelis (2008: 75) puts it, “the way in which subjects relate to virtual or actual social structures is not constant but variable”, highlighting its implications for the relationship between platforms and agency. We need an understanding of agency that acknowledges this variability without lapsing into a voluntarism that ignores social structure. If it is obscured, or ontologically veiled in Pickering’s (2010) terms, we are left with a human being emptied of properties and powers (Archer 2000). Agency is then reduced to action alone, understood solely through the transactional data it produces. The problem is especially pronounced when we consider user-generated content: produced, circulated and consumed on social media platforms. If we collapse agency into action, we lose the capacity to account for why these people have produced this content in the way in which they have. This is reflexive behaviour, which needs to be explained by reference to the social context in manner comparable to any other undertaking, even if digital infrastructure needs to figure more prominently in our account of that context.

There are undoubtedly legitimate concerns about the “addictive” character of such platforms, especially in how they are continually optimised to maximise user engagement (Eyal 2014; Schull 2012). However much platform activity

is clearly *social* action, orientated towards the (re)actions of others. Even if a user is driven by a compulsive need to seek the recognition which social platforms offer, the content they produce cannot be understood beyond the vernacular of the platform, their social networks and their (fallible) interpretations at the intersection between the two. This sociality is mediated by the platform's technical architecture: follower counts, "likes", "shares" and "retweets", etc. (van Dijck 2013). Such social reflexivity often entails technical reflexivity: users evaluate themselves in relation to categories coded into the infrastructure itself. They calibrate their behaviour in response to feedback from others and/or the system, reshaping the context which other connected users inhabit (Pasquale 2015a). Moreover, commercial imperatives continually drive platform operators to refine their architecture in pursuit of greater engagement, producing an accelerated recursivity reminiscent of, though distinct from, familiar structure/agency dynamics.

It's faster, digitally mediated and characterised by a profound informational asymmetry (Andrejevic 2013: loc 464). Reducing the relational complexity of these interactions to mere behaviour, registered in the traces left by digital transactions, overlooks urgent questions about how platform ubiquity transforms social life and the participants within it. It is weirdly disinterested in the causal power of the platform context to condition behaviour, instead treating transactional data in a naturalistic and atomistic way: as *what people do when they think no one is looking*, to paraphrase the subtitle of a book by a prominent data scientist (Rudder 2014). In spite of the applied orientation of much data science, particularly within tech firms, there's a methodological inconsistency in how user behaviour is analysed. Data scientists initially treat user behaviour as naive, transparent data points that "speak for themselves". However, when they actively intervene in the platform to test hypotheses, they suddenly acknowledge methodological complexity but only on an ad hoc basis for that specific intervention. This approach fails to recognise that the platform itself is fundamentally a field of potential interventions that constantly shape user behaviour. Consequently, critical causal questions about platform influence are obscured, making it impossible to adequately theorise the complex relationship between platforms and user agency.

We must recover the specificity of transactional data, recognising that it cannot be adequately reduced to behavioural traces (Marres 2017). Social media data exemplifies why such reductionism is flawed, but the broader point is that many orthodox framings of transactional data collapse action into behaviour. This obscures vast dimensions of meaningful human activity, including how infrastructural design shapes that activity. It's not just the immediate context which gets lost but the prior (inter)action which explains why that context took the form it did, at that specific moment in time. Resisting this collapse does not deny the relevance of behaviour when examining platform capitalism. After all, not all action is social despite a growing theoretical tendency to assume otherwise (Archer 2000; Campbell 1998). Indeed, some of the most politically pertinent features of digital capitalism involve deliberate

attempts to manipulate behaviour at scale (Davies 2015). It simply insists that we need to recognise *action* online, as well as behaviour, including the conceptual complexity involved in distinguishing between the two.

Unfortunately, the dominant “big data” framing downplays the human element in social digitalisation, propelling a powerful cultural moment that eviscerates the human by depriving us of reflexivity, normativity and first-person perspective (Couldry and Hepp 2017). Instead of being reflexive contributors to a profound social transformation, individuals are cast as passive objects susceptible to intervention. I suggest there is a bifurcation here in data science between its operation in a naturalistic mode (treating user behaviour as transparent and self-explanatory) and an applied mode (designing interventions to shape user behaviour). The first implies a platform voluntarism which imagines neutral tools which merely express the agency of their users, allowing data scientists to draw direct inferences about users from their digital traces. The second implies a platform determinism in which the platforms mould user behaviour in predictable and reliable ways, driven by deliberate interventions in pursuit of commercial and organisational goals. Rather than representing coherent ontological positions, these contradictory stances serve the operational requirements of platform capitalism, with understandings of platform and agency emerging from practical imperatives rather than serving as theoretical foundations for practice. This oscillation between voluntarism and determinism reflects whether the immediate objective is observation or intervention for data scientists working within a specific context. To provide a genealogy of these ontological positions would be a significant work in its own right, though they clearly circulate around the utopian and dystopian tendencies explored earlier in this chapter.

Despite the excitement surrounding this “flood of data” and the prospect of renewed naturalism in social science, transactional data itself does not necessitate a behaviouristic interpretation (Conte et al. 2012). Instead, an ideological supplement drives a cultural project to conquer the interpretive ambiguities of social life. Proponents believe digital data reveals “who we are when we think no one’s looking” to use Rudder’s (2014) revealing phrase. There is an aspiration towards a “utopia of total social legibility” which is as implausible as it is influential (Little 2016). The intellectual commitments amongst designers, engineers and scientists in academia, government and commerce exert real influence. In fact this influence is a crucial dimension of platform and agency, empowering a specific group of agents in a novel and significant way. Their conceptual categories became coded into ubiquitous systems that mediate social life, proving real in their consequences even if their descriptions are partial and misleading. There is a naturalist ideology here which aspires to read the “book of the social” with the same clarity as the “book of nature” has been read through a past wave of technical innovation (Barnes and Wilson 2014).

In order to move through this impasse, we need to recover personal reflexivity as a mechanism which conditions the variable ways in which agents relate to platforms. In fact platforms presuppose this reflexivity as the normative and

affective raw material which fuels user participation in their operations, even as it simultaneously poses an obstacle to the total social legibility which data evangelists aspire towards. In the next chapter, we'll explore how personal reflexivity mediates the relationship between platforms and agents, demonstrating that far from being determined by digital infrastructure, agents actively navigate, appropriate and sometimes resist platform architectures through their reflexive capacities.

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7 Personal Reflexivity

The ubiquity of personal computers, smartphones and tablets makes it difficult to recognise their deep ontological significance, even as we recognise their obvious practical impact. This influence has often been cast in epochal terms, recalling the poetics of the detraditionalisation thesis from section one, telling powerful stories about how everything has been changed by these developments. Yet stories about how *everything* has changed struggle to account for *what* specifically has changed and *why* it has changed in the way it has. To answer these questions we need to attend to the personal reflexivity which accounts for the variability of how subjects relate to platforms.

There are powerful moral sources underpinning the poetics of the “digital age”, particularly the “coupling” between human and machine which, it is imagined, would vastly expand our human powers (Wu 2010: 161–171; Turner 2006). The realisation of our contemporary digital capacities required a breakthrough both technological and economic: the miniaturisation and commodification that brought computers into the home and into the hands of everyday consumers. By enabling non-specialists to harness its mechanical capabilities, the personal computer turned formerly astonishing possibilities into routine facets of daily life: enabling us to video call distant family members on the other side of the world, stream a near infinite library of cultural content on demand or place orders for groceries to be delivered at a time of our convenience.

This “triple revolution” of high-speed internet, mobile computing and social networking so thoroughly shapes our concept of change that it is almost taken for granted (Rainie and Wellman 2012). Yet following Wu (2010: 171–172) what may be even more significant is how these technologies serve as “a type of thinking aid – whether the task is to remember things (an address book), to organize prose (a word processor), or to keep track of friends (social networking software)”. This promise took newly concrete form in the large language models (LLMs) which were released in the final stages of this project. Even if there are vast political, economic and ecological challenges raised by LLMs, it’s difficult to engage with them in an open way and not see immediate possibilities for such “thinking aids” (Carrigan 2014). There is a relational account needed here of how our trajectories of interaction with technological artefacts expands the (potential) scope of our agency, including the reality of

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collaboration and cooperation with “artificial intelligence” as expressed in the rapidly evolving capabilities of LLMs (Archer 2019). However, this relational account would be misleading if it is not informed by a prior account of how these technologies constitute a context for action, a dynamic which my notion of *platform and agency* is intended to provide a framework for grasping.

In what follows I use “platform” as a broad term for the interconnected technology (such as cloud storage, cloud computing and social networking) through which we experience the constraints and affordances of modern computing. These systems draw together technological developments in an internally complex but nonetheless singular form, available to distributed users through programmed and predictable modes of action. They are infrastructures through which power is exercised, mediating social relations and facilitating capital accumulation in new ways. But they are also mundane objects encountered in their “front stage” dimension as a routine feature of daily experience, to recall the discussion from the previous chapter.

While the corporate embrace of the term offers a reason for caution, I argue it is analytically useful for three reasons: it avoids the purely instrumental view of technology as tools, foregrounds the coordinating capacity of these systems, and highlights the divergent interests among those who interact with them (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021). Moreover, it provides an organising principle for understanding technologies (e.g. “the algorithm”) that might otherwise appear as an amorphous and sinister orchestrating presence. It provides a microsocial grounding for these influences which helps us trace out the connection between everyday life and wider forces. Here, I use “platform” to encompass not only the broader technological landscape where platforms dominate but also as a conceptual frame for grasping the sociotechnical dynamics that shape people’s everyday activities and interactions.

Despite growing attention to digital platforms, the question of agency remains surprisingly neglected. While some integrative works, such as Kennedy, Poell, and van Dijck (2015) or Couldry and Hepp (2017), address platform *and* agency, these remain exceptions. Too often, the platform itself becomes the singular focus, with agency discussed only insofar as it relates to the platform’s characteristics. This leads to what Archer (1995) calls “downwards conflation” where agency appears wholly shaped by the platform and ignores cultural meanings or values that fall outside the remit of algorithmic power (Pasquale, 2015a, 2015b). This is not the platform determinism which I suggested in the last chapter that data scientists are prone to, at least in their *intervening* modes. But there is a tendency in the platform studies literature to tacitly inflate the causal power of platforms vis-a-vis agency, either through a limited conception of agency or disregarding it all together. Though many platform scholars do consider agency, it is often *in spite* of their conceptual frameworks rather than because of them, making it hard to sustain a focus on agency beyond its function within digital architectures. This risks overlooking how users co-produce platform norms, standards and cultures, instead collapsing human agency into the role of “user” alone (Burgess and Baym 2020).

This chapter contributes to a broader inquiry into the problem of **platform and agency**: an area well-suited to realist social theory. It begins by examining four sociotechnical conditions shaping personal reflexivity, which provide a foundation for considering sociotechnical transformation in terms of *psychobiography* and *personal morphogenesis* in later chapters:

- 1 The multiplications of communication channels
- 2 The digitalisation of the archives
- 3 The problem of abundance
- 4 Curation and filtering

The following chapter then turns to two conditions influencing *collective reflexivity*, ease of mobilisation and computational politics, exploring the sociopolitical questions they raise. While this approach cannot exhaust the complexity of platform and agency, it offers a social realist micro-sociology of reflexivity that focuses on everyday life while recognising how structural factors such as life chances and social roles condition the personal possibilities available to an individual (Archer 2000). In this sense, it begins with individuals but remains resolutely non-individualistic, supplying micro-foundations for a meso- and macro-level theory of a world saturated by platforms. By doing so, we can recover a rich, multifaceted sense of the agent in platform society which transcends the role of “user” or the narrow constraints of sociotechnical conditions. Only then can we explain sweeping societal changes in a way that acknowledges the reality of platform power yet preserves the capacity for personal flourishing and collective resistance. These are capabilities that will prove crucial in the coming decades (Couldry 2024).

Personal Reflexivity: The Multiplication of Communication Channels

In recent years, we have witnessed such a rapid proliferation of digital phenomena that some argue the social sciences should focus more on description than explanation (Beer and Burrows 2007). As these phenomena are intensely morphogenic, they generate additional novelty at macro, meso and micro levels. By their nature they tend to interact, with each other and existing drivers of change, in order to produce complex hybrid forms which are themselves intensely morphogenic. This emerges from a confluence of factors: broad diffusion of new technology (smartphones, tablets, broadband, Wi-Fi, mobile networks, etc.), robust venture capital despite uncertain profitability and an evolving market capitalism that accommodates these conditions. Not only has there been a dizzying spread of consumer-facing platforms competing for the attention of smartphone-equipped users but there is also continual churn, with an accelerating cycle of platform birth, growth, and death. Even as specific services (e.g. Myspace) rise and fall, they do so within a landscape of multiplying communication channels. New innovations can reinvigorate previously waning channels, as with the app-driven resurgence of text messaging, resulting

in a sociotechnical context hosting an ever-expanding array of communicative possibilities, where the motives for their use cannot be assumed in advance.

Miller (2011) and his collaborators call this pluralisation of communication channels *polymedia*, noting the absence of established norms to govern their use (Miller and Sinanan 2014). These are not just new ways to communicate, their novelty calls into question established norms governing communication, as well as raising questions of how we select between them and in which circumstances. As Miller and Sinanan (2014: 135) explain,

if the grounds for choosing a media or the way people configured their combination of media was no longer based upon access or cost, then the reasons people choose, and even more importantly, the reasons others would impute to their choices were now presumed by others to be social and moral.

This leads to a *quantitative* escalation in communication but also a *qualitative* change following from the expanded range of communicative activity and the greater necessity for personal reflexivity entailed by this range. The change itself and the challenge it poses each necessitate that agents *grapple* with it, generating a vast popular discourse and grey literature concerning the norms of communication which anyone working with an organisation will have encountered. The sociotechnical development renders reflexivity imperative in Archer's (2012) sense, even if their reflexive responses will be variable in structured (though not determined) ways.

It is often claimed that digital technology makes social life more distracted or superficial, leading to a loss of humane qualities assumed to be in ready supply during past times. Consider, for example, Turkle's (2015: loc 419) influential portrayal of "the first generation of children that grew up with smart phones" who are:

Intelligent and creative, they are at the beginning of their careers, but employers report that they come to work with unexpected phobias and anxieties. They don't know how to begin and end conversations. They have a hard time with eye contact. They say that talking on the telephone makes them anxious.

If we take issue with this portrayal it does mean denying there are changes in social disposition which might have a causal connection to smartphone usage. Instead we only need to query the generational generalisation and the portrayal of this change as a linear process of loss, a classic example of Taylor's (2007) subtraction story. The common sense feel of the representation, capturing traits which everyone has encountered in at least *some* millennials, smoothes over the problematic nature of the generalisation. An equally common rejoinder is that people have decried every major technological shift in much the same way. There can be no problem with smartphones because every media innovation has provoked a comparable moral panic.

While this chapter takes the notion of *distracted people* seriously, it argues that the underlying mechanisms are frequently misunderstood. Rather than attributing distraction to technology alone, the sociotechnical innovations previously discussed appear to generate two tendencies at the level of personal reflexivity:

- 1 A first-order escalation in the demands placed on individuals' attention.
- 2 A second-order reduction in their capacity for sustained reflexivity, arising from the diverse coping strategies people employ.

While these tendencies shape agency, they do not fully dictate it. Instead, individuals respond in real time, revising motives and strategies to navigate intensifying demands. It's a shift in the water in which they swim, rather than an external force pressing down upon them. Because humans cannot truly multitask, despite common claims to the contrary (Levitin 2014; Wajcman 2020: 104), task-interruption deserves serious consideration as a cognitive phenomenon with social implications (Altmann and Trafton 2007; Ratwani et al. 2008). However, the argument here is not simply that "constant connectivity" makes us more distractible. While Archer (2015) rightly notes that digital communications, like mobile phones and television, subtract time from internal conversation, the effects extend well beyond those who adopt expressive reflexivity living episodically with minimal sustained reflection. This is a matter of unintended temporal consequences mediated through the operation of reflexivity elsewhere in the lifeworld, rather than an intrinsic power of the technological artefact reshaping the nature of the human.

The same mechanisms that facilitate expressive reflexivity also encourage tendencies among other reflexive modes that truncate reflexivity unintentionally. This occurs through the *triaging* necessary to handle mounting situational pressures. While platforms and communication overload constrain reflexivity, they do not obliterate it, with individuals adapting in real-time through partial or strategic coping measures. Or failing to cope. The crucial point is they are *responding*, even if counterproductively.

The social acceleration literature has often focused on technology's radical impact on working life (Agger 2004; Crary 2014), but its treatment of agency can be problematic. Either agency is overlooked entirely or conceptualised so generally that it misses the day-to-day reflexivity people use to navigate the lifeworld (Archer 2007). This tendency encourages a form of technological determinism, reducing individuals to mere recipients of change. This literature comprehensively misses what Wajcman (2020) describes as "the detailed manner and circumstances in which time is organized into daily routines by gendered individuals within households" as this abstracted individualism obscures "the vicissitudes of scheduling and the intricacy with which our lives are tied to others" (Wajcman 2020: 65).

Still, the social acceleration perspective does identify a key empirical concern: why has intensive time pressure become so pervasive despite the spread of

labour-saving technologies, and without a real reduction in available free time? Drawing on Wajcman (2020), several explanations emerge:

- Individualised time-use data can mask household inequalities.
- Norms and technologies co-evolve so that time-saving devices do not necessarily save time.
- Attempts to relieve time-pressure by multi-tasking ironically intensify it.

As the temporal structure of daily life shifts, susceptibility to task-switching rises and brings associated cognitive costs. Prolonged reflection becomes less likely to commence when life's temporal density is high, and once interrupted, it tends not to resume until those demands subside. If we're rushing through a day in pursuit of a range of overlapping goals, we rarely stop to reflect on our pursuit. This might come later when we find time to rest, but if we're exhausted from the struggle then we'll often use that time for recuperation rather than (meta) reflexivity. I'm primarily considering this in relation to mediated communication, given its foundational role in "a digital age", but the sociologists of time are making a broader point here: the temporal load we are subject to changes how we relate to the tasks which constitute that load (Wajcman 2020; Rosa 2013). It's a shift in the adverbial register: *how* we do things rather than *what* we do.

A similar dynamic appears in working life. Multiple communication channels often inflate the expectations tied to a job without adding extra time to complete them. The morphogenic nature of these channels means each can be applied to existing responsibilities, thereby expanding the role. For example, as Carrigan (2019) describes, academics increasingly feel pressured to use social media to disseminate findings: a practice that can require ever-greater engagement, for example, it's always possible to spend more time on online content creation, at least until it becomes your full time job. This phenomenon is especially noticeable in sectors where mastering new platforms has become part of an unspoken job description and where constrained career paths hinge on free labour (e.g. internships or unpaid online content) in hope of "discovery" (Conor, Gill and Taylor 2015). Journalism illustrates this trend: developing a personal brand via diverse channels is crucial in a highly competitive environment that favours a few well-known bylines. However, any field in which new communication platforms open fresh possibilities for fulfilling professional duties is susceptible to this role expansion. Not only are roles "greedy", as Archer (2000) once put it, sociotechnical change is creating a tendency for them to become greedier over time. Platforms encourage new practices in relation to these challenges but do not dictate them; agents still choose how to adopt, intensify or reject these possibilities.

Moreover, a growing reliance on quantitative metrics reinforces these trends, as the digital mediation of new occupational tasks opens the door to what Lazega (2014) calls digitalised social control. Power relations between workers and management can shift, with technological novelty incentivising a "numbers

game” or arms race in which strategies that are individually effective (e.g. tweeting more frequently) raise the collective bar. Under these conditions, success hinges on visibility, which often boils down to “shouting louder” than one’s peers. As Beer (2012: 480) puts it, “Academics who are able to viral-market themselves are likely to be the winners in this situation”. Yet lack of equal starting points fosters further ossification. Dean (2010) describes power-law distributions across digital networks, where a small minority reaps most rewards and the majority is left behind. In scholarship, this manifests in “unread and unloved” publications (Back 2008), and in music, countless unrecognised artists hoping for commercial success (Beer 2012). New channels thus reshape occupational roles while making them “greedier”: the logic of visibility demands limitless self-promotion, escalating requirements for those vying for recognition.

Personal Reflexivity: The Digitalisation of the Archive

While the multiplication of communication channels manifests itself in the present-tense demands placed upon the subject, against a backdrop of intensifying workplace pressures and competitive individualism, the significance of the digitalised archive concerns the *future* orientation of subjects: how the present “I”, always conditioned by the past “me”, relates to the “future” you. As Wiley (2006: 9) puts it, “if we attempt to foresee the various paths along which we might go, we can clearly see what is right for us”. How does platformisation effect this forward-looking dimension of reflexivity? What shifts occur in how individuals imagine their future selves in a world recast by the “triple revolution”? And how do these shifts alter the process of shaping a life?

Giddens (1991: 84) pointed to these issues while discussing globalised media: it reveals “a multifarious number of milieux ... visible to anyone who cares to glean the relevant investigation” and that the “collage effect of television and newspapers gives specific form to the juxtaposition of settings and potential lifestyle choices”. However, he offered little insight into why some outcomes occur more frequently than others. Archer (2014) and Maccarini (2012) see a similar gap in Rosa’s (2013) acceleration theory, which claims the good life’ has become a “full” life: doing as much as possible with as many people, in as many places. As Maccarini (2012: 64) emphasises, any shift in temporal structure does not automatically produce this ethos. Rather we need a robust theory of culture, personal reflexivity and human flourishing to explain this shift in moral psychology, assuming it’s an empirically accurate observation.

Maccarini (2012: 63) further observes that because “the cultural system is never fully integrated, people can tap into these or other resources”, raising the question of how these cultural influences are structurally patterned, rather than assuming they exercise an equal influence across all people in all contexts. Recognising this contingency demands that we explain how the cultural system is mediated socioculturally, an issue the triple revolution profoundly recasts at the personal level. In a personalised web accessible from any device, “offline” ceases to exist and we carry the digital archive everywhere we go.

This has profound implications for how the *cultural resources* and *resources of the self* we considered in the first section are drawn upon through personal reflexivity. How does platformisation effect the ways individuals represent their future selves and align current actions with those futures they hope to embrace or avoid? I define the archive as a social order's store of cultural variety: ideational content (propositions, categories, labels, metaphors, analogies, etc.) that subjects think with and through. Analysing precisely how specific cultural items (books, sites, films, etc.) are formed or broken down exceeds this chapter's scope, as do detailed explorations of the specificities of cultural forms such as those considered by Porpora (2003). Cultural variety is drawn upon internally in "modelling our options, internally, so we can visualise the choices that lie before us" (Wiley 2006: 14), but this may be done in a range of different ways.

We are invariably oriented towards a future "you": one or more possible selves that shape the horizon of our present actions. Absent a clear representation of these futures, we face a vacuum revealing uncertainty about how today's choices connect to tomorrow's outcomes. Such representations are never created in a social void: they emerge, intentionally or unintentionally, from cultural materials at hand. Here, I refer to this domain of cultural resources as the archive and argue that its ongoing platformisation fundamentally alters how we imagine who we might become in an era of intensifying social morphogenesis. By examining the structure of this digital archive, often neglected in sweeping accounts of social and cultural transformation, I aim to explain why some individuals flourish while others struggle under expanding opportunities and choices. In doing so, I highlight how these diverse outcomes, both individual and collective, feed back into further transformations. The archive's digital shift does not dictate personal trajectories but conditions them, leaving room for reflexivity and resistance.

Referring to the platformisation of the archive implies a historical transformation, shifting from an analogue repository to a digital one. While archives were once entirely analogue, embodied in books and other physical media, the reality is more nuanced than a simple analogue-digital dichotomy. I do not aim here to chronicle every aspect of this transition, which has unfolded unevenly across various contexts, rather, I focus on platformisation as an ongoing process. This is not a unitary phenomenon, but we can identify a "tipping point" traced through empirical indicators (Porpora 2013).

Recognising this tipping point allows us to ask whether the digitalisation of the archive represents a qualitative shift in the cultural conditions of human life. Previously, similar tipping points occurred with the emergence of language or the first externalised information storage (e.g. cave art and bodily adornment) around 35,000–45,000 years ago (Bentley and O'Brien 2012). Viewed on this grand timescale, the "messy" history of digitalisation, so often compressed into simplistic narratives of the internet or globalisation, becomes more tractable. The digital archive is not monolithic but intensifies a long-evolving capacity to store, share and reshape cultural resources.

Building on these insights, I turn to a specific case study: the archive's relationship to memory. This might appear counterintuitive, yet investigating how people use the archive to construct a sense of the past can shed light on how they might employ the same structures to envision the future. In her work on "mediated memories" van Dijck (2007) describes the shift from predominantly analogue "memory objects" to a digital norm. This does not mean the analogue form is disappearing entirely; indeed, there are second-order effects driving renewed appreciation for older media in their relative scarcity. Consider the contemporary enthusiasm for vinyl records for example. As Hoskins (2009) notes, digitalisation alters how memory objects circulate, reshaping the culture of memorialisation in which they originate. Activities once mostly private now lean, even inadvertently, towards public self-presentation. Personal experiences quickly transform into publicly shared memories (Reading 2009). These newly visible archives of personal history may also shape how individuals project future selves: an interplay between reflecting on who we were and imagining who we could be.

Platformisation reframes how we recall the past and imagine the future, two facets of a single process (Garde-Hansen et al. 2009). Drawing on Boyd's (2014) framework, platform mediation exhibits *persistence*, *visibility*, *spreadability* and *searchability*: affordances that effect both memory and future-oriented vision, as well as the connection between them. For instance, persistent digital records make it harder to reinvent ourselves in the present, the psychobiographical corollary of what Mayer-Schönberger (2011) calls the "end of forgetting". Meanwhile, the spreadability and searchability of memories significantly expand how others' past experiences can impinge on our current sense of self. Once confined to small circles, these recorded memories (and associated future aspirations) can now routinely enter our personal orbit through digital channels. We might evade or ignore them, yet such acts of agency reflect the deeper biographical impacts of a platformised social environment. Beyond memory alone, this is a question of broader mediation. As van Dijck (2007: 24) explains,

Since the 1950s, we no longer need to derive our personal tastes or cultural preferences mainly from social circles close to us, because media have expanded the potential reservoir for cultural exchange to much larger, even global, proportions.

What Thompson (2013: 233) describes in a similar vein as "new opportunities, new options, new arenas for self-experimentation" illustrates the implications for personhood at stake in the development of the media. These expanded media channels "lift out" cultural preferences from local contexts, forging new ways of shaping both our retrospective and prospective sense of self. There is an enormous array of texts, media and ideas in circulation: all potentially representations of who we could become or avoid becoming. While this abundance can be viewed as a liberating effect of disembedding mechanisms, it can also induce a sense of vertigo (Giddens 1991; Young 2007). My aim here is to

move beyond these dual interpretations by analysing how the platformisation of the archive intersects with the intensification of social morphogenesis, focusing on the *practical* challenges of shaping a life in the face of unprecedented cultural variety. The platform archive expands possibilities without prescribing how individuals must respond.

Personal Reflexivity: The Problem of Abundance

It is often observed that digital technology has ignited an explosion in cultural production. Cyber-utopians like Shirky (2008, 2010) celebrate the “mass amateurization” these technologies enable. Meanwhile, slightly less utopian but still optimistic commentators such as Gauntlett (2013) point to a long tradition of “amateur craft” being undervalued, arguing that critiques of the “cult of the amateur” echo attempts by elites to protect their professional boundaries. This blur between consumer and producer has been conceptualised in terms of the “prosumer”: someone who both generates content and responds to it, either by reflecting on external content or remixing it to form new creations. Many of the billions of YouTube views each day might be from such “remixes” which require extensive media consumption to splice multiple clips into a cohesive, greater whole. Moreover, this practice depends on the background literacy that allows creators to select and recombine material effectively.

This explosion of user-driven content underscores the increasing availability of creative tools that can facilitate personal and collective reflexivity. There has been a radical growth in creative production afforded by platforms with a vested interest in promoting such user participation (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 2). As van Dijck (2013: loc 3290) notes, “the majority of large, mainstream platforms gauge content in terms of quantity, often measured by its potential to draw massive numbers of users”: the whole attentional economy rests on sustaining this process of escalation, with specific platforms exhibiting a deliberate bias in their architecture towards creating a cadre of social media stars. The resulting tendency to “publicize successful outliers to propagate the illusion”, as Nichols (2015) puts it, has some profound implications for human flourishing which we’ll return to shortly (Johnson, Carrigan and Brock 2019).

Yet we must address quality as well as quantity in discussing this cultural explosion. If cultural variety refers to ideas available for thinking-with (i.e. offering meaningful resources for reflexivity), much contemporary production does not meet that threshold. Furthermore, an increase in output does not guarantee a parallel rise in variety. For instance, as Birnbaum (2015) observes, most selfies reflect a limited repertoire of poses, despite driving an explosion of online images. Similarly, the filtering of existing content without adding new perspectives has defined the growth of blogging (Rosenberg 2009), especially on micro-blogging platforms like Twitter (now X). Thus, recognising the scale of production prompts us to investigate the escalatory processes behind it, even if the raw increase does not automatically broaden cultural variety. The platform archive can homogenise as much as it diversifies.

Commercial interests drive much of the output growth and, in doing so, can erode communication quality. Content farms, for example, rely on poorly paid freelancers who, rushing to produce algorithm-driven pieces, lack the time for depth or reflection. The insertion of LLMs into this political economy has the potential to turbocharge these processes (Carrigan 2024). Shenk's (1997) early warning about "data smog" highlights how information overload can impede judgment, pointing towards how Andrejevic's (2013) "infoglut" would come to disorientate the exercise of our agency. These escalatory pressures are especially evident in commercial communication, where any successful tactic for capturing attention quickly spreads among competitors. This cancels out its advantage and triggers an endless cycle of innovation and imitation. While rational for individual actors, this intensifies field-level challenges: both quantity and quality escalate in ways that fragment audience attention, prompting backlash and necessitating further strategic adjustments. One self-described "media manipulator" (Holiday 2012) has called for an end to these tactics, warning of the harmful implications for social and political life.

Lastly, the interplay of computational innovation and marketing imperatives has produced a staggering rise in what we commonly call "spam". Yet, as Brunton (2013) notes, this term masks a complex phenomenon deeply intertwined with internet history. Familiar spam appears as "constantly repeating messages of crushing banality" unleashed at a scale previously unimaginable (Brunton 2013: loc 120). The problem extends to automated spam bots that threaten to flood social media, leading platforms to develop new defences: an escalation pitting bot creators against bot detectors. This perpetual wave of automated ads competes for our attention, compounding the everyday noise of social media (Losse 2012: loc 184). Might this second-order effect of platformising the archive eventually become self-destructive? The breadth and speed of spam's growth could reshape how subjects relate to the archive in unexpected ways, muddying the reflexive process. The recent rise of "AI slop", low-quality content generated by LLMs, puts past fears of being inundated by spam into a worrying new perspective.

The popular concept of an "information diet" (Johnson 2011) captures how people attempt to avoid "intellectual empty calories" by carefully selecting cultural inputs. The somewhat awkward metaphors in this burgeoning discourse reflect our previously limited vocabulary for purposeful filtering of everyday information flows: a challenge that only became widespread with Web 2.0. In this productivity culture, a few individuals have found success as gurus or consultants in life hacking, bio-hacking or minimalism. Yet as with the power-law dynamics mentioned earlier, many more aspire to that status, collectively fueling a discursive boom ripe for further sociological investigation.

We must be careful not read back a uniform motivation from a converging practice: a strategic response to cultural escalation can also be orientated towards the reclamation of relational goods which have been eroded by demands external to the relations in question. For example, a digital detox intended to ensure a better quality of time with family or an information diet

which aims to ensure intellectually varied news sources. We could suggest an ideal typical autonomous use of such strategies (*seeking to minimise distraction and maximise focus*) and a corresponding meta-reflexive use (*seeking the expansion of cultural horizons and regular access to cultural items that matter*) but such suggestions are speculative in the absence of empirical research which recognises the variability of personal reflexivity.

A crucial question remains about the actual effectiveness of “information diet” strategies in slowing or managing cultural escalation. Although these approaches aim for long-term habit change, their success is far from assured. Moreover, all such strategies focus heavily on first-order situational responses, immediate coping or task management, often at the expense of second-order trans-situational concerns (i.e. the deeper content of reflexivity). This may look like a broad shift towards “situationalism” but as Rosa (2013) suggests, it would be misleading to see it as an epochal transformation of subjectivity. Rather it is a conditional response to cultural escalation that varies across different social contexts. Understanding why individuals choose to cope in particular ways requires examining their motivations, ongoing challenges, and strategic actions. Only through doing so can we adequately track the psychobiographical implications of these often subtle causal effects.

Roose (2014) introduces the notion of “cognitive triage” to describe the compartmentalisation he observed among young stockbrokers. Financial firms offered these recruits material rewards during a bleak job market, helping them delay long-term commitments, yet also demanded near-total immersion in the finance world: 18-hour days, continuous busy work and a brutal socialisation. The outcome was a crisis-management style distinct from Archer’s (2012) expressive reflexivity. Rather than living episodically by gut feelings, *cognitive triage* means living episodically by instrumental rationality tending only to immediate priorities amid intense situational pressures. These pressures might last for a predictable period (e.g. a junior year in finance, a heavy teaching semester) or arise from a temporary confluence of demands. In either case, focusing solely on what is urgent narrows the scope of reflexivity, particularly by crowding out what is *important* (personal concerns) for the sake of what is *urgent* (external demands). This once fringe experience can now be seen as a reportedly everyday feature of working life, even in once “slow” domains of practice such as higher education (Vostal 2016).

Personal Reflexivity: Curation and Filtering

It is estimated that only a quarter of the stored information in the world was digital by the turn of the millennium, in contrast to a 2013 estimate of less than 2% as non-digital (Mayer-Schönberger and Cukier 2013: 151). These estimates reflect a transition from a political economy of (cultural) scarcity, in which talent is scarce and difficult to locate and distribute, to one of abundance. Instant availability of entire catalogues of content mean that the attention of consumers becomes the key to commercial success. Today, there is always more

to read, hear or watch. Infrastructural barriers to circulating cultural content have all but vanished, thanks in part to the zero marginal reproduction costs for digital goods. While this may appear trivial, it prompts a near-limitless expansion of topics requiring reflexive discernment: as constraints on accessing cultural variety dwindle, the channels for discussing that variety with others multiply. This sociotechnical environment conditions rather than determines how individuals engage in real-time reflexivity, as they navigate an abundance of possible ideas and artefacts. It's a complex and messy environment in which to attempt to make sense of your place within the world.

Put simply, there is more for us to miss out on, we can more easily access it, and we are increasingly aware of exactly what we're missing through our interactions with others. While each missed opportunity might seem minor, the cumulative effect is profound for reflexivity. We only have so much capacity to weigh the opportunity costs of cultural abundance: if we cannot read all the books, papers and so on that we believe worthwhile, how do we decide which to prioritise? It is easy to envision diverse reflexive modes responding differently to this challenge: relying on trusted interlocutors (*communicative reflexivity*), focusing on utility and filtering out "noise" (*autonomous reflexivity*), delving into deeper personal values or working to reshape the context of choice (*meta-reflexivity*) and feeling overwhelmed by the entire situation (*fractured reflexivity*). As introduced in the first section, these modes have specific personal implications and broader social consequences, reflecting how personal reflexivity feeds back into collective trends.

In the face of qualitative and quantitative cultural escalation, intermediaries play a critical role, filtering the vast array of outputs. As noted earlier, not all new content necessarily expands the overall cultural variety, a paradox which online intermediaries can often amplify through their strategic conduct as they seek to grow their audience. Still, awareness of this material expands, especially given how online marketing often exceeds the boundaries of relevance to capture attention (Brunton 2013). All users need at least some mechanism to filter the platform archive if they're to find any value in it. Deciding which form of filtering emerges, what tools or methods define the experience, proves vital to understanding how the platform landscape operates as a context for agency. Filtering intermediaries condition user behaviour: they do not fully determine what we see, but they structure how we navigate what would otherwise be overwhelming flows of cultural materials.

These intermediaries fall broadly into two camps: curatorial and algorithmic. Case studies like Amazon and Google show how scale demands in the tech industry gradually privileged algorithmic solutions over human editorial curation. For instance Google at one point considered editorial intervention to handle search limitations but ultimately abandoned that approach, except in special cases involving problematic or illegal content (Vaidhyanathan 2012: 62). Similarly, Amazon's editorial team was replaced by automated systems offering automatically generated recommendations (Stone 2013: 134). In the web's early days, collating and categorising links were the foundation for multi-billion-dollar ventures.

Yet once these portals secured a monetisable audience, the algorithmic potential of user-engagement data took centre stage (Carlson 2015: 37–38). As Pariser (2011) describes it the resulting “filter bubble” fostered a highly personalised environment built on opaque criteria. These algorithmic filters are mediating user behaviour, shaping what is visible and how it appears, rather than outright determining the form or content of personal reflexivity.

However, this didn’t entail the death of curatorial intermediaries, only their exclusion from the architecture of major platforms. A plethora of curation tools have stimulated curatorial activity by encouraging users to engage in the selection, organisation and presentation of material they find online. While these tools differ in application, they collectively shift judgements of salience to curators, rather than the original creators. A comparable pattern emerges in blogging and micro-blogging: filter blogs and curated micro-posts often capture notable audiences (Rosenberg 2009; Carrigan 2019). At the highly visible end, there are people “in the business of locating and connecting interesting things”, as the co-editor of the popular blog Boing describes himself (Doctorow 2002). More broadly, curation has woven itself into everyday media usage, influencing how subjects perceive cultural variety. Though individual curators may not command large followings, the collective effect is significant, with social traffic surpassing search traffic for most websites. These emergent curation practices condition users’ reflexive engagement: they do not close off variety outright but highlight and select from the archive, shaping how individuals perceive and manage cultural abundance.

As suggested previously, we can assume that reflexive modes respond differently to the filter bubble (Pariser 2011). Escaping personalisation is possible, but not cost-free: it demands technical expertise, time and energy. Will a given user consider these trade-offs worthwhile, especially when personalisation saves time? This question hinges on awareness of the sociotechnical environment, with such choices reflecting how personal histories, motivations and resources shape engagement with digital filters. Comparable issues arise with the “curatorial bubble” on social media: do we evaluate our connections by the quality or quantity of content they share? Do we follow people for exposure to diverse cultural resources or does unfamiliar material deter us? Such questions prevent firm predictions about how various subjects respond to opportunities and constraints in their informational worlds. Nevertheless, considering how dominant reflexive modes might shape diverging approaches can be enlightening. More crucially, this perspective illuminates a mediating layer between macro- and meso-level drivers of archival transformation and the micro-level dynamics it spawns. The ways individuals filter and curate content feed back into broader cultural trends, illustrating how individual strategies (embedded within psychobiographies) both reflect and reshape the platform landscape over time.

Human Agency in a Platform Society

There is always a risk of oversimplification in claiming a broad shift in the attentional environment inhabited by human beings. Moreover, a category

such as “human agency”, for all its analytical utility, can itself obscure the significant empirical variability within this category. A parallel arises with the risk of stereotype noted in the first section, where Adams (2004) cautioned against imagining Victorian social life as overly constrained by moral strictures. A similar danger exists when we contrast today’s “chronic distraction” with a nostalgic past ostensibly free of such pressures. In fact Jacobs (2021: 91) plausibly suggests that “a higher percentage of human beings today have regular access to silence than at any point in human history”, pointing to historical evidence of the cacophony which characterised the early modern world. While new forms of portable media certainly create public noise, with no robust norms having yet emerged to curb it, there are equally new opportunities to cultivate a personal “cone of silence” via technological means (Jacobs 2021: 89).

This work does not undertake an empirical survey of the ambiguities arising from such complexities, not least of all because it would require a conceptual framework for sociotechnical change and human agency that we currently lack. Nonetheless, it rests on the assumption that our task is to identify generative mechanisms, those capable of explaining tendencies within open systems where countervailing forces may also be at play, rather than to offer epochal pronouncements about what Vostal (2014) would describe as the “mega force” of technological change. In this sense, my goal is to create conceptual space for nuanced discussions about digital technology and human agency, steering clear of sweeping claims about a new era or outright rejections that any change is unfolding. By abstaining from epochal generalisations I’m aiming to create the space in which the epochal implications of identifiable processes of transformation might be gently teased out. The everyday normalcy of smartphones, tablets and laptops (as well as the digital platforms they facilitate relationship with) creates a risk that we might underestimate their impact, precisely because they are now so intimately woven into daily routines. It is this quotidian embedding, this platformisation of the lifeworld, which we need to grasp for an adequate microsociology of digital change to be possible.

Even though the integration of human agency and digital technology feels ordinary, these day-to-day interactions are no less revolutionary. We routinely enlist devices to perform actions that unite our agency with the software’s capabilities. A prominent tradition interprets this as a ceaseless co-constitution of humanity and technology, often cast in post-human terms (Carrigan and Porpora 2021). While this literature has its merits, approaching it through the lens of Archer (2000) reveals a sociological shortcoming: focusing on subject/object relations in a purely practical order can obscure our understanding of technology in the social order. If we fixate on the relationship between the individual user and their artefact, we miss the broader context in which that relationship is unfolding. Indeed as Mutch (2013: 28) warns us, imposing too tight an analytical cleavage on the relationship between the social and the material generates a “perverse (given the promise of the concept) neglect of the specificity of the systems involved and an inability to deal adequately with the broader context of practice”. Keeping human actors and technological artefacts analytically

distinct enables us to explore their interplay: how a technology's unique properties and powers matter within a specific context.

Hence rejecting the all-encompassing vision of "technogenesis" and moving beyond a purely Weberian lens allows us to ask finer questions about how humans and technologies co-exist, rather than merging into a single, seamless entity (Gane 2004: 3–4; Latour 2005). We must reject views that cast technology as directly moulding human beings because it ontologically veils the recurrent intersection of two property sets (human and technological) where neither holds automatic priority. Yet to stop at that ontological critique would fail to offer an explanatory route forward. By disrupting the co-constitution paradigm, it becomes easier to avoid treating new technologies as self-originating and unique phenomena. Instead, as Housley et al. (2014) suggest, we might "digitally remaster" existing sociological concepts, bringing them into dialogue with a platformised world. This conceptual overhaul lays the groundwork for asking sociological questions better suited to the epochal challenges explored in the first section. In this sense, I'm arguing that core theoretical categories still apply, even as platform society redefines time-space relations and the organisation of the cultural resources circulating through them. From this conceptual foundation we can more easily counter the drift towards a technologised essentialism, common in both public and expert debates about how sociotechnical changes effect emerging adults. Such narratives often skip the label "essentialism" yet still assume novel technologies spawn entirely new forms of adulthood, albeit with justifications provided that range from the genuinely thought-provoking (even if incorrect) to the painfully banal.

In the next chapter, I consider the *collective reflexivity* so integral to our experience of the world, the different forms of "we" in which we are embedded, before turning to a realist account of platform socialisation in the subsequent chapter. My argument will be that socialisation transforms amid the spread of social platforms, foregrounding their deep penetration into everyday life but resisting the claim that we face a decisive, epochal shift in personhood. My biographical approach contends that certain core features of "growing up" remain invariant due to the temporal nature of personhood: we develop over time through interaction with others, in contexts we do not choose but upon which we can eventually exert influence. We can thus see personal histories and platform structures intertwine without transforming humans into a wholly new species of adult.

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8 Collective Reflexivity

Underlying this project is a commitment to treating the individual as a crucial category for social analysis. We often conflate individual and individualism, particularly given the disciplinary divide between sociology and psychology. Here, I am to avoid these conflations by recovering the individual in a richly sociological register, drawing on Archer's (2000, 2003, 2007, 2012) ground-breaking work in this area. That we start with individuals does not imply we must *end* with them. Indeed, much would be inexplicable if *only* individuals featured in our accounts, since this would exclude social terms (like groups and institutions) from our explanations. This would render normative change opaque, at least if we look beyond momentary shifts in attitudes or voting behaviour to more long-range transformations of normative life. There are evidently macrosocial processes of normative change which resist decomposition into the aggregation dynamics of individual actors.

Porpora (2016) examines such “great normative transformations” of the twentieth century, outlining the mechanisms responsible for bringing them about. While Porpora (2016) looks back to see how what “may begin as isolated individuals [...] combine forces to form social movement organizations” and perhaps achieve success through a process that “involve[s] changes in formal rules that come from the higher placed agency of government officials”, this chapter will look forward to consider how the present conditions under which motivated persons “combine forces” might be explained in the terms of the sociotechnical transformations which are the subject matter of this book's second section.

Media sociologist Couldry (2024: loc 530) has recently suggested that mass commercial social media platforms are destroying the conditions which make social solidarity possible. Without a “practical sense that all of us have a stake in working with, or alongside, the people us and the people within reach of us” how could we meet the existential threat of the climate crisis? Platforms could be potent engines of solidarity because of “the ease and speed with which they bring people together around new topics” (Couldry 2024: loc 5461). As Doctorow (2024: 25) puts it, they are both the means by which “corporations and government surveil and control us” as well as “how we form communities and coordinate our tactics to fight back”. In this chapter, I'll explore this

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Janus-faced character of platforms and collectivity, building on arguments developed at length in Carrigan and Fatsis (2021).

Open systems being what they are, no attempt will be made to predict future outcomes. Instead I focus on the mechanisms that enable or hinder the shift from *personal* reflexivity to *collective* reflexivity, clarifying how agency fosters or fails to foster social change. I assume that individual agency and collectively agency are inherently linked, given our tendency to band together in pursuit of shared goals. Furthermore, the content of those goals is conditioned by the shared experiences and placement which precedes any definition of a “we” (Archer 1995). Such emergent effects overlap with the aggregate result of individual activities, even if the latter has tended to be explored primarily by the methodological individualists.

However rather than treating these analytical approaches as opposed, we can follow Archer (1995: 11) in considering their “mutual impact and import”. For instance an aggregate effect, such as widespread unreflective social media use, may become the target of a collective campaign (improving digital literacy or countering misinformation) which aims for a new aggregate outcome (enhanced digital literacy and reflective media usage). The rich and vibrant field of social movement studies understandably demarcates a clear object, the *social movement*, in ways which something obscure the entanglements which precede and succeed specific movements (Mizen 2015). This makes it difficult to acknowledge the individual whose behaviour precedes and extends beyond social interaction, without reducing the analysis to the individual alone. Individual actions can set the stage for collective reflexivity which, in turn, shape further trajectories of individual action.

I approach the individual as a vector of sociotechnical change, influencing both personal and collective reflexivity. Donati and Archer (2015) list a range of entities which are capable of collective reflexivity: couples, families, voluntary associations, cooperatives, labour unions, political parties, foundations, local communities and social movements. Such reflexivity involves “constituting a collectivity that evaluates objectives (discernment), deliberates about realizing its common concerns (deliberation) and commits itself to achieving them (dedication)” (Donati and Archer 2015: 62). My focus here will be on social movements in particular because, as Johnston (2014: 1) contends, “the defining characteristic of all movements, big and small, is that they move history along, sometimes in significant ways”. While Porpora (2016: 18) notes how transformative change, intentionally propelled from below by grassroots movements may be the exception, it was still crucial to the specific transformation he analyses. Social movements, though only one form of collectivity, are vital for our discussion of macro-level social normativity, particularly as discourse around social media’s role in “Twitter revolutions” gives way to anxieties about “fake news”, “computational propaganda” and “filter bubbles” (Carrigan 2022). Platforms both condition and facilitate collective reflexivity with profound social and political consequences. We need to account for these dynamics in a way which is adequate to both personal and collective reflexivity.

This raises a core question: What is a social movement? Emphasising their capacity for collective reflexivity doesn't clarify exactly how they differ from other relational subjects. While social movement scholarship provides many definitions (Crossley 2002: 1–16), broad agreement that movements are collective begs another question: what does collectivity itself entail? As Crossley (2002: 2) points out, it is extremely challenging to pinpoint when a *group* becomes a *movement*. Some view collectivity as mere aggregation, focusing on how individual (or microscopic) actions produce macro-level outcomes, that is, “aggregation dynamics” (Little 2012). These effects matter, but if we only attend to them, we ignore the emergent features that distinguish movements.

Here, the central issue is not merely how people “join forces” but how the nature of their union creates a reality that guides their future actions, individually and collectively, beyond any simple sum of individual contributions. For example, movements often produce biographical consequences for participants, both short- and long-term (McAdam 1989). Sometimes, their contribution to social change lies more in the transformations experienced by activists than in the eventual success or failure of the movement itself. Interestingly, Archer described being profoundly shaped by her early experiences of the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament as a student, not least of all because it was the first time she met sociologists (Carrigan 2016).

Keeping biography and movement analytically distinct thus illuminates the causal interplay between them and highlights how external factors affect both, generating second-order outcomes for future movements. For example, Mizen (2015) shows how frustration with “A-B” marches among anti-war activists contributed to Occupy's more militant tactics in the early 2010s. This illustrates how continuities in personal activist histories (e.g. periods of activity vs. inactivity) can intersect with the evolving tactical repertoires of movements. Moreover, digital media's capacity to generate real-time archives can make these biographical influences more visible to sociologists (Brock and Carrigan 2015). Still the challenge of cultural abundance means that transmission of these lessons might be difficult in practice, contributing to the fragile character of many movements forming under these conditions (Tufekci 2017).

Although communications technology has long been central to social movements, the distinct affordances of platforms have been an increasing focus of inquiry into social movements (Couldry 2014). My argument is that platforms, at the levels of both personal and collective reflexivity, bring about significant changes in the organised and sustained shift from individual critique (*personal reflexivity*) to collective protest or action (*collective reflexivity*). It's easier than ever for a *group* to assemble around an issue of shared concern but harder than ever for it to become a *movement*, at least without a substantial infrastructure which surrounds and supports it. The process of assembly is made easier, bringing a group together in a specific time and place, while it is harder for a durable collectivity to emerge from these assemblies. It produces movements which are *fragile*, taking the lead from Tufekci's (2017) illuminating analysis, for reasons I'll explore at greater length later in the chapter.

This does not mean social critique or political protest is diminishing. Rather, the change lies in how the two modes are linked together. Subjects still function as strong evaluators in Taylor's (1989) sense, capable of critically assessing social reality and deciding what requires transformation. They can embrace such causes so deeply that these social transitions become integral to their personal concerns, leading to their participation in social projects of transformation (Archer 2007). Movements in turn arise from personal reflexivity, given the collective effort needed to enact truly transformative goals. At the same time, existing movements encourage personal adoption of causes by serving as carriers, offering a shared platform for concerns that would be challenging to pursue alone. Papacharissi (2015) convincingly identifies the affective dimension to this mobilisation, as platforms afford the coalescence of feeling in animating and motivating ways. What I'm seeking to add are the variable ways in which personal reflexivity either leads to collective reflexivity (i.e. "I" take deliberate action to become part of a "We") in this setting, or finds itself undercut by the challenges we explored in the previous chapter.

By simultaneously producing *distracted people* and *fragile movements* platforms erode the capacity of social movements ability to guide sociotechnical change. They undercut our capacity to steer change in collective and democratic ways while also being a change which urgently requires precisely this kind of steering. This is less a collapse of moral imagination and more a weakening of the generic capacity to sustain long-term collective efforts. It is a realist characterisation of what Couldry (2024) describes as a breakdown of solidarity and a concomitant failure of coordination. Unless we can work together in sustained ways that can persist through change, the capacity of movements to exercise normative influence is severely curtailed vis-a-vis other forms of collectivity (particularly think tanks, lobby groups and political action committees) which can more easily establish a durable infrastructure to sustain their continuity.

There is a mutual reinforcement at play: increasingly *fragile movements* flash powerfully yet briefly, demanding normative engagement from *distracted people*, who exhibit growing interest but limited ability to sustain involvement. Even as we see a surge in evaluative capacity and political activity, these might fail to coalesce into the robust, enduring organisations which are capable of sustaining change over time. The same digital infrastructure leads us closer to a future many would oppose, even as it aids the strategies of collective agents aiming to actualise that future. Effective social movements may be less likely precisely when we need them most, raising the concern that sustained organisational power might fall to elites defending their privilege on a resource-depleted planet spiralling into climate disaster (Rushkoff 2022; Seymour 2024).

Fragile Movements

Social movements have always relied upon communication technologies. As Gerbaudo (2012) points out, "[s]ocial media can be seen as the contemporary

equivalent of what the newspaper, the poster, the leaflet or direct mail were for the labour movement". Rather than "an essentialist vision of social media as being automatically either suitable or unsuitable as a means of mobilisation" we need to consider the material affordances of these platforms, analysing how they shape movement formation and mobilisation (Gerbaudo 2012: 4–5). The stratified ontology of social realism is vital here for differentiating between:

- 1 Movements as emergent entities practicing collective reflexivity
- 2 Sociotechnical structures facilitating their operations
- 3 Biographical journeys of participants entering, persisting within and exiting these movements

While this framework could guide qualitative studies of particular movements, the focus here lies on ontological questions central to sociotechnical change and collective reflexivity. Specifically, how communications technology shapes movement characteristics by influencing distinct trajectories of individual participation. This section explores how proliferating communication channels ease assembly yet inadvertently hinder the organisational capacity to grow and adapt, producing the *fragile* character introduced by Tufekci (2017) into the debate. The next section examines how *distracted people* exacerbate this fragility, compounded further by a reliance of movements on polymedia, which intensifies the distractedness of participants even as they are mobilised. Platforms condition *who* assembles, *how* they do it and *why*, without outright determining these outcomes.

Enthusiasm about social media's role in mobilising movements is perhaps best captured by Shirky's (2008) *Here Comes Everybody*. The book rests on a simple premise: social media slash transaction costs of organisation to near zero, removing logistical constraints that once hindered collective action. Implicit in this view is the idea of a latent impulse for collective action, held back by bureaucratic barriers until social platforms freed us from them. Couldry (2014) describes this as an "emerging myth of natural collectivity" structured around "what 'we' do naturally, when we have the chance to keep in touch with each other, as of course we want to do" (Couldry 2015). This vision often dovetails with a naïve belief that social media erodes established social control: a notion popularised during the early uprisings in the Middle East but also reflective of a broader cyber utopianism (Cockburn 2015; Morozov 2012). Beneath this problematic discourse is a more credible observation: as Tufekci (2014b) explains, the logistical demands of mobilisation have shifted radically:

Social media affordances have altered which capabilities underlie the ability to mount popular mobilisations. For example, in the past, the capability to organize a large-scale march on Washington, or a bus boycott in Montgomery, required extensive organisation, coordinating everything from car pools to laboriously publishing pamphlets to setting up many meetings that in turn determine organisational and logistical issues.

Similarly, battling for visibility through broadcast media often required investing in institutions that became familiar with the workings of media and power.

Under present conditions activists turn to social media to pursue tasks such as co-ordination and publicity and it is the sometimes spectacular achievements that result, with a small number of people bringing about mass action, which explains the enthusiasm for social media which still persists in some circles. As Tufekci (2014b) points out, “There are countless examples of how social media allows mobilizations to carry out fairly impressive feats with little prior infrastructure”. If no urgency demands this infrastructure, why build it? Ad hoc coordination *might* suffice, and in a cultural setting celebrating “networked action” participants may become captivated by the ensuing sense of spontaneity, impeding the development of more robust organisational capacities. If it seemingly works and it feels energising then why would we look anywhere else to support our mobilisation?

What Tufekci calls “sediments”, the leftover traces of activity, can be interpreted as emergent causal powers within relationally constituted movements. Such powers help a movement maintain coherence across changing conditions. It might be true that, as Johnston (2014: 139) puts it, social media lead to a “shrinking [of] the time required for coordinating protest tactics to a flash”. The more pressing issue is how relying on these digital affordances shapes the movement’s emergent character. This is a deeply empirical question, and I do not to offer an adequate answer here. Instead I’m offering a conceptual argument that relying on social media for assembly will *tend* to undermine the cultivation of collective reflexivity. There certainly might be countervailing factors which help nascent movements overcome this tendency. However, I argue that even if platform-mediated movements are symbolically vivid and affectively vibrant, they cannot deliberate effectively on goals or strategies unless assembly extends beyond drawing a crowd or inciting a swarm. Individual motivations may lead them to coalesce together, but they will lack sustained collective structures to shape ongoing reflection.

Movements formed under these conditions often exhibit lower relational density, in the sense they lack the organisational capacities that traditionally underpinned assembly. If they can form on the basis of the weak(est) ties, there’s an absence of durable social capital which can support them in negotiating changing conditions. Such a movement risks fizzling out because it cannot effectively respond to unforeseen events, having limited capacity for collective reflexive. If the “we” is primarily symbolic, hinging on an *image* of unity rather than an experiential orientation to a shared project, it may well disintegrate once the taken-for-granted momentum breaks. Hence, these fragile movements will lean towards being more aggregative than truly collective, although this is a tendency arising from the mode of assembly rather than an intrinsic feature stemming deterministically from the technology utilised.

Nonetheless, this fragile form still counts as organisation, involving at least minimal coordination to assume its specific form. It’s more than an aggregate

of individuals, even if it will often not be much more. Yet it places less emphasis on durable capacities that persist beyond assembly, reducing the likelihood of reproducing structural resources for future efforts. While one might read this as inherently negative, the 2022 attack on the US Capitol exemplifies how fragility can also limit the scope of a dangerous movement. Various non-mainstream social platforms facilitated the action, building on a conventional protest rally. It's urgent to note how the distinction between fragile organisation and spontaneous crowd action influences how responsibility is assigned. Evidence suggests well-organised groups and elite support also played a role, so calling the attack "fragile" does not mean it lacked organisation but that it operated under distinct constraints, with a contingent and unpredictable character which was heightened by reliance on digital platforms. Following Tilly (2003), understanding how fragility intersects with existing repertoires of contention is a complex question beyond this chapter's scope. Here, I focus on the ontological implications of this shift, examining how digital platforms condition agency within collective contexts.

Prior to digital communications, the logistical hurdles of assembly demanded robust organisational capacities, fostering the collective reflexivity needed to forge shared projects and sustain commitment over time (Tufekci 2017). Without these processes, any "we" experienced by participants is likely mostly symbolic, leaving them unprepared for challenges that require flexible, creative and collective deliberation. Although individuals may be personally transformed (McAdam 1989), the durable "we" that can drive collective projects does not solidify. Participants in fragile movements may be newly disposed to future activism, but that does not offset the structural fragility they encountered. A future movement, built from similar "parts" in a similar environment, likely inherits the same fragility. Hence, analysing the organisational nodes within specific acts of fragile assembly is crucial to forecasting the likely trajectory of such movements. In some cases, a vanguard group might prefer this ad hoc mode if it has no intention to expand its organisational base: the affective energy stirred by a one-off event can still benefit their agenda under the right conditions. Platform movements often flourish in episodic bursts without necessarily securing the sustained reflexivity that fosters lasting social change.

The Social Organisation of Distracted People

My core argument is that the same forces producing *fragile movements* simultaneously generate *distracted people*. One set of mechanisms unfolds at the personal reflexive level (cultural abundance and intensified work) while another acts at the collective level (reliance on platforms undermining organisational capacities). As Archer (2012) suggests, expressive reflexives may multiply under these conditions, but the lived time of those otherwise poised for sustained movement participation contracts into *cognitive triage*, an expanding feature of personal reflexivity under these conditions. When life is planned week-by-week or day-by-day, committing to long-term social engagement becomes

difficult. We may skip a protest due to an upcoming deadline or, even if we go, we lack the time or energy to follow-up with more active involvement. Triaging one's immediate needs further restricts our focus on the second-order concerns which ultimately matter (Sayer 2011). Tasks proliferate, and rewarding projects become obstacles subject to self-quantification in a quest for enhanced performance. Even "digital detoxes" become another stopgap, relying on voluntary disconnection to handle an involuntary hyper-connectedness.

Cognitive triage does not mean people stop critiquing or acting. Rather, it means certain actions get prioritised amidst intense situational demands, leaving limited time for the post-action reflection crucial for long-term strategic thinking. Productivity culture underscores how claiming one "lacks the time" merely means one is not prioritising it. These are choices, though ones made under intensely stressful and constrained conditions for most of us. However, this prioritisation is a strong evaluation: the very form of reflection that cognitive triage undermines (Taylor 1989; Sayer 2011). The more we rush and need to prioritise, the harder it becomes to make commitments we can really endorse because of the cognitive and affective constraints of that very rushing. Turning to productivity culture to "solve" an overload typically involves a particular expression reflexivity, aligning with a conventional reliance on expert guidance rather than trust in one's own deliberation (Mäkinen 2014; Salecl 2011). This posture expands as management philosophies fixate on "wellness" aiming to optimise human capital while compelling excellence (Cederstrom and Spicer 2015). The ratcheting up of situational demands upon employees of which cognitive triage is an outcome has to be considered in terms of the broader context of market capitalism. Digital communications contribute to the intensification of work through the morphogenesis of occupational roles and through facilitating new technologies of measurement and intervention upon which contemporary management increasingly depend.

The concept of cognitive triage clarifies how individual adaptations, though vital at the level of personal reflexivity, can undermine efforts to collectively address shared conditions or forge sustained participation in movements. The reliance of fragile movements on mediated assembly compounds this difficulty, as fewer opportunities exist for newcomers to plug into a network or join an organisation with clearly defined roles. The COVID-19 pandemic and the shift to Zoom or similar platforms exacerbate this. While it may ease one's initial step into involvement, it dilutes the immediacy of face-to-face engagement and privileges existing relational networks, making it still harder for distracted individuals to join and remain engaged. Hence, distracted people and fragile movements perpetuate each other at a second-order level, as well as emerging from the same mechanisms at the first-order level. These mediated channels shape whether and how people leap from personal reflexivity into the collective realm, without assuring any robust or enduring structure which ensues from it.

Perhaps other action forms flourish under conditions ill-suited to sustained social movements. Electronic activism, labelled "slacktivism" for its low commitment, could be rethought in Margetts et al. (2015) terms as the lowest rung

on a “ladder of participation”. Such steps are asynchronous, symbolically potent, and spread easily online. They also function as “frictionless” by-products, publicly visible yet relatively effortless, unlike more cumbersome forms of analogue participation. This visibility invites criticism of “virtue signalling” (i.e. social action intended as public performance) yet remains an ontological trait of mediated activism, even if we reject the derogatory connotations. Digital infrastructures encourage quick, visible acts that often will not culminate in deeper collective reflexivity.

Rather than classifying such activity as intrinsically worthy or otherwise, it can be usefully considered in terms of the biographical context within which people take such action. While as Tufekci (2014b) notes such “semi-public symbolic micro-actions can slowly reshape how people make sense of their values and their politics”, it is equally likely that they can act as a salve to those triaging: providing fleeting satisfaction when deeper, second-order commitments remain crowded out by pressing imperatives. Corporate agents, meanwhile, vie for the public’s attention in a highly competitive environment. With limited mental bandwidth for moral claims, petitions or donations, activists and organisations face a challenge in cutting through the noise. This pressure encourages communicative innovation: raising the bar for all, intensifying workloads and further inhibiting stable reflexivity.

Ironically, amplifying messages across multiple channels to overcome social distraction deepens that very distraction. The crowded social media terrain pushes movements and organisations to adopt specialised communications tactics, requiring professionals with the time and skill to manage complex, multimedia outreach. This logic of professionalisation in the attention economy disincentivises grassroots, volunteer-driven groups that lack such resources, thus undermining the ideal of mass cultural participation once celebrated. Platforms shape who can speak loudly and how, effectively constraining the range of participants able to sustain meaningful engagement. The “super participants” who are “especially loud and especially visible online” should not be mistaken as typical of a broader online majority, with platform contexts inevitably characterised by intense inequalities of visibility and influence (Phillips and Milner 2018: 167). In this sense, we should understand the digital public sphere as more *demotic* than *democratic*, foregrounding people without facilitating their participation (Turner 2009; Carrigan and Fatsis 2021: Chapter 2).

The ongoing rise of generative AI (chatbots, text-to-image, text-to-video, etc.) may further alter the dynamic between professionals and amateurs. Automating cultural production could reduce paid positions and undermine pathways for talented amateurs aspiring towards steady roles (Conor, Gill, and Taylor 2015). Simultaneously, these tools expand the cultural repertoires of existing professionals, facilitating human/machine creativity and potentially intensifying the symbolic richness of political communications. Yet, such advances may deepen inequalities, as established organisations, capable of sustained coordination, deploy these new resources, while ephemeral fragile movements continue to ignite and fade with minimal capacity to sustain themselves.

These chatbots could also be used directly as micro-targeted tools of persuasion and propaganda, rather than simply being content production devices for human actors.

This raises a much broader question relevant to the epochal concerns which underlying this project. How might future normative transformations unfold in a world dominated by fragile movements and distracted people? In order to explore this issue we should treat participant's present actions as seeding latent future possibilities, through their downstream implications for psychobiography. Understanding how movement participation trajectories produce specific long-term effects will be vital for grasping potential twenty-first-century normative shifts, akin to those Porpora (2016) examines for the twentieth century. Even fleeting activism can leave biographical imprints, potentially informing future collective reflexivity (Mizen 2015). Asking how ephemeral movement participation shapes individuals does not presume any universally positive or negative outcome. Such experiences might contribute to the incubation of future progressive movements that transcend fragility, just as easily as they might prime activists for a far-right resurgence. Others may retreat from activism altogether after encountering repeated failures. The key point is to avoid dividing personal life and movement life into ontological silos which preclude examination of the interplay between them. If movements form more easily but fail to last, individuals will relate to collective change differently and, conversely, if people cannot push beyond personal horizons, movement formation will become harder. Beneath this practical interplay lies an ontological claim about how personal and collective reflexivity co-constitute each other.

Another factor shaping twenty-first-century normative shifts is the uneven impact of expanded communication channels on collective agents. As movements struggle with fragility and sustaining collective reflexivity, the same socio-technical changes lead to what Tufekci (2014a) calls a "data-analytic environment that favours the powerful, data-rich incumbents". This creates new possibilities for monitoring and control because of the digital data produced as a by-product of transactions which existing corporate agents are uniquely poised to exploit. This creates a situation which turns "political communication into an increasingly personalised, private transaction" driven, it should be noted, by the situational logic of competition into which organised political parties are locked, more than any deliberate project to privatise the public sphere (Tufekci 2014a).

Applied behavioural science and psychometric modelling, built on massive proprietary data from social platforms, enable manipulative mobilisations that exploit existing grievances likely to spur fragile movement participation while ultimately serving opaque agendas. Critically "such messages are not visible to broad publics and thus cannot be countered, fact-checked or otherwise engaged in the shared public sphere the way a provocative or false political advertisement might have been" (Tufekci 2014a). Coupled with a shaming culture where micro-harassment at scale can ruin reputations, these concerns raised by Tufekci (2014a) and Couldry (2014) warrant serious attention

(Seymour 2016, 2024; Ronson 2015). The account of distracted people and fragile movements offered in this chapter provides a framework within which we might begin to investigate the conditions under which such opaque strategies thrive. The absence of durable movements to articulate grievances and the experiential reality of fleeting participation might prime subjects for subsequent *shadow mobilisations*, in which affective movements are encouraged to coalesce on misleading or manipulated foundations. I would suggest this mechanism is key to understanding the rise of the far-right across the world in the intervening years, though it's beyond the scope of the chapter to substantiate the claim.

These asymmetries, seen in targeted political intervention, mirror a broader shift whereby, in Lazega's (2020: 4) words the "digitalisation of relational life pushes technocratic bureaucratisation of the world much further ... shaping social changes and transitions without open deliberation, accountability and democracy". The intentional drive for social change is just one visible facet of deeper ontological issues, highlighting how sociotechnical conditions condition the ways in which purposive action unfolds. Following Couldry (2020), I concur that a new social order is emerging, demanding concepts robust enough to grasp and critique it, even if I remain sceptical about our capacity to delineate the features of it at this stage. This chapter has mapped how *distracted people* and *fragile movements* hamper collective agency. Next, I turn to the collective agents that thrive under these conditions, examining who can wield influence in an age of fragility and distraction.

Collective Agency and Computational Politics

Recognising the infrastructural power of platforms, how decisions of designers mediate social interaction, can lure us into an unsatisfactory political ontology, framing digital capitalism as split between *engineers* and *the engineered*. This dystopian mirror to cyber-utopianism equally privileges technological mediation, viewing it as a prime driver of either domination or liberation, thus over-estimating technology's causal powers while under-estimating the contribution of social structure. Such an approach obscures capitalist dynamics by ignoring how engineers, working within firms, are embedded in a broader political economy that shapes their operations (Srnicek 2016). To fixate on the emerging relations risks analytically segregating these firms from capitalism more broadly, obscuring the many continuities which their self-styled epochal framing ("we are not like other firms") can easily mask. It also offers an incomplete view of everyday life under digital capitalism: not only at the level of user phenomenology (where digital devices and activities inform personal experience) but also concerning how individuals *care* about these data-producing activities and translate them into social action with crucial aggregative and collective consequences. While platform design is integral, it neither fully explains nor controls social life, as a logical corollary of the relative autonomy of platforms and agents.

Only by historicising technology firms can we understand their macrosocial impact. The downturn which gripped the sector before the Generative AI bubble began shows why isolating Big Tech from broader capitalist cycles is misguided. These companies still respond to the same business cycles, albeit in distinctive ways reflective of sector-specific logic. As interest rates climb, capital is less content with long-term promises of returns, which is jarring for firms accustomed to the easy capital of early twenty-first-century monetary policy. A growing emphasis on subscription models across the platform economy tacitly rejects the “blitzscaling” orthodoxy, wherein companies rapidly expand with little regard for short-term profitability, aiming to secure their dominance within winner-take-all or winner-take-most markets. Hwang (2020) notes the digital advertising market’s structural fragility, compounded by shrinking ad budgets and reduced consumer spending, further undermining advertising-based models. The pandemic vision of what Klein (2020) termed a “screen new deal”, weaving Big Tech deeply into social life, may have faded. Yet their immense infrastructural control persists, suggesting we are entering an era where their influence remains entrenched even as their consumer orientation wanes.

These dichotomous frameworks also obscure collective agency: an omission Archer’s (1995) social realism helps address. Engineers function as primary agents, holding vested interests via shared social positions and resource distributions. Yet data show engineers are not inherently dominant: product managers and designers can earn more, despite engineering interns still making roughly twice the US median wage. Data scientists, once hailed as the “Sexiest Job of the 21st Century”, also face potential labour oversupply, which could suppress salaries. Meanwhile, ethnographic accounts, tech journalism and popular culture portray Silicon Valley as ruled by a handful of celebrity entrepreneurs, with countless aspirants hoping to join this elite (Marwick 2013; Martinez 2016). However, the privilege seemingly enjoyed by these aspirants grows more ambiguous once skyrocketing Bay Area costs and declining quality of life are factored in.

The political economy of Silicon Valley is multifaceted, making simplistic judgements about a new digital elite inadequate. Still there are compelling questions about a *variegated* digital elite: from expanding corporate lobbying to unconventional political beliefs, all shaping national and global politics. Epistemology, ontology and political economy converge here because these agents, often overlooked in standard transactional data accounts, do in fact generate, circulate and interpret said data (Couldry and Hepp 2017: 4978). “Raw data” is, as Gitelman (2013) reminds us, an oxymoron because it always reflects certain interpretive decisions and the material interests underpinning them. Even if engineers and architects do not consciously see themselves as sharing vested stakes, their projects within organisations may serve overarching interests. But this is a loose convergence across a sector rather than the deliberate intention to reengineer the social which the “techlash” literature, particularly in its popular forms, sometimes appears to imply.

Just as it's too reductive to picture a new "engineering" class siphoning all benefits from digital capitalism, so it is oversimplified to see the "engineered" as merely an atomised and distracted mass. Transactional data certainly enable individual-level analysis and opaque interventions but covert assemblages of people under false pretences predate digitalisation (Gehl and Lawson 2022). Even so digital media vastly extend these capacities, as well as insulating organisers from detection (Tufekci 2014a, 2017). Nagle (2017: 118) argues that those organising against the current American president are now at risk from an "ability to send thousands of the most obsessed, unhinged and angry people on the Internet after someone if they dare to speak against the president or his prominent alt-light and alt-right fan". This normatively motivated network harassment, studied by Marwick (2021) and collaborators, represents a potent political force which appears to grow in significance with each passing year.

These radical potentials for mobilising distracted individuals invite concerns about democracy's long-term stability (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021). The growth of the far-right since I began to develop this argument in the mid-2010s has strengthened my conviction that something deeply dangerous is emerging here (Winlow, Hall and Treadwell 2017; Seymour 2024). Yet the ongoing reconfiguration of primary agency may still birth collective agents unaffected by such manipulations. When interventions alter the life chances of an aggregate (which may not have existed previously as a distinct group), it also prompts individual and collective responses to shared concerns, including predictive privacy harms or digital exclusion. Such organising is challenging, given the opacity of transactional data, but it is not impossible. If anything, the struggles faced by union organisers in gig economies, where labour relations are opaque and precarious, are mild compared to the complexities of politically mobilising around covert forms of disenfranchisement (Woodcock 2015). These conditions shape emergent collectivities and reveal the potential for new alliances to form beyond traditional categories.

Nonetheless, these empirical challenges do not preclude the possibility of nascent primary agents organising into corporate agents, or their potential for self-organisation. Identifying these aggregates reshapes how we theorise collective and individual agency. Segmenting populations with "big data" (Williamson 2017: 62–63) affects the public as they are "carved up" in novel ways. While there may have been a gap between the rhetoric and reality of the mid-century advertising business, its ambitions "to call group identities into existence where before there had been nothing but inchoate feelings and common responses to pollsters' questions" should be taken seriously (Frank 1998: loc 640–657). The market segmentation which became the focus of advertising in the latter half of the twentieth century was partly identification of latent differences within the population and partly an artefact of the methods used to identify those purported differences.

What *has* changed are the means available to this end, offering an unprecedented degree of granularity in the analysis of consumer behaviour and opacity in interventions made on this basis. The granularity and opacity of data-driven

interventions have soared, aligning with Archer's (1995) sense of primary agency as constituted by shared life chances within an aggregate of the population. If these categories are real in their effects, they can contribute to grouping and regrouping, even if this is a downstream consequence of their imposition on the social world. Yet those harmed by predictive privacy violations may not recognise the harm or locate similarly situated individuals, impeding any collective organisation, even before we get to the challenges of sustaining fragile movements (Crawford and Schultz 2014).

This opacity is integral to the troubling character of computational politics which Tufekci (2014a, 2017) explores. It challenges our long-held assumptions about the public sphere and the airing of grievances within it. Opaque processes now configure life chances, creating legal and political dilemmas that algorithmic accountability projects have barely begun to address (Pasquale 2015). These harms, unseen and unheard, reflect deeper inequalities, even when they might appear familiar in form. As Couldry (2012: loc 1534) notes, the internet's ubiquity means digital skills and strategies become increasingly crucial, often correlating with socio-economic status and education. Simplistic zero-sum notions of digital access ignore subtler forms of digital exclusion, which could worsen as public services assume digital-by-default modes, risking both material and symbolic erasure of those not fully incorporated into these systems.

Andrejevic (2013) goes further, positing a "big data divide" that splits society between the data-rich and the data-poor, forcing them to engage the social world in fundamentally opposed ways. These asymmetries underpin platform capitalism's infrastructure: one divide is material, ownership and control of data-storage resources, while the other is epistemological, reflecting different endowments of practical knowledge among those with database access (Andrejevic 2013: loc 464). Conventional social science struggles to grasp this divide, creating a need for collaborations that scale from individual algorithms through to global structures. Yet the digital social science produced within platform capitalism has rarely facilitated the transformative approach needed to tackle these inequities. In the next chapter, I conclude the project biographically, exploring how we *become who we are* in a platformised lifeworld. This aims to fortify digital social science amid mounting sociotechnical challenges, especially given the rapid escalation of LLMs that appear to be accelerating change even further.

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9 Platformised Socialisation

In what follows I focus on a specific question: the changing character of socialisation which is likely to ensue from these developments. It would be a mistake to conceive of this as somehow distinct from wider questions of political economy given that what Wright Mills (2000) once described as the “varieties of men and women [who] now prevail in this society and in this period” entail political implications. This is what motivated my analysis of the *distracted* forms of personal reflexivity which digitalisation encourages, as well as the *fragile* forms of collective reflexivity which tend to ensue from them. My argument has been that three mechanisms account for this tendency:

The proliferation of interruptions: Phones, tablets, laptops, voice assistants and other artefacts constantly demand our attention, often in trivial ways but which as a trend challenge our capacity for sustained focus (Soojung-Kim Pang 2013). Dave Eggers (2021: loc 1284) describes the “jittery, needy psyche” of the digital age, echoing Mark Fisher’s (2009) notion of a “twitchy interpassivity”. Although I urge caution about attributing distraction solely to devices, I suggest the temporal patterns of device use lead to a shift in our deliberative activity.

Pluralised communication channels: Telephone, video calls, messaging apps, social media and email are among the many modes of mediated interaction, yielding more communication but also greater ambiguity over which channels to use, when to use them, with whom and for what purposes. More avenues for contact spawn interruptions, but there is a deeper dynamic at work in which having more potential objects of reflexive deliberation complicates communication itself.

Cultural abundance: A shift from scarcity to abundance in cultural resources means there is always more content to read, watch or explore, often cheaply available or in “unlimited” subscription forms. Availability doesn’t dictate what we consume, but it heightens our awareness of potential pursuits. Providing solutions to manage this abundance and boost user engagement is a central drive in the economy of social platforms (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021). My central argument is that these mechanisms shape how individuals deploy their agency rather than altering the basic powers

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of agency itself. They operate as the context for reflexivity, establishing parameters of action with significant consequences. Contra posthumanists, it is the environment that shifts, not the human essence, though contra liberal humanists, this shift runs so deep that the line blurs analytically, if not ontologically (Carrigan and Porpora 2021).

These mechanisms alter how individuals exercise reflexivity without wholly rewriting their fundamental capacities, producing tendencies towards distracted (personal) reflexivity or fragile (collective) reflexivity which can be mitigated or counteracted by other mechanisms. In this chapter, I connect this account of **technological reflexivity** with the account of **personal morphogenesis** which was the focus of the first section. This requires a closer look at deliberation, the substance of reflexivity, in a platformised lifeworld. The multiplication of interruptions, pluralisation of communication channels and cultural abundance define the terrain in which we negotiate and exercise deliberation. These mechanisms jointly constitute a shift in the conditions of everyday life, shared features of the overlapping social milieux in which interaction occurs, which I'm describing as the platformisation of the lifeworld.

I argue that deliberation increasingly falls prey to sociotechnical demands for attention or to the second-order effort of managing these disruptions. Internal conversations become **staccato**: shorter, with fewer ties to prior intra-personal dialogues. And they are more susceptible to new possibilities because it grows harder to "bound variety", as Archer (2012) puts it, to focus on a manageable subset of the myriad options available. Hence, internal conversations can look more **stochastic** in the process because we're keenly aware of all the other things we could do, places we could go, or selves we could become. This is a shift in the temporal structure (staccato) and the content-orientation (stochastic) of personal reflexivity which does not eliminate internal conversation but rather transforms its character under platform conditions. This environment coexists with structural inequalities dictating who can genuinely act on these new possibilities. Rather than reduce the cultural volatility of a platformised lifeworld to "deeper" patterns of life chances, I suggest forging a link between these registers to address the tectonic shifts in social life.

These trends correlate strongly with how embedded digital platforms are in a person's day-to-day life. Yet they are not fully reducible to individual usage, as the opportunity costs of opting out keep climbing. What once counted as a mere inconvenience, missing out regular contact with specific friends or certain cultural developments, can now mean losing access to organisational and governmental services, especially after COVID-19 accelerated platformisation (Carrigan et al. 2023).

"Network weather" as some technologists put it, fosters broad social pressure which pushes people to engage further, turning non-use into an increasingly reflexive stance of resistance rather than simply having failed to sign up (Weller 2011). Dave Eggers (2021: loc 831) envisions a future where the voluntarily unconnected are marginalised, penalised and monitored. Perhaps an

extreme scenario, yet it underscores the creeping compulsion behind platformisation. Opting out grows costlier in a world where social, cultural and economic engagement all hinge on platform use. Fourcade and Healy (2024: loc 1759) observe that “failure to engage and properly care for one’s data double is a moral fault at best, a sure sign of illicit behaviour at worst”. This means that “being invisible to digital infrastructures is suspicious, an organisations code it negatively”. To the extent our position within the world is tracked and evaluated through digital data, the institutional penalties for opting out will continue to grow, even if we are willing to accept the relational limitations which follow from being “off the grid”.

Therefore, we can no longer treat digital activity in a voluntaristic register, as something which individuals *choose* to do. Instead we need to recognise it is an unavoidable feature of being a person within a contemporary context, even if what this means in practice remains variable. For this reason, I propose conceptualising influence of digital platforms *adverbially*, in order to foreground the shift in *how* we do things rather than *what* we do. Their entrenchment fosters reflexivity that is **distracted**, more prone to external interruptions and **porous**, less likely to hold a specific focus. For example, autonomous reflexives might resort to cognitive triage (i.e. emphasising the urgent over the important) as a strategic response to an environment that fractures attention. Similarly, the object of reflexivity can shift when coping with distraction and porousness becomes a prime deliberative concern, whether organised (e.g. self-management in the Quantified Self movement) or haphazard, intensifying personal struggles in a fractured mode.

By introducing the adverbial register, I’m seeking to stress the temporal mode through which this mechanism operates. It exercises its influence over time, in an accumulating manner, rather than as a single-shot action. It’s a subtle shift driven by a change in our conditions, rather than a determinate force compelling a person in the present moment. Its influence is manifested psychobiographically, as a subtle shift in the linked series of changes a person goes through, rather than as a singular event operating in the present tense. Digital entrenchment conditions how individuals navigate these forms of reflexivity, without fully determining either the mode or the object of reflection. The influence of this condition manifests over time in **becoming who they are** rather than in singular instances of external influence over their external behaviour or inner life.

I invoke *distracted* as an adverb to denote how everyday internal conversations, our mundane self-talk, become subject to platformisation. While platforms can influence what we deliberate about by exposing us to more social and cultural diversity, I argue it most profoundly alters *how* we deliberate. I agree with Archer’s (2012: 62) Peircean point that “the more social variation and cultural variety available to ponder upon reflexively ... the greater the stimulus to innovative commitments”, but that has to be supplemented by an awareness of the differential capacity of agents to cope with that variety, as a biographical engagement with cultural abundance.

Distraction and overwhelm function in tandem: we need reflection to handle abundance, yet reflection is itself disrupted. When we fail at Archer’s (2012)

“bounding variety”, we risk the kind of anomie Durkheim (2006: 270–271) describes as a “bottomless abyss that nothing can fill” such that “the more one has, the more one wants to have, the satisfactions one receives only serving to stimulate needs instead of fulfilling them” (Durkheim 2006: 270–271). His description of the inner life of the bachelor goes some way towards anticipating the moral phenomenology of what Maccarini (2019) calls the “bulimic self” and Archer (2012) identifies as “expressive reflexivity”:

The humdrum existence of the ordinary bachelor is enough, with its endless new experiments raising hopes that are dashed and leaving behind them a feeling of weariness and disenchantment. In any case, how could desire settle on something when it is not sure that it will be able to keep what attracts it? For anomie is twofold. Just as the subject never gives himself definitely, so he possesses nothing definitely. Uncertainty about the future, together with his own indecisiveness, thus condemns him to perpetual motion. Hence a state of unease, agitation and discontent that inevitably increases the possibility of suicide.

(Durkheim 2006: 270–271)

This illustrates how questions about shifts in reflexivity and their implications for inner life in a transforming world have been a feature of sociological thought since its inception, even if the conceptual vocabulary has varied. My focus here is narrower: the impact of digital technologies, especially the platform, which I hold to be dominant. As Van Dijck, Poell, and De Waal (2018) established digital platforms now penetrates social existence so deeply they cannot be treated as a mere subsystem or a neutral infrastructure. Platforms act as quasi-agentive forces, learning from user data, modelling behaviour, and using these models to influence individuals. These processes are opaque to external observers, concerned with whole populations and growing more asymmetric over time as machine learning outgrowths feed back into the underlying dynamics (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021). There is something ontologically mysterious about the platform, or at least distinctive and novel in comparison to previous infrastructural forms. They may act in quasi-agentive ways, but they are not agents, contra Airolti (2021). Framing them as such flattens the distinction between human agents and platforms in a way that obscures the interaction between them. Instead I will argue for a notion of the platform as *sui generis*, interfacing with structure, agency and culture (Archer’s S-A-C) without being reducible to any of them. The emergence of LLMs in the later stages of this project further complicates this picture, though I would suggest they are not agents either, even if there are practical gains to accrued by acting as if they were in certain contexts (Carrigan 2024). Rather than treating platforms as a new class of social actor, we should understand them as a novel environment within which agency unfolds: one that actively shapes the parameters of possible action while remaining fundamentally distinct from the reflexive beings who navigate it.

Digital Natives and Digital Immigrants

An example of how overstating technological influence can lead to unwarranted conclusions is the (thankfully debunked) concept of “digital natives”. Mark Prensky (2001: 1–2) famously claimed that today’s young people “think and process information fundamentally differently from their predecessors” because of having “spent their entire lives surrounded by and using computers, video-games, digital music players, video cams, cell phones, and all the other toys and tools of the digital age”. Such “digital natives” are “all ‘native speakers’ of the digital language of computer, video games and the internet”, in contrast to the “digital immigrants” who are tasked with teaching this strange and rather alien species (Prensky 2001: 1–2). As many critics have noted this language of “digital natives” and “digital immigrants” naturalises digital inequalities by presuming universal competence among the young, masking the substantial digital divides that persist and the material inequalities which are correlated with them (Boyd 2014: 192–196). However, even if most scholars reject the term, it retains popular influence and often resonates with everyday experiences of observing young people’s apparent ease with digital tools. There is an intuitive plausibility to the notion, much like the platitudes we discussed in the first chapter, which accounts for its durability.

Rejecting the category of “digital natives” does not mean denying that changes are taking place. Rather, it questions the categorical approach that treats these changes as producing new *types* of people. If we assume that new technology automatically yields new humans, we neglect how the interaction between the causal powers of people and the causal powers of technology varies across contexts. My concept of *distracted people* likewise does not assert everyone has become irreversibly changed, it suggests that under certain conditions, people’s exercise of agency shifts: leading us to ask how that happens and why it matters. Whereas “digital natives” posits an entirely new species, *distracted people* points to an *adverbial* shift: our reflexivity becomes (1) more vulnerable to external interruptions, and (2) more porous, or open to rapid shifts of focus.

This distinction runs against a broader intellectual current that sees digital technology causing a fundamental transformation in personhood itself. Whether hailed optimistically (as in Prensky 2001) or warned against cataclysmically (Zimbardo and Coulombe 2015), these claims assume that a technological environment directly produces entirely new kinds of human beings, obscuring the role of reflexivity and social relations in shaping actual outcomes. As Facer (2011: 32) observes:

The presence of digital technologies in the home has not made all children more creative, more entrepreneurial, more social or more stupid, any more than the sales of Encyclopaedia Britannica or comics in the early twentieth century made all children cleverer or dumber. Nor are all children involved in the same sorts of activity online: they are not all avid games players, social networkers, bloggers or happy slappers. The expert

development of competency in these settings, moreover, is fostered by parents, peers and others in the informal learning setting.

Likewise Facer (2011: 33) warns that the “breathless rhetoric of generational change” completely obscures the difficulty involved “for all generations and age groups of developing complex conceptual and critical skills”. They don’t arise inevitably from mere exposure to devices or media but instead depend on relational support, reflexive engagement and the structured contexts in which people live. We embrace a pernicious essentialism whenever we assume technology itself must yield qualitatively different humans. Such a stance implies a totalising shift in the category of the human that inevitably squeezes out more nuanced understandings of how changes really occur.

Hence, eschewing “digital natives” does mean rejecting the idea that significant changes are underway with implications for what it means to be human. It simply suggests we be cautious about leaping to the conclusion that new technology, by itself, generates wholly new categories of people. Instead, the interplay of reflexivity and relations matters crucially, unfolding over time within structured contexts. In this chapter, I draw on Archer’s (2012) account of socialisation as reflexive engagement, discussed in the first section, in order to show how these processes might work in a platformised lifeworld. Through doing so I clarify the difference between a sweeping essentialism of new persons and a more precise analysis of how people become who they are, with and through technology. The concepts of *psychobiography* and *personal morphogenesis* provide analytical tools that help us understand how platform engagement accumulates into patterns that shape who a person becomes, without assuming predetermined outcomes. From this perspective we can distinguish between a sweeping essentialism of new persons and a more precise analysis of how people become who they are, with and through digital technology.

Platforms and the Cultural Context for Socialisation

If we reflect on our earliest encounters with the internet, we might recall being startled by its perceived immensity. Even for the youngest reader, the web they initially encountered is a fraction of the size of the web they confront today, particularly if we include user-generated content on social media or the vast archive available via streaming services in this category. That initial contrast between “old media” (physical and time-consuming) and “new media” (immaterial and immediate) likely felt revolutionary. It certainly left me with a lifelong fixation on the existential horizons opened up by these technologies, which I’m still working through to this day. Yet each year since, as the platform archive is ever more integrated into daily life, the conditions which provoked this reaction continue to intensify. In a morning spent working on this book, I’ve had a continual stream of live shows from a particular singer playing in YouTube on my second screen. I’ve not requested this: the platform has (correctly) inferred my continued interest in what it’s offering me. It simply fades into the background

as ambient expression of my revealed preferences. Still, interpreting the wonder which the platform archive can provoke in terms of an exponential leap in variety can be misleading for a number of reasons:

- 1 Older media forms either disappear or lose prominence as what Jenkins (2008) calls convergence culture becomes mainstream. Television, radio and print don't simply vanish but are incorporated into digital platforms, often losing their distinct character in the process.
- 2 "New media" also exhibit uniformity, given that algorithms on major social platforms push content production in comparable directions (Caplan and Boyd 2018). When everyone is chasing visibility within the same system, there are inevitable overlaps and duplicates in the ensuing content production.
- 3 Variety itself is filtered by these algorithmic operations in complex, sometimes inconsistent ways. The apparent abundance of content is mediated through recommendation systems which narrow or encounters based on past behaviour, creating a misleading impression of limitless variety underlying what is actually a deeply curated experience.
- 4 "Old" and "new media" often generate synergies, such as the "back channel" on Twitter for a popular TV show (Couldry 2012: 3078–3128), or how leading bloggers gain visibility and prestige by relying on mainstream media to pick up their stories (Couldry 2012: loc 3770–3785).

Instead what we face is, in Chadwick's (2017) terms, a hybrid media environment, which simplistic old versus new oppositions will prevent us from grasping adequately. It's not an infinite new which replaces a finite old but something far more nebulous in practice. Furthermore, there is a longer term possibility that platforms, by mediating cultural content, may undermine the livelihoods of content producers, ultimately restricting the variety they were imagined to promote (Lanier 2010; Taplin 2017). The potential role of LLMs here could be crucial as they come to be leveraged within the existing political economy of content production. For our present purposes what matters is being clear this is not an infinitely expanding frontier, even if it might feel like that when we are lost in the infinite scroll of our feeds. None of this denies an overall increase in variety. The point is simply to avoid presuming an unfettered, exponential expansion and instead distinguish *net variety* from how that variety is *distributed and experienced* during socialisation. This distribution is especially salient when we consider the self-representations which circulate through social media. Plummer (2001: 7) refers to these collective outputs as "documents of life" which for centuries have been, in his words, "hurled out into the world by the millions":

People keep diaries, send letters, make quilts, take photos, dash off memos, compose auto/biographies, construct websites, scrawl graffiti, publish their memoirs, write letters, compose CVs, leave suicide notes, film video diaries, inscribe memorials on tombstone, shoot films, paint pictures, make tapes and try to record their personal dreams.

I propose these documents of life function as a major conduit for encountering variety, what Thompson (1995: 233) calls “new opportunities, new options, new arenas for self-experimentation”. While Thompson referenced media broadly (e.g. novels, film and TV) the same logic applies to documents of life, as both provide glimpses of possible activities, places and people which inform our sense of what life could be. Another related category is the *resources of the self*, like self-help or productivity materials, circulating throughout social media and forming part of the cultural system (Archer 1988). These cultural items are salient for reflexivity, with the potential to influence how individuals imagine their futures, evaluate their present circumstances and understand their past experiences. They provide the symbolic vocabulary through which possible selves are articulated, shaping both what can be envisioned and how these visions are weighed against one another.

These three categories (documents of life, crafted narratives and resources of the self) are analytical distinctions that can overlap: a narrative might double as a didactic fable, or a document of life might implicitly endorse a certain way of living. I introduce them here to clarify intelligibilia: the variety we see, how it is mediated, and how it is distributed. Identifying each medium’s distinct causal power is crucial for understanding how changes in the platform environment effect the production of variety. This means bridging social theory and media theory in order to offer new analytical tools to respond to Archer’s (2012) concern about how “variety” is distributed and why it has been a neglected concept beyond system theory (Coudry and Hepp 2017).

I concentrate here on documents of life, rather than crafted narratives or self-help literatures, though the latter remain influential. Platformisation affects all three categories in somewhat predictable ways. It lowers barriers for new creators to find audiences, exemplified by self-help authors leveraging blogs, YouTube or podcasts to reach potential readers, or novelists launching eBooks from scratch. This broadens the pool of cultural intelligibilia, which can overwhelm consumers (the problem of abundance) and force producers to specialise. Once we recognise the implications of variety for psychobiography and personal morphogenesis, the platform dynamics of abundance and filtering take on profound existential implications. These effects don’t manifest as dramatic ruptures in the shape of a life, but rather accumulate gradually through countless mundane choices and encounters over time. The algorithmic curation of what we see and the steady exposure to certain potential selves over others, shape who we become through the quiet accretion of small decisions rather than through singular transformative movements. This temporal dimension is crucial: platform effects work through duration rather than intensity, making their influence both more pervasive and less immediately perceptible to those experiencing it.

While early social media was hailed as a democratising force, there’s now widespread recognition of the attention hierarchies that define online visibility. While anyone can “have their say”, not everyone will be heard (Carrigan and Fatsis 2021). The radical expansion in documents of life and resources of the

self intersect with these dynamics to offer a powerful source of sometimes dissonant ideas, easily accessed from a bedroom or mobile device. Under these conditions it becomes harder to be an identifier in Archer's (2012) sense, someone whose natal context provides normative consensus, if that context is undermined by the torrent of variety which slips into it through platform intermediaries. There's an underlying sense of cacophony which grows under these conditions, as countless voices and perspectives compete for attention within the same platform environment.

Personal Reflexivity: Possible and Potential Selves

Documents of life reveal mundane fragments of lived experience that can exert real influence, even as inequalities remain regarding who speaks, who controls that speech and whose voices actually register. Adapting Turner's (2009) analysis of reality TV we might see this as more *demotic* than truly *democratic*: "normal people" gain exposure but not necessarily power. Indeed this "normality" will likely get entangled in the attention economy of social media, potentially hollowing out authenticity in the quest for online recognition (Johnson, Carrigan, and Brock 2019). Under these conditions, "authenticity" becomes a gruelling performance which needs to be continually staged, sold by influencers to firms seeking to promote their products through authentic voices, even as their capacity for it continually erodes (Hund 2023).

With these platforms come visibility and popularity concerns that previously exercised their force in less intensive and extensive ways, though it's important to reiterate that peer pressure was clearly not invented by tech firms in the early to mid-2000s. This means the familiar boundary between everyday documents of life and the polished outputs of the cultural industries begins to blur. Rather than an egalitarian explosion of self-expression on social media, everyday representations become marked by traits once linked to professional creators. A celebrity ethic, typically a painstaking pursuit, becomes part of daily life for growing numbers of people (Marwick 2013; Hund 2023). Gill (2023) offers a bleak vision of young women caught up in the emerging system of ubiquitous social photography, with each social event coded in terms of possible failure to meet the standards of perfection expected within their peer groups.

Platform-based media and pervasive devices (smartphones, tablets, wearables, etc.) remove the traditional limits on self-representation in daily life while actively incentivising the pursuit of popularity within metricised spaces. It's theoretically possible to resist what Gerlitz and Helmond (2013) call the "like" economy, yet these feedback loops (likes, shares and follows) strongly mediate peer approval through the platform's evaluative framework. This fosters an artificial commensurability, where a small number of Instagram likes competes against thousands garnered by others. The outcome is an apparent reclamation of the ordinary, masses of everyday representations that, ironically, are guided by hidden drives to elicit platform-based acclaim. These portrayals feel more authentic (emerging from "real life") yet are no more inherently truthful than

those found in traditional broadcast or print media. The filtering is both technological and cultural, with cultural norms naturalised as inherent features of a platform's usage (Rettberg 2014: 23). The everyday is constructed in new ways as the "authenticity" upon which the influencer economy depends (Hund 2023). If these influencers were not "real" would they be able to exercise the influence which commercial sponsors are purchasing?

Possible selves offers a valuable lens for interpreting how these media shifts shape our sense of the future: the relationship between the "I" and the (imagined) "You" which is integral to personal morphogenesis. Often under theorised, it has been used within realist approaches to examine how subjects imagine their futures, leveraging imagination and memory to visualise who they could or should be in the future (Carrigan 2014; Stevenson and Clegg 2011). As Strahan and Wilson (2006) observe prompted by Ebenezer Scrooge's journey in *A Christmas Carol*, such capacities pervade literature: we're always dealing with characters or persons meeting versions of themselves. MacIntyre (2013) dubs this the "unity of a human life" wherein our actions gain meaning through the integration of episodes into an overarching continuity, which I've argued can be usefully conceived of as *psychobiography*. Even theories of perpetual self-reinvention assume something persists to be reworked in the ceaseless labour of creation (Craib 1998). In these terms self-relations inherently involve redescription of the past, shaping how we act next in a manner which links past, present and future (Bhaskar 1989: 171–173).

Why do we imagine certain futures rather than others? Which parts of ourselves occupy our attention? Why do some possibilities linger while others dissipate? Our inner world draws on symbolic resources we have incorporated from our environment, producing a varied repertoire that facilitates our imagination and creativity (Archer 2003: 69). I propose that **possible selves** serve as the mechanism by which cultural intelligibilia (crafted narratives, documents of life and self-help resources) influence our relationship to our future, through the *internal representations* which we construct that are influenced but not determined by our environment (Archer 2007: 20). In contrast **potential selves** are the "raw materials" for constructing future-oriented representations, pieced together from the cacophony of the platform ecosystem. They are the aspects of the intelligibilia which are drawn upon, or which provoke us, to construct the possible selves which define our. Hence we must attend to the "signs, symbols and languages given to us through paperbacks, soap operas, chat shows, docudramas, film, video, self-help manuals, therapy workshops, music videos" as "the resources from which we tell our stories" (Plummer 2002: 137). Through doing so we open up an important interface between personal life and cultural change, as can be seen through historical shifts in the character and diffusion of cultural forms. In fact much of the detraditionalisation thesis could be productively recast as an argument about such a transformation, particularly with regards to the present weight which past forms carry normatively and existentially.

The concept of potential selves clarifies how cultural and agency intersect. While possible selves focus on the properties and powers of a human agent, the

future moment of personal morphogenesis, potential selves highlight cultural forms themselves. Building on Archer's (1988) account of the cultural system's objectivity, I argue that certain cultural intelligibilia are especially prone to being interpreted as potential selves (Archer and Elder-Vass 2012). For instance a sitcom about a wealthy family is more conducive to imagining one's future self than an etymological dictionary might be. Such representations (encoded in print, film or photography) travel independently of their creators, allowing audiences to interpret them as material for shaping possible selves. Hence, the status of possible selves arises from a cultural form's aptness to convey human possibility, even if that wasn't the producer's intended purpose. This classification ranges from overtly relevant genres (such as Young Adult fiction) to items that are context-dependent (such as a Taekwondo rulebook). By exploring how people encounter and appropriate these forms, we can begin linking the psychology and sociology of media at the microsocial level. These forms can operate as cultural prompts which influence how individuals conceive who they might become, or as the material out of which such prompts are constructed or coalesce.

Historically technologies for self-narration have always existed, such as diaries or scrapbooks. Social platforms extends these practices in a radical way, broadening the modalities of storytelling and drastically expanding potential audiences. What Couldry and Hepp (2017: loc 4049) describe as "the extended spatiotemporal reach of self-narratives" should be taken seriously, though the role of platform architecture in shaping the realisation of that potential reach should not be forgotten. For example, the technology of a diary was private by default, liable to be locked in a drawer as easily as shared with close friends (Couldry and Hepp 2017: loc 4065). Unlike social media which defaults to at least some form of publicity, even when users are meticulous in leveraging the limited privacy features which are made available to users on most platforms. Van Dijck's (2007: 6–7) concept of "personal cultural memory" underscores how media mould the ways we record and recall experiences, shaping our sense of past, present and future in relation to others (Van Dijck 2007: 21). With platformisation, the scale and publicness of these self-narratives now far exceeds old boundaries, making the self increasingly dependent on platform infrastructures, with potentially radical implications for socialisation (Couldry and Hepp 2017: loc 4115).

Platformisation hasn't removed every technological barrier to Archer's (1988) cultural system. Instead it reconfigures them while fuelling exponential growth. We must also avoid overstating how comprehensive this shift is: numerous archives remain undigitised, some only existing as indexes and many are locked behind organisational walls. Additionally access depends on factors like internet connectivity, device quality and tech proficiency. Home broadband with multiple devices differs substantially from erratic, costly mobile access or reliance on a public library's limited resources. The cultural system is still structurally and socioculturally mediated. What we're seeing is a profound shift in the form of that mediation, rather than a removal of the link itself. Large language models are particularly significant from this perspective, enabling a form of

sociocultural mediation in which a person can literally talk to a condensed expression of aspects of the cultural system. Archer and Maccarini (2021) late work on artificial intelligence, though preceding the launch of ChatGPT in November 2022, raised important ontological questions about the implications of such developments.

It follows from the approach in section one that we must always attend to variation. For some people digital resources become ubiquitous, shaping daily navigation of the world. For others these assumptions about universal connectivity can exacerbate exclusion, especially under a digital-by-default approach in public or organisational services. Recognising these constraints prevents us from imagining an unbounded abundance of cultural content: that abundance, as Couldry and Hepp (2017: loc 1569) suggest, remains a theoretical horizon, which is dependent on the user's sociotechnical circumstances. Abundance is a challenge but it is not an infinite one. In fact it is the construction of its finitude, for a singular person in a specific context, which constitutes the specificity of that existential and practical challenge.

If we consider the media system as a whole it is clear there is more representational activity taking place, in the sense of a demonstrable increase in the quantity of media artefacts (across a dizzyingly broad selection of genres and modalities) being produced and shared across a range of platforms. The infrastructural developments which have taken place are aggregative rather than substitutive, for example, social audio platforms and the podcasting space more broadly do not replace audio but act back upon it in multifaceted and hybridising ways. However, the significance of representational activity which takes place through social media rests in how "user-generated content" is primed by default for circulation and reception by others. This was never true of its analogue precursors, with self-generated content by amateurs formerly being defined in part by the difficulty in ensuring widespread visibility, raising important questions about how this changes how people understand their representational activity. The promise of being able to reach a wide audience figures heavily in the user cultures which have emerged across mass commercial social media platforms, embodying a tantalising promise of rapid fame which needs to be seen against the backdrop of widespread economic precarity (Johnson, Carrigan and Brock 2019).

In so far as people are orientated towards the inducements of platforms (likes, retweets, views, etc.), as a generic concern for social self-worth it comes to be mediated by the architecture of interaction, their self-representational activity is likely to become more reflexive. This can be seen most dramatically in the case of influencers, aspiring and otherwise, pursuing online celebrity in order to leverage it for financial gain (Abidin 2018; Hund 2023). But these are merely the outliers of a more pervasive trend in which a corporate culture, built upon self-branding and self-promotion, influences wider social life by engineering these assumptions into their increasingly popular machinery of interaction (Marwick 2013). The implications of this appear as frequently in popular commentary as they do in scholarly research, even if the former tends to lack a nuance which the latter aims towards, for example, claims about the

narcissism of the selfie generation, the decreasing capacity to cope with human imperfection and the anxieties which the barrage of perfect images produces in those who compare themselves to them.

Even if we find the moralistic tone and hasty generalisations of these accounts problematic, there is nonetheless a kernel of truth underlying them. If self-representations are increasingly driven by algorithmic imperatives towards maximising their circulation, perfecting their content and most effectively winning the approval of online audiences then consequences for socialisation will inevitably flow from this. Craib's (1994) warning about the *importance of disappointment*, the existential necessity of learning to live with frustrations and restrictions, comes to seem ever more relevant when considering this trend. The reflexive and self-referential character of self-representations transforms the normative character of documents of life in a manner which seems unlikely to be developmentally positive, particularly for the generation who have never known any other form of peer feedback. We should avoid idealising past sociocultural relations, with their capacity to produce shame and dismay in those unable to live up to their injunctions. Nonetheless, the documents of life against which young people increasingly measure themselves in a platformised lifeworld present them with normative standards which are liable to prove impossible to meet, corresponding with new forms of shame and sanction produced by these experienced failures (Gill 2023).

Only a limited array of potential selves circulate within this media system, filtered through the aforementioned constraints inherent in media organisations, as well as the commercial apparatus surrounding them. In contrast, the rich diversity of "documents of life" tended to be restricted to local contexts, due to their reliance on media which did not easily scale (Van Dijck 2007; Plummer 2001). The ramifications of those potential selves encountered were restricted in each case: by the inevitable characteristics of existing networks within which "documents of life" were circulating, as well as the many filters in operation within existing media organisations.

If potential selves are primarily encountered through face-to-face interaction, it is liable to leave the individuals concerned embroiled within the dynamics of what Archer (2003, 2007) calls "communicative reflexivity". Under these conditions, individuals rely on similarly situated others to complete and confirm their internal dialogues about what to do and who to be. This tends to generate consensus, not because of any inevitable uniformity of people who approach life in this way, as much as the "common sense" about "people like us" when substantial swathes of the possibilities a person confronts are likely to be discussed with others. The potential selves encountered might be challenging but this challenge is mediated through interpersonal interaction with others liable to share a common starting point. The individual grapples with implications for their possible selves in dialogue with others who are already prone to sharing the same "mental furniture".

In contrast the potential selves encountered in a platformised world have no such commonality underpinning them, beyond the minimal social integration

entailed by being users of the same platforms who are orientated towards the same incentives, as meditated by folk constructions of the “algorithm” (Ruckenstein 2013). As Van Dijck (2007: 24) puts it, “we no longer need to derive our personal tastes or cultural preferences mainly from social circles close to us, because media have expanded the potential reservoir for cultural exchange to much larger, even global, proportions” (Van Dijck 2007: 24). Not only is this likely to be a further blow to the possibility of sustained communicative reflexivity, it raises the question of the form which social integration can take under these circumstances. We face a disturbing possibility that normative consensus might come to take another form: individual atoms privately matching their behaviour in a collective enterprise of modulation driven by opaque algorithms serving corporate vested interests. Pasquale (2015) draws attention to the comparison inherent to social media metrics, as well as the forms of mutual replication that it might lead to if left unchecked. This is not a vision of social authoritarianism which negates personal reflexivity but rather one which coordinates it through the platformised synchronisation of concerns and projects, creating a recursive integration where platform feedback loops become constitutive elements of social life itself rather than merely technical mediators of it (Morozov 2019).

The Challenge of Shaping a Life

In earlier sections, I explored how cultural variety in the archive stems from a mix of heterogenising and homogenising processes. This perspective departs from the usual linear assumptions, whether celebratory or critical, about the growth of variety in late, liquid and postmodernity. Instead variety accumulates unevenly, sprawling curatorial and algorithmic mechanisms that mediate how people actually encounter it in real world settings. Given variety increases in irregular ways, these second-order interventions add another layer of uneven access. The approach I developed in the first section stresses how reflexivity is bound up in first-order responses, contributing to second-order challenges which themselves will need to be engaged with reflexively.

The layered contingencies surrounding variety become even more complex once we consider personal reflexivity in greater depth. How do individuals engage with these proliferating options? What do people *do* with this variety? Archer (2012) talks about this as “bounding variety” or filtering possible opportunities until they are subjectively manageable. Communicative reflexives, for instance, depend on interlocutors, which can pose unique difficulties in platform contexts. Autonomous reflexives centre on projects and goals, a task complicated by the sheer awareness of countless potential aims. Meta-reflexives focus on broader concerns, yet these rarely yield straightforward paths to action, delving deeper into the cultural system can compound confusion. Meanwhile, fractured reflexives find it especially hard to bound variety, struggling to maintain a coherent path forward. Such distinctions underscore how personal reflexivity might either reinforce or counteract the curatorial and filter bubbles: the dominant mechanisms through which people encounter the platform archive.

My central claim is that the curatorial bubble and the filter bubble function independently yet jointly shape how individuals encounter and respond to cultural variety. Algorithmic mediation extrapolates current interests from past data, potentially eroding serendipity and foreclosing cultural exploration by “freezing into place a future that rigidly reenacts the past” (Pasquale 2015). Meanwhile curatorial meditation harnesses social or cultural preferences, risking the emergence of closed and homogenous communities, even if this homogeneity is something which members have to actively work towards because it matters to them (Sunstein 2009). However in both scenarios the actual impact remains contingent because agents typically adapt to these platforms, even if that adaption paradoxically reinforces the system’s logic. Again the first-order responses contribute to second-order outcomes which themselves require a reflexive response. These structural mechanisms do not fully dictate outcomes as much as guiding or constraining the way users encounter or evade cultural variety, leaving space for person reflexivity to resist, personalise or unwittingly reproduce these boundaries.

It follows from this that communicative and fractured reflexives typically default to passivity in the face of the filter bubble and homophily within the curatorial bubble. They let algorithmic mediation dictate much of their online presence and gravitate towards like-minded peers (often people they already know) who reaffirm their existing positions. Autonomous reflexives, by contrast, more actively shape both the filter and curatorial bubbles, applying techniques to design an information environment that bounds variety in line with their established goals. Meanwhile, meta-reflexives also exert agency over these bubbles but centre on concerns rather than goals, prioritising the question of whether something is interesting over where it is useful.

Hence, we are left with three ideal typical orientations towards cultural variety: *avoiding*, *applying* and *exploring*. Consequently the sociotechnical environment will tend to stabilise communicative reflexivity through supporting the (active) reproduction of niches, does not alter the prevalence of autonomous reflexivity and amplifies meta-reflexivity by raising the odds practitioners of this mode will encounter and explore ever more cultural variety. Under contextual incongruity such exploration can itself spur further meta-reflexivity through the generative character of engaging with variety. The “rabbit hole” effects created by recommendation systems create a pressure towards commitment, if a user’s online behaviour accurately expresses a nascent commitment. There will come a point when they are being consistently served material which either reinforces an existing concern or provides the ideational ballast to give shape to a developing one.

Yet we might question the premise that bounding variety is strictly necessary. The metaphors which suffused the early popular reception of the internet certainly hinted at this possibility, preoccupied as they were with “surfing the net” or exploring the “information superhighway”. Could individuals drift endlessly within an infinite frontier of boundless variety? As Lupton (2014: 107) observes, the former metaphor has the connotation of “moving from

website to website easily and playfully, riding over the top of digital information and stopping when we feel like". Instead, we're now more likely to encounter talk of the "fire hose" of data, the "data deluge" or the "data tsunami" which threaten to "swamp" or "drown" us (Lupton 2014: 107).

Indeed while the pleasure of full immersion remain, a tense awareness of potential risks pervades (Noys 2014). It can be energising to remain immersed in the flow, caught within what Lacanians like Dean (2010) describe as the circuits of drive. Is it sustainable though? Is it possible to live like this in the longer term? In an earlier chapter I argued many manifestations of productivity culture should be seen as responses to the demands this new sociotechnical environment places upon personal reflexivity. Practices like the "information diet", "lifestyle minimalism", "life hacking" and "getting things done" seek to help individuals manage attention under intensifying demands. Each grapples with the hazards of distraction, though the nature of that distraction remains somewhat vague.

The political theorist Jodi Dean (2010) analyses what we might describe as a "stuckness" that proliferates online: we get "stuck doing the same thing over and over again because this doing produces enjoyment. Post. Post. Post. Click. Click. Click". The popular comedy Portlandia describe this as a "technology loop": the trap of frenzied overstimulation in which the cultural riches of online experience can leave one ensnared (Krisel 2011). Such portrayals capture the subjective sense of being caught in an online swirl, potentially explaining why "internet addiction" has grown in both everyday and professional discourse. Though not formally recognised by the American Psychiatric Association's Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, web addiction clinics have appeared in multiple countries, from the United States to China (Krotoski 2012: 40).

This surge in internet addiction clinics, underscored by clinicians' interests and a panic-laden public discourse, further cements the disorder's institutional status even if there are critical questions we should raise about it. Contemporary psychiatry separates substance addictions (chemical dependence) from impulse-control disorders (behavioural compulsions) raising the question of which category this claimed addiction should be seen to fall into (Boyd 2014: loc 1349). While some, like Carr (2011), argue that the internet "re-wires" our brains, the idea that "internet addiction" hinges on chemical dependence seems untenable, even if it's plausible that the neurophysiology of encountering novelty might play a significant role in these patterns of behaviour. Furthermore, given that diagnosing an addiction typically means pointing to points of interference with what would otherwise be an active life, the causal direction is left ambiguous: heavy internet use could be either symptom or cause.

Hence, I propose conceptualising "internet addiction" as a breakdown in second-order volition in Frankfurt's (1988) sense rather than an addiction per se. It's a sense of self-efficacy being foreclosed by compulsion, as nascent purposes are smashed into pieces by the repetitive cycles the platform seeks to

inculcate in its users. According to Frankfurt (1988: 19), a failure in second-order volition arises in two ways:

- 1 The *unwilling addict*, whose first-order desire conflicts with a second-order wish not to act on it, creating an internal struggle over conflicting motivations.
- 2 The *wanton*, who has no second-order evaluation of their impulses, thus remaining stuck in first-order desires with no reflective conflict.

The wanton cares little if craving or aversion wins out because these second-order reflections are precisely what their existential situation is failing to generate. This distinction clarifies the difference between someone feeling trapped in Dean's (2010) "Post. Post. Post. Click. Click. Click", yet *trying* to break free, versus someone drifting in a loop without caring or perhaps even noticing. In this sense, second-order reflection (or its absence) channels or obstructs an individual's capacity to alter habits in digital contexts.

Within "internet addiction" discourse the digital wanton looms: a zombie-like figure with diminishing functionality. Yet Boyd's (2014) ethnography depicts something more like "conflicted addicts", as with the case of Andrew who eventually quit Facebook having reached the conclusion that "This is stupid and it's having control of my life and I don't want anything to do with it" (Boyd 2014: 1279). She suggests that while "teens complain about how time drags when they must do things that they do not find enjoyable, time seems to slip away when in mediated environments with their peers" and that this experience, which can be "disorientating and a source of guilt", stands as the "root of anxiety about social media addiction" (Boyd 2014: 1312). Where "internet addiction" stands at the extreme of behaviour, its everyday counterpart is the distractedness we have explored in previous chapter. But as Gitlin (2007: 32) emphasises, "distraction" requires a target: what is it we're being drawn away from?

I argue that digital distraction and internet addiction each reflect a breakdown of second-order volition, arising from the cultural abundance distinctive of digital capitalism. The unease or guilt driving panic over "internet addiction" reveals a "stuckness" either in existing commitments or the formation of new ones: a digitally induced crisis of bounding and maintaining variety. Being "stuck in the stream" or "caught in technology loops" captures a growing sense of overwhelm: too many possibilities hinder meaningful action, whether one already has goals in place or still needs to shape them. By stressing the adverbial character of this shift, I've emphasised how the consequences accumulate over time (*psychobiography*) with implications for who we become (*personal morphogenesis*).

What would this look like in practice? In a popular article on the Guardian website, the journalist Sophie Heawood (2013) attached the label "everything-ist" to her experience of being unable to commit to courses of action, no matter how mundane, "unable to quite go with a plan or be in the moment because of all the other plans and moments where you might be, cheating on yourself with

all your other selves". Online commenters related intensely, or sought to reassure her with advice that revealed their own experience of this predicament. In these scenarios, the persistent knowledge of "something else I could be doing" disrupts sustained focus, fragmenting experience into fleeting episodes, without a coherent unity. This resonates with expressive and fractured reflexivity more broadly. Everythingists long for that unity but never quite arrive at it. Where Archer (2012: 105) sees every concern as a potential invitation to commit, everythingists face an endless onslaught of possibilities, none of which can be fixed upon for very long.

For Kenneth Gergen (1991: xviii) the problem here is the goal of unity. Describing his "struggle" against "my modernist training for constant improvement, development and accumulation" he claims there are substantial rewards "if one avoids looking back to locate a true and enduring self, and simply acts to fulfil potential in the moment at hand". Reflecting on this orientation Rosa (2013: 297) suggests "the absence of an integration of experiences into an identity-constituting whole can be affirmed as pleasurable and satisfying just insofar as it is possible to develop an ironic, playful relation to the uncontrollable vicissitudes of life". Yet Gergen's philosophy might be simpler for an internationally renowned, securely employed academic than for many others, whose material constraints limit spontaneity. Could he have got to his present position if he had followed this advice? We should acknowledge that it is not a purely passive approach. Gergen advocates fully immersing one in each moment rather than fretting over the past or the future. It means relating to the world from a position of agency, albeit one defined entirely by the horizon of the present situation. In contrast "everythingists" find themselves incapable of this sustained immersion, constantly vacillating among different possibilities. Gergen's approach could be taken as a therapeutic prescription for them: do one thing wholeheartedly, ignoring the infinite other things you might be missing.

Gergen and Rosa assume that the unity of a life has become unattainable, if it ever truly was. My preceding analysis suggests they underemphasise the cultural dimension of this dilemma: many people's trouble with commitment arises from confronting vast cultural variety, rather than the narrow "modernist training" invoked by Gergen. At the same time Gergen and Rosa may overstate the structural dimension: society is not wholly "liquid", contra Bauman (2000), so shaping one's life remains achievable, even if the dynamics governing that achievement are undergoing change. Unpredictability and instability complicate our rational calculations, but we can adapt by adjusting our plans and intensifying our reflexive tactics. Particularly if, as Archer (2012) suggests is true of meta-reflexive, we fall back on our values to guide our decision-making under conditions of uncertainty. This strategy is most successful if the *ends* we are working towards (e.g. a recognised professional role) remain stable, leaving only the *means* in flux (e.g. the shifting dynamics of building a career in a rapidly changing field). However this stability is exactly what is in question, raising the possibility that our values might be a useful navigational aid but not one

which can replace the normative compass which the detraditionalisation thesis argues has been lost with the onset of late modernity.

Another tactic is temporising: narrowing the timeframe of one's goal and displacing wider considerations into the future. For instance the Spotify CEO Daniel Ek sets five-year "missions" for "achiev[ing] something meaningful" while leaving enough flexibility to adapt (Seabrook 2014). By contrast Elon Musk's lofty ambitions (such as commercialising space flight, electrifying cars and establishing lunar colonies) and Mark Zuckerberg's quest to unite us like "cells in a single organism" dwarf such short-term horizons (Losse 2012: 201; Vance 2015). Beyond corporate settings, philanthropic capitalists channel wealth to reshape the world, sometimes countering ills they partly helped create. George Soros once likened himself to "a giant digestive tract, taking in money at one end and pushing it out at the other" (Wilson 2015). These *digital elites* illustrate that shaping a life seems quite feasible when near-limitless resources support one's aspirations. In fact we live in a world increasingly defined by the projects such elites undertake in order to shape their lives. For everyone else the challenge remains more unforgiving, underscoring how economic inequality and the platform dynamics we have discussed interact.

The conceptual distinctions we make are key for understanding how socialisation is changing under these conditions. While "essences" may be unfashionable in social theory, the philosophical question of kinds remains one which perpetually reoccurs no matter how we try and suppress it. Wright Mills (2000: 7) once asked the question "what varieties of men and women now prevail in this society and in this period?" His interest was in how they are "selected and formed, liberated and repressed, made sensitive and blunted" and what this meant for "what varieties are coming to prevail". In our rush to analyse new technologies we risk overestimating their impact, inadvertently replicating the marketing hype from commercial firms keen to stress their own significance. Therefore, there's a crucial role for careful ontological inquiry in exploring how kinds are cultivated or constrained by technology.

This care is exactly what is missing in invocations of new kinds of people supposedly being birthed by technological innovation. What might be called technologised essentialism (technology defines essence) goes hand-in-hand with the pair of dichotomies we explored in preceding chapters: **platform determinism/voluntarism** and **technological optimism/pessimism**. The empirical complexity of the developments we've explored in this book means it is difficult to recover these ontological questions. The rush to keep up with new developments too often gets in the way of understanding the common aspects underlying these transformations. When each technological innovation is treated as fundamentally novel, requiring fresh conceptual frameworks and methodologies, we lose sight of the persistent patterns in how humans engage with technology. The parallel mistake is to dissolve the change into the continuities, refusing to acknowledge there is something new and significant underway which might force the development of our categories.

The tendency in both cases is to treat technology as a homogeneous force acting uniformly on passive subjects, rather than recognising the variable ways in which reflexive agents incorporate digital platforms into their psychobiographies through ongoing cycles of personal morphogenesis. By attending to these processes of becoming, rather than positing essentialised subjects emerging from digital sociotechnical change, we can develop a more nuanced understanding that preserves both the reality of technological influence and the persistence of human agency. This is necessary if we are going to meet the real and growing challenge that personal reflexivity could be eviscerated through the algorithmic coordination of personal concerns and projects. The analytical task lies in recognising how easy it is to overestimate this power in the present-tense, presenting us as slaves to the algorithm, while being easy to underestimate it on the timescale of the life course, in which the parameters of our personal becoming risk precipitously narrowing into platformised frameworks without us ever being entirely aware of the shift.

What might seem like mundane issues of critical digital literacy, enabling people to exercise agency over their own use of devices and platforms, comes to take on a much broader significance through this lens. These seemingly personal issues connect both to the horizons of human flourishing for individual lives and to the macrosocial implications of this aggregate trend. In this text, I've tried to sketch out a framework through which we can understand this challenge conceptually, but there remains much more work to be done.

The Epochal Challenge of Sociotechnical Change

It is inherently difficult to write academic books about a field which is developing rapidly. Having written two books about social media and one about large language models, I was familiar with the challenge (Carrigan 2019, 2024; Carrigan and Fatsis 2021). In those cases, I devoted a year or two to each project, limiting how much change could unfold during the writing process. In contrast, I began this book with a part-time PhD in 2008, continuing through a postdoc (2014–2017) and completed it in the early 2020s. Rather than amplifying the challenge of keeping pace with technological developments, this extended timescale made it easier by removing the pressure to track the most recent empirical developments. Gillespie (2018: loc 866) observes that “It takes a while – years, decades – for a culture to adjust itself to the subtle workings of a new information system, and to stop expecting from it what traditional systems provided”. During this project's lifespan, from the iPhone's launch in 2007 to the emergence of LLMs in its final years, this information system has taken shape around us. The timescale helped me focus on the process itself rather than the particular outcomes which can so easily dominate our analytical attention.

An observation I heard Margaret Archer make on numerous occasions, without ever to my knowledge being incorporated into her written work, concerns the relationship between T2 and T3 in the morphogenetic sequence. This

framework distinguishes initial conditions (T1), a phase of interaction (T2–T3) and the outcome (T4) that reproduces or transforms those starting conditions. While often taken to imply retrospective analysis, perhaps reflecting her own sensibilities and interests as an historical sociologist, Archer was deeply sensitive to *incomplete* processes within the interaction phase. There is no a priori reason to assume we stand at the end of a cycle, even if this is a common epistemic temptation. That judgment can only be made through identifying whether starting conditions have been reproduced or elaborated. When studying ongoing phenomena, we are often situated within T2–T3 rather than after T4. It could not be otherwise because “at any time innumerable M/M cycles will be simultaneously underway throughout the social order” which means “there will constantly be second-order properties, emergent from ‘the results of the results’ of ... earlier cycles and their relational outcomes in different substantive areas” (Archer 2013: 10). The approach I’ve taken in this book suggests that we see sociotechnical change as an incomplete cycle with results which are continually feeding back into other M/M cycles. This is a process gestured towards, though I do not believe adequately grasped, within existing literature through notions such as Beer’s (2016) data coils and Morozov’s (2019) feedback loops.

The virtue of the detraditionalisation thesis lay in its insistence on a meta-process, a change which exceeds empirical trends which can be measured. It provides, as Lundby (2009: 141) puts it, “a meta approach that makes it possible to integrate very different results of surveys and qualitative investigations into an overall coherent understanding”. The problems with the detraditionalisation thesis arose from the grandiose poetics which left it captivated by its own pronouncements about epochal change. For this reason, I believe we ought to be as cautious as we can about declaring an outcome to sociotechnical change, without dispensing with the recognition there *will* be an outcome. If anything the vast investment in LLMs and the data infrastructure which supports them, intersecting with a post-pandemic political economy which appears to be leaving neoliberalism behind, heralds an intensification of change rather than a diminution (Tooze 2021; Varoufakis 2023). It’s possible this might be leading towards a perpetual polycrisis, a social order unable to stabilise itself amidst an accelerating climate catastrophe. But even this doom loop, suggested by Seymour’s notion of *disaster nationalism*, represents a social order of sorts, even if it’s an apocalyptic one.

It is difficult to incorporate this horizon of crisis into our frame of reference without subordinating our analysis of the interaction phase through which it is being generated. However, by approaching platformisation through the concepts of *psychobiography* and *personal morphogenesis*, I have argued that we can avoid both grandiose (and premature) pronouncements about a “digital age” and dismissive rejections of the reality of genuine change. The analysis I’ve offered of *distracted people* and *fragile movements* explores how platforms reconfigure rather than replace human agency. By examining how reflexivity operates within platformised contexts, tracing its biographical unfolding rather

than proclaiming wholesale transformation, we gain a more textured understanding of contemporary social life. This has meant breaking with an account of agency premised, as Savage (2021: 191) puts it, “on this ontological temporal difference between past, enduring structures, and a contemporary contingent agency that breaks from them”. Unless we can surrender this baggage, we are left with a meta-process defined through the falling away of the past, operationalising “tradition” as that which is experiencing a decline and thus squeezing out continuities through definitional fiat. The problem is not an epochal horizon, as much as ontological assumptions which lead to the epistemic mistakes of pronouncing epochal change in a grandiose and premature manner. A realist conception of the platform can acknowledge its emerging status as a condition of our social existence, while remaining clear that is we who must decide what to make of it.

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